

History of Ethiopia and the Horn (Hist.1012)

1.1. The Nature and Uses of History

A. Nature

- The **term history** is derived from the Greek word *historia* which meant “inquiry” or “an account of one's inquiries.” The **first use of the term** is attributed to one of the ancient Greek historians, **Herodotus** (c. 484–c. 420 B.C.E.), who is often held to be the “**father of written history**.”
- In ordinary usage, **history** means all the things that have happened in the human past.
- More specifically, the distinction is between what actually happened in the past or that part which exists independently of the historian and still awaits to be recorded and the accounts of the past provided by historians, **that is, „history“**.
- **Academically, history** can be defined as an organized and systematic study of the past. The study involves the discovery, collection, organization, and presentation of information about past events.
- **History** can also mean the period of time after the development of complex social and political organizations along with the invention of writing.
- Evidently, what actually happened in the past is almost infinite. Historians **select which topics and problems they wish to study**, as do scientists. In this regard, the major concern of history is the study of human society and its interaction with the natural environment which is also the subject of study by many other disciplines.
- ☞ What differentiates **history** from other disciplines is that while the latter study the interaction between humans and their environment in the present state, **history** studies the **interaction between the two in the past within the framework of the continuous process of change taking place in time**.
- ☞ Because of the longevity of that time, historians organize and divide the human past into discrete periods after identifying significant developments **in politics, society, economy, culture, environment** etc. through the rigorous study of documents and artifacts left by people of other times and other places. Then they give a label to each period to convey the key characteristics and developments of that era. Accordingly, history is conventionally divided into:-
 - **Ancient**,
 - **medieval** and
 - **modern history**. This is what we call **periodization in history**; one of the **key characteristics** of the discipline.
- **E. H. Carr** defined **history** as an “**unending dialogue between the present and the past**.” In short, the past does not exist now, but continues to live in present.
- **Until the early twentieth century** the study and teaching of history was limited to narrative presentation of “what happened” in the past. At the core of this narration had been political events relating to **the deeds of “great men” and “great women”**. As societies have become more complex, as the different areas of the world have become more closely interconnected, as new types of primary source and research methods are brought into use, so more rigorous accounts of the past have become more necessary.
 - Thus, history assumed three dimensions as its main job i.e. to
 - ✓ narrate what happened,
 - ✓ discuss how it happened and
 - ✓ analyze why it happened
- **Contemporary history teaching and research pursue** a more integrative approach offering students an expanded view of historical knowledge that includes aspects of
 - ✓ environment,
 - ✓ religion,

- ✓ gender,
- ✓ philosophy,
- ✓ economics,
- ✓ technology,
- ✓ art and society **instead of mere cataloguing of political events**

B. Uses of history

History:-

1/ Help us better understand the present

- ✓ History is the only significant storehouse of information available for the examination and analysis of how people behaved and acted in the past.
- ✓ People need to produce some sort of account of their past because **it is difficult to understand problems that face humanity and society today without tracing their origins in the past**. Put differently, knowledge of relevant historical background is essential for a balanced and in-depth understanding of many current world situations.

2/ Provides us a sense of our own identity

- ❖ Knowledge of history is **indispensable** to understand who we are and where we fit in the world.
 - ✓ As memory is to the individual, history is to the society. An individual without memory finds great difficulty in relating to others and in taking intelligent decisions.
 - ✓ A society without history would be in similar condition. It is only through sense of history that communities define their identity, orient them, and understand their relationships with the past and with other societies

3/ Provides the Basic Background for Many Other Disciplines

- Historical knowledge is extremely valuable in the pursuit of other disciplines such as literature, art, philosophy religion, **sociology, political science, anthropology and economics**. With regard to the last four, it is fair to argue that **history is a mother discipline** for they arose out of historical investigation or formed part of historical writing.

4/ The Careful Study of History Teaches One Many Critical Skills

- ✓ Studying history helps students to develop some critical skills relating to the how of doing research. These include but not limited to how to:-
 - ✚ find and evaluate sources;
 - ✚ make coherent arguments based on various kinds of evidence and present clearly in writing. These analytical and communication skills are highly usable in other academic pursuits. Gaining skills in sorting through diverse interpretations is also essential to make informed decisions in our day-to-day life.

5/ Can Help One Develop Tolerance and Open-Mindedness

- ✓ Most of us have a tendency to regard our own cultural practices, styles, and values as right and proper. Studying different societies in the past is like going to a foreign country, which contributes to rid ourselves of some of our inherent cultural provincialism.
- ✓ By studying the past, students of history acquire a broad perspective that gives them the range and flexibility required in many life situations.

6/ Can be Entertainment/supplies endless source of fascination

- ✓ Exploring the ways people in distant ages constructed their lives involves a sense of beauty and excitement, and ultimately another perspective on human life and society.

7/ Enable us understand the past and avoid or correct mistakes of the past done by our ancestors

8/ Help us understand the existence of different customs, laws and institutions

9/ Help us to have broad understanding about national and international issues, democratic principles and nationalism

10/ Can help foster promote national feeling

To conclude, history should be studied because:-

- it is essential to the individual and the society. we cannot escape from our past.
- only through studying history we can grasp how and why things change; and
- only through history we can understand what elements of a society persist despite change.
- **Aesthetic and humanistic goals** also inspire people to study the past, far removed from present-day utility.

Nevertheless just as history can be useful, it **can also be abused**. Such abuses come mainly from deliberate manipulation of the past to fit current political agenda. In such cases, history is written backwards. That is the past is described and interpreted to justify the present. While personal biases are not always avoidable, a historian is different from a propagandist in that the former takes care to document his judgment and assertions so that they can be subjected to independent and external verification.

1.2. Sources and Methods of Historical Study

- ✓ Historians are not creative writers like novelists; the work of historian must be supported by evidence arising from sources. Sources are instruments that bring to life what appear to have been dead. Where there are no sources there is no history. **Sources** are, therefore, **key to the study and writing of history**.
- ✓ Historical sources are broadly classified into two types: **Primary and Secondary**.
- ⌚ **Primary sources are:-**
 - original or first hand in their proximity to the event both in time and space
 - surviving traces of the past available to us in the present
 - **Examples**:- manuscripts (handwritten materials), diaries, letters, minutes, court and administrative files, travel documents, photographs, maps, video and audiovisual materials, and physical remains or relics such as coins, fossils, weapons, utensils, and buildings, oral tradition (by eye witness)
- ⌚ **Secondary sources are:-**
 - second-hand published accounts about events that happened in the past.
 - often use primary sources, but are written long after the event has occurred, providing an interpretation of what happened, why it happened, and how it happened
 - give us what appear to be finished accounts of certain historical periods and phenomena
 - **Examples**:- articles, books, textbooks, biographies, and published stories or movies about historical events, oral tradition (a retold eye witness account)
- What we have to know is that as new sources keep coming to light, no history work can be taken as final. New sources make possible new historical interpretations or entirely new historical reconstructions.
- **Oral sources** are also indispensable to study and document the history of non-literate societies. In many societies, oral information can pass from one generation to another without being recorded. This type of oral data is called **oral tradition**. For the history of Ethiopia and the Horn, historians use a combination of the sources described above. However, whatever the source of information- primary or secondary, written or oral- the data should be **subjected to critical evaluation before used as evidence**. For instance:-
 - **Primary sources** have to be verified for their **originality** and **authenticity** because sometimes, primary sources like **letters** may be forged.
 - **Secondary sources** have to be examined for the **reliability** of their reconstructions.
 - **An oral tradition** may lose its originality and authenticity due to omission, exaggeration and distortion through time. Therefore, it should be crosschecked with other sources such as written documents to determine its veracity.

- ✚ In short, historians (unlike novelists) must find evidence about the past, ask questions of that evidence, and come up with explanations that make sense of what the evidence says about the people, events, places and time periods they study.

1.3. Historiography of Ethiopia and the Horn

➤ **Historiography** is:-

- ✓ The history of historical writing. In short, it means the history of history.
- ✓ The history of historical accounts, studying how knowledge of the past, either recent or distant, is obtained and transmitted.
- ✓ People have had some sense of the past perhaps since the beginning of humanity. **Yet historiography** as an intentional attempt to know and represent descriptions of past events in writing has rather a briefer career throughout the world.
- ✓ The organized study and narration of the past was introduced by the **Greeks Herodotus also called “Father of written History”** (c. 484–c. 420 B.C.) and **Thucydides** (d. c. 401 B.C.).
- ✓ The other major tradition of thinking and writing about the past is the **Chinese**. The most important early figure in Chinese historical thought and writing was the Han dynasty figure **Sima Qian** (145–86 B.C.).
- ✓ **History emerged as an academic discipline** in the **second half of the nineteenth century first in Europe and subsequently in other parts of the world notably in the US**.
 - ✚ The **German** historian, **Leopold Von Ranke** (1795–1886), and his colleagues **established history as an independent discipline in Bonn** with its own set of methods and concepts by which historians collect evidence of past events, evaluate that evidence, and present a meaningful discussion of the subject.
 - ✚ **Ranke’s** greatest contribution to the **scientific study of the past** is such that he is considered as the **“father of modern historiography”**.

➤ **Historiography of Ethiopia and the Horn** has changed enormously during the past hundred years in ways that merit fuller treatment than can be afforded here. In order to appreciate twentieth-century historiography of the region, it is first necessary to examine earlier forms of historiography (historical writing).

☞ The earliest known reference that we have on history of Ethiopia and the Horn is

- The ***Periplus of the Erythrean Sea (The Voyage of the Indian Ocean)***,
- ✓ Written in the **first century A.D** by an anonymous author.
- ✓ It is a manual document or handbook **used by merchants** who frequently come to the Red Sea, the Gulf of Aden and Indian Ocean.
- ✓ Gives a detailed account of **the Aksumite state and the ports** on the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden coasts. According to this document, **Adulis** was the port of the city of Aksum. It also states that the king of Aksum was called **Zoscales**, and could communicate with Greek.
 - Another document describing **Aksum’s trade and the then Aksumite king’s campaigns** on both sides of the sea is **the Christian Topography**. This document is:-
- ✓ composed by **Cosmas Indicopleustes**, a Greek sailor, in the **sixth century A.D**
- ✓ It also stated about the Aksumite merchants that visited lands to the south of Abbay to buy gold for the ruling class.
- ⌚ Unfortunately, contemporary Ethiopian materials are non-existent to **substantiate** the information from the above sources despite the country’s reputation for an ancient civilization of literacy.

☞ **Inscriptions aside**, the earliest **written Ethiopian material** dates from **the seventh century A.D**. The document was found in **Abba Gerima monastery** in **Yeha**.

☞ The discovery of **inscriptions** that dates the **7th c AD** was followed by **a manuscript** discovered in **Haiq Istifanos monastery** of present day **Wollo** in **the thirteenth century A.D** (medieval time). The value of manuscripts:-

- ✚ Is essentially religious.
 - ✚ have the added value of providing insights into the country's past. For example, the manuscript cited above **contains the list of medieval kings and their history in brief.**
 - ☞ The largest groups of sources available for medieval Ethiopian history are **hagiographies**.
Hagiographies:-
 - ✓ Originating from Ethiopian Orthodox Church.
 - ✓ Invariably written in Ge'ez
 - ✓ Their important function is enhancing the prestige of saints
 - ✓ Yet other related anecdotes are also introduced, and often discussed in detail such as the development of the church and the state including territorial conquests by reigning monarchs.
 - ❖ A parallel **hagiographical tradition** also existed within **the Muslim communities of the country**.
 - ✓ One such account offers tremendous insight into the life of a **Muslim saint, Shaykh Ja'far Bukko of Gattira, in present day Wallo, in the late nineteenth century.**
 - ✓ Besides the life of the Saint, this account discussed about:-
 - ✚ the development of indigenous Islam and
 - ✚ contacts between the region's Muslim community and the outside world
 - ☞ Ethiopia had also an indigenous tradition of history writing called **chronicles**.
 - ✓ Chronicles in the ancient Ethiopian Ge'ez tongue **first appeared in the 14th century and continue (sometimes in Amharic) into the early twentieth.**
 - ✓ **Kings or their successors** entrusted the writing of chronicles to court scribes or clergymen of recognized clerical training and calligraphic skills.
 - ✓ The **first and the last** of such documents are the ***Glorious Victories of Amde-Tsion*** and the ***Chronicle of Abeto Iyasu and Empress Zewditu*** respectively.
 - ✓ **Chronicles** incorporate both legends and facts past and contemporary about **the monarch's genealogy, upbringing, military exploits, piety and statesmanship.**
 - ✓ Chronicles are known for their factual detail and strong chronological framework, even if it would require considerable labour to convert their relative chronology to an absolute one.
 - ✓ Chronicles are also averse to quantification.
 - ✓ Major events in and around the imperial residence are explained mainly in religious terms; **the chronicle**, therefore offers very little by way of **social and economic** developments even in the environs of the palace.
- ⌚ However in conjunction with other varieties of written documents such as **hagiographies and travel accounts by foreign observers**, **chronicles** can provide us with a glimpse into *the character and lives of kings their preoccupations and relations with subordinate officials and though inadequately the evolution of the Ethiopian state and society.*
- ☞ Written accounts of **Arabic-speaking visitors** to the coast also provide useful information on various aspects of the region's history. For example:-
 - ✓ **al-Masudi and Ibn Battuta** described the **culture, language and import-export trade in the main central region of the east African coast** in the **tenth** and in the **fourteenth centuries respectively.**
 - For the **sixteenth and seventeenth centuries**, we have two documents composed by **Yemeni writers** who were eyewitnesses to the events they described. These were:-
 - 1/ ***Futuh al Habesha (The Conquest of Abyssinia)*** was **composed by Shihab al-Din**, who recorded the conflict between the Christian kingdom and the Muslim principalities in the **sixteenth century**. This document also describes:-
 - ✚ the operation of the war including **the conquest of northern and central Ethiopia by Imam Ahmad ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi**



major towns and their inhabitants in the southeastern part of Ethiopia, although the discussion abruptly ends in 1535.

2/ The other first-hand account is left to us by **Al-Haymi**, who led a **Yemeni delegation in 1647** to the court of **Fasiledes (r. 1632-67)**.

- Other materials that appeared in the **sixteenth century** include **Aba Bahrey's Amharic script the History of the [Oromo]**.

- ✓ The document was written in the **1593**.

- ✓ Notwithstanding its limitations, this document provides firsthand information about the **Oromo population movement** in the stated period

- ☞ **The contribution of missionaries and travellers** to the development of Ethiopian historiography is also significant.

- **Mission sources**

- ✓ From the **early sixteenth** until the **later nineteenth** centuries, European **missionaries (Catholics and Protestants)** came to the country with the intention of staying, and who, nevertheless, maintained intimate links with Europe.

- ✓ Some of the major topics covered by these missionary sources include **religious and political developments within Ethiopia**, and **the country's foreign relations**. An example of such account is:-

- ***The Prester John of the Indies*, composed by a Portuguese priest, Francisco Alvarez, who led the Portuguese mission to the court of Lebne-Dengel in 1520.**

- **Travel documents**

- ✓ One example of travel documents is **James Bruce's *Travels to Discover the Source of the Nile***.

☞ Like other sources however both **mission and travel materials** can only be used with considerable reservations and with care for they are socially and politically biased.

- **Foreigners** also developed interest in Ethiopian studies.

- One of these figures was a **German, Hiob Ludolf (1.1624-1704)**.

Ludolf:-

- ✓ was the **founder of Ethiopian studies in Europe in the seventeenth century**.

- ✓ Was who wrote ***Historica Aethiopica*** (translated into English as ***A New History of Ethiopia***).

- ✓ **never visited Ethiopia**; he wrote the country's history based on information he collected from an Ethiopian priest named **Abba Gorgorios (Aba Gregory)** who was in Europe at that time.

- **The other foreigner was August Dillman**

- ✓ In the 19th century he **published two studies on ancient Ethiopian history**

⌚ Compared to **Ludolf**, **Dillman** demonstrated all markers of objectivity in his historical research endeavors.

- ☞ **Historical writing made some departures from the chronicle tradition** in the **early twentieth century**. This period saw the **emergence of traditional Ethiopian writers** who made conscious efforts to **distance themselves from chroniclers** whom they criticized for **adulatory tone** when writing about monarchs.

- ✓ The earliest group of these **traditional writers** include:-

- **Aleqa Taye Gebre-Mariam**,

- **Aleqa Asme Giorgis** and

- **Onesmus Nasib (Aba Gemechis)**.

- Later, **Negadrases Afework Gebre-Iyesus** and **Gebre-Hiwot Baykedagn** joined the above three writers.

- ✓ Unlike chroniclers, these writers dealt with a range of topics from **social justice**, **administrative reform** and **economic analysis to history**. For instance:-

- ✚ Taye wrote *Yeityopia Hizb Tarik (The History of Ethiopian People)*
- ✚ Asme wrote *Ye [Oromo] Tarik (The History of the Oromo)*
- ✚ Onesmus translated the Bible into his native tongue, *Afan Oromo*.
- ✚ Afework wrote the first Amharic novel, *Tobiya*, in Ethiopian history
- ✚ Gebre-Hiwot has *Atse Menilekna Ityopia (Emperor Menilek and Ethiopia)* and *Mengistna Yehizb Astedader (Government and Public Administration)* to his name

- The **most prolific writer of the early twentieth century** Ethiopia was, however, **Blatten Geta Hiruy Wolde-Selassie**.

- ✚ Hiruy published four major works. Namely: *Ethiopiana Metema (Ethiopia and Metema)*, *Wazema (Eve)*, *Yehiwot Tarik (A Biographical Dictionary)* and *Yeityopia Tarik (The History of Ethiopia)*.

☞ In contrast to their predecessors, **Gebre Hiwot and Hiruy** exhibited relative objectivity and methodological sophistication in their works.

- ⌚ Unfortunately, the **Italian occupation** of Ethiopia interrupted the early experiment in modern history writing and publications. **After liberation:-**

- ✚ **Tekle-Tsadik Mekuria:**

- formed a bridge between writers in pre-1935 and Ethiopia professional historians who came after him.
- has published some eight historical works.
- made better evaluation of his sources than his predecessors.
- Yet like his precursors, bias permeates most of his works.

- ✚ **Yilma Deressa:**

- Wrote *Ye Ityopiya Tarik Be'asra Sidistegnaw Kifle Zemen (A History of Ethiopia in the Sixteenth Century)*. This book addresses:-
 - ✓ **the Oromo population movement** and
 - ✓ **the wars between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim principalities** as its main subjects.

☞ **Tekle Tsadik** and **Yilma's** works are **written in Amharic** and therefore can be **used by the wider public and scholars alike**

- ✚ **Blatten Geta Mahteme-Selassie Wolde-Meskel** also contributed his share. Among others,

- He wrote *Zikre Neger (Things Remembered)*.

- ✓ *Zikre Neger* is a comprehensive account of Ethiopia's **prewar land tenure systems and taxation**, but fails to capture localized circumstances, responses, and conflicts and silent on the actual impacts of government legislation on regulating access to resource control.

- ✚ Another **work dealing specifically with aspects of land tenure** is left to us by **Gebre-Wold Engidawork** and has been translated into English.

- ✚ Another writer of the same category was **Dejazmach Kebede Tesema**.

- He wrote his memoir of the imperial period, published with as ***Yetarik Mastawesha in 1962 E.C.***

- ☞ **The 1960s** was a crucial decade in the development of Ethiopian historiography for it was in this period that **history emerged as an academic discipline**. In this period:

- ✓ The pursuit of historical studies as a full-time occupation began with the opening of the Department of History at the then Haile Selassie I University (HSIU) in **1963**.
- ✓ Institute of Ethiopian Studies (IES) was established at Haile Sellasie I University College (1963). Its founding member and first director the late **Richard Pankhurst**. He has

authored or co-authored twenty-two books and produced several hundred articles on Ethiopia.

- ✓ IES has been publishing the *Journal of Ethiopian Studies* for the dissemination of historical research.
- ✓ **IES has its own library that:**
 - contains literary works of diverse disciplines
 - has its fair share in the evolution and development of professional historiography in Ethiopia.

☞ The production of **BA theses** began towards the end of the decade.

- The Department of History launched its **MA and PhD programs** in **1979** and **1990 respectively**.
 - ✓ Since then, researches by faculty (**both Ethiopians and expatriates**) and students have been produced on various topics.
 - ✓ Although entirely a research organization, the Institute of Ethiopian Studies (IES) is the other institutional home of professional historiography in Ethiopia.

➤ The **professionalization of history in other parts of the Horn** is a **post-colonial phenomenon**

- ✓ With the establishment of independent nations, a deeper interest in exploring their own past quickly emerged among African populations, perhaps stimulated by reactions to decades of education in an alien imperial historiography. With this came an urgent need to recast the historical record and to recover evidence of many lost pre-colonial civilizations.
- ✓ The **decolonization of African historiography** required new methodological approach (tools of investigation) to the study of the past that involved:-
 - **a critical use of oral data** and
 - tapping the percepts of **ancillary disciplines** like **archeology, anthropology** and **linguistics**.
- ✓ At the same time, European intellectuals' own discomfort with the **Euro-centrism** of previous scholarship provided for the intensive **academic study of African history**, an innovation that had spread to **North America by the 1960s**.
- ✓ Foundational research was done at the **School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS)** in London and the **Department of History** at the University of Wisconsin-Madison.
- ✓ **Francophone scholars** have been as influential as **Anglophones**.
- ✓ Yet African historiography has not been the sole creation of interested Europeans. African universities have, despite the instabilities of politics and civil war in many areas, trained their own scholars and sent many others overseas for training who eventually published numerous works on different aspects of the region's history.

1.4. The Geographical Context of Human History in Ethiopia and the Horn

- The term **"Ethiopia and the Horn"** refers to that **part of Northeast Africa** which now contains the countries of **Djibouti, Eritrea, Ethiopia** and **Somalia**. The region:-
 - ✓ consists chiefly of mountains uplifted through the formation of the Great Rift Valley. (*The Rift Valley is a fissure in the Earth's crust running down from Syria to Mozambique and marking the separation of the African and Arabian tectonic plates*).
 - ✓ has a massive highland complex of mountains and plateaus divided by the Great Rift Valley and surrounded by lowlands, semi-desert, deserts and tropical forests along the periphery. (physiographic features)
 - ✓ has variety of **climate, natural vegetation, soil composition**, and **settlement patterns**.
 - ✓ As with the physical features, people across the region are remarkably diverse. They:
 - speak a vast number of different languages
 - profess to many distinct religions
 - live in a variety types of dwellings, and

- engage in a wide range of economic activities.
 - However, peoples of the region were never isolated; they interacted throughout history from a diversity of locations. This interaction enable them to share common past.
- The history of Ethiopia and the Horn has been shaped by **contacts with others through commerce, migrations, wars, slavery, colonialism, and the waxing and waning of state systems**. Yet the evolution of human history owed much to geographical factors notably:
- location,
 - landforms,
 - resource endowment,
 - climate and drainage systems which continue to impact, as incentives and deterrents,
 - the movement of people and goods in the region

The impact of the region's geography on the way people live and organize themselves into societies

- ❖ **Spatial location in relationship to other spaces and locations** in the world is one geographical factor that has significant bearing on the ways in which history unfolds. **Ethiopia and the Horn** lies between the **Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Indian Ocean** on the one hand, and the present-day eastern frontiers of Sudan and Kenya on the other. Thus, since early times,
 - The **Red Sea** and the **Gulf of Aden** linked Northeast Africa to the Eastern Mediterranean, the Near and Middle East, India, and the Far East
 - The **Indian Ocean** has linked East Africa to the Near and Middle East, India and the Far East.
- ❖ Another element of geography that had profound impact on human history is **drainage system**.
 - Ethiopia and the Horn has five principal drainage systems. These are
 - 1/ the Nile River System
 - 2/ the Gibe/Omo–Gojeb River System
 - 3/ the Genale/Jubba-Shebele River System
 - 4/ the Awash River System and
 - 5/ the Ethiopian Rift Valley Lakes System
 - ✓ **Flowing from Uganda** in the south to the Sudan in the north, the **White Nile meets the Blue Nile** (Abay in Ethiopia that starts from the environs of Tana Lake) in Khartoum and eventually, drains into the Mediterranean Sea through Egypt.
 - ✓ The **Awash River System** is an **entirely Ethiopian system** and links the cool rich highlands of Central Ethiopia with the hot, dry lowlands of the Danakil Depression
 - ✓ The **Ethiopian Rift Valley Lakes System** is a self-contained drainage basin, and includes a string of lakes stretching from **Lake Ziway** in the north to **Lake Turkana** (formerly known as Rudolf) on the Ethio-Kenyan border.
 - ✓ The **Gibe/Omo–Gojeb River System** links southern Ethiopia to the semi-desert lowlands of northern Kenya.
 - ✓ The **Shebele** and Genale rivers originate in the Eastern highlands and flow southeast toward Somalia and the Indian Ocean. Only the Genale (known as the Jubba in Somalia) makes it to the Indian Ocean; **the Shebele disappears in sand just inside the coastline.**
 - ⌚ The above watersheds are very important in the life and history of the peoples inhabiting the region. Besides providing people with the source of their livelihood, the drainage systems facilitated the movement of peoples and goods across diverse environments, resulting the exchange of ideas, technology, knowledge, cultural expressions and beliefs.
 - ⌚ Studying the drainage systems of Ethiopia and the Horn is crucial for proper understanding of the relationships of the peoples living within the river basins mentioned previously.
- ☞ Ethiopia and the Horn can be divided into three major distinct environmental zones.

1/ The vast Eastern lowland

- ✓ Covers the narrow coastal strip of northeastern Eritrea, widens gradually and descends southwards to include much of lowland Eritrea, the Sahel, the Danakil Desert, the lower Awash valley, and the arid terrain in northeast of the Republic of Djibouti. It then extends to the Ogaden, the lower parts of Hararghe, Bale, Borana, Sidamo and the whole territory of the Republic of Somalia.
- ✓ There is not much seasonal variation in climatic condition of this zone. Hot and dry conditions prevail year-round along with periodic monsoon winds and irregular (little) rainfall except in limited areas along the rivers Awash, Wabe Shebele and Genale/Jubba which traverse the region and a few off-shore islands (eg. Dahlak, Socotra) in the Red Sea, Aden Gulf and Indian Ocean which are inhabited by people closely related to those of immediate mainland districts.
- ✓ Much of the lowland territory is covered only by shrub and bush as its major vegetation.

2/ Highland massif

- ✓ Locate immediately to the west of and opposite to the eastern lowland
- ✓ Starts from northern Eritrea and continues all the way to southern Ethiopia.
- ✓ The eastern extension of the highland massif consists the Arssi, Bale and Hararghe plateau.
- ✓ The major divide between the western and eastern parts of this zone is the Rift Valley.
- ✓ The major physiographic features of the zone are complex of mountains, deep valleys, and extensive plateaus.
- ✓ It is generally said that rainfall has declined in Ethiopia and the Horn since the 1960s causing drought and famine, such as the well-known Ethiopian famines of 1970s and 1980s.

3/ Western hot lowlands

- ✓ **Found** along the western foothills or on the periphery of the plateau and on borderlands of the Sudan, stretching from north to south.
- ✓ in earlier times this region characterized by thick forests chiefly on the banks of the Nile and its tributaries.
 - ❖ Despite the varied physical environments discussed above, the countries of the Horn of Africa are, for the most part, linguistically and ethnically linked together as far back as recorded history goes.
 - ❖ **Population movements** had caused a continuous process of interaction, creating a very complex picture of settlement patterns. This is the case, for example, in Ethiopia where a number of Cushitic groups live surrounding as well as interspersed among more or less semitized population in the northern and central highlands of the country.
 - ❖ The **high degree of interaction, the long common history of much of the population and their adherence to Christianity or Islam, had weakened ethnic dividing lines in large parts of the region. Linguistic and cultural affinities** are therefore as important as ethnic origin in the grouping of the population.

Unit two

Peoples and Cultures in Ethiopia and the Horn

2.1. Human Evolution

- Regarding the origin of human being, there are two divergent views. These are:
 - 1/ **The creationist view** that contends super natural force or God created non-living and living things including human being with complete physical shape and structure.
 - 2/ **The evolutionist view** which argues that living things and nonliving things developed from small beings through gradual changes of many million years.
- ✓ The **earliest evolution theorist Charles Darwin (1809- 1882)** published **Theory of Evolution or Origin of Species by Natural Selection (1859)** and **Descent of Man (1871)**.
- ✓ According to evolutionists,

- human evolution accounts only fraction of history of the globe that had been formed through natural process about 4.5 billion years ago or before present (B. P.)
- The earliest known life came in to being between 3 & 1 billion years B.P. Accordingly:
 - ✚ **Blue green algae, small plants, fishes, birds and other small animals (mainly invertebrates) emerged at about/circa (c.) 800 million years B. P.**
 - ✚ In due course, **first primates** branched out of **Tarsiers** and **main placental mammal stream** as of **200-170 million years B. P.**
 - ✚ Then, **some primates** developed into **Pongidae** such as **baboons, monkeys, gorilla, chimpanzee, orangutan, gibbon** etc while others evolved in to **Hominidae (human ancestors)**.

➤ Archaeological evidences suggest that:-

- ✓ Human beings and apes share common ancestors.
- ✓ East African Rift Valley is a **cradle of humanity**.

☞ Evidences related to both **biological and cultural evolution** have been discovered in the Lower Omo and Middle Awash River valleys both by Ethiopian and foreign scholars. Such as:

- ✚ A fossil named as **Cororapithecus** dated **10 million B. P.** was discovered in **Ancar (in Hararghe)** in 2007.
- ✚ A fossil called **Ardipithicus Ramidus kadabba** (dated **5.8-5.2 million B.P.**) was discovered in Middle Awash.
- ✚ *Ardipithicus ramidus* (dated **4.2 million B.P.**) was discovered by **Tim D. White** at **Aramis** in Afar in 1994.
- ✚ Other **Australopithecines** were also discovered at **Belohdelie** (dated back **3.6 million years B.P.**), in Middle Awash.
- ✚ Fossilized animal bones (**3.4 million years**) were found with stone-tool-inflicted marks on them (the oldest evidence of stone tool use ever found in the world) by international team led by **Shannon McPherron** in **Lower Awash Valley** in 2010.
- ✚ A three years old child's fossil termed as **Australopithecus afarensis, Selam**, dated to **3.3 million years B.P** was also discovered at Dikika, Mille, Afar in 2000.
- ✚ Another **Australopithecus afarnesis (Lucy/Dinkinesh)**, dated c. **3.18 million years B. P.** with **40% complete body parts**, weight 30kg, height 1.07 meters and pelvis looks like bipedal female was discovered by Donald Carl Johnson at **Hadar** in Afar in 1974 A. D.
- ✚ Fossil named as **Australopithecus Anamensis** was discovered around **Lake Turkana**.
- ✚ **Ethiopian Anthropologist Berhane Asfaw** and his team discovered an **eco-fact** named as **Australopithecus Garhi (means surprise in Afar language)** dated **2.5 million years B.P** was discovered at Bouri, Middle Awash, between 1996 and 1999.
- ✚ Other species like **Australopithecus Bosei, Australopithecus Aethiopicus** and **Pithecan** were also discovered in different areas of East Africa
- ✚ **Dr. Richard Luis Leaky and Mary Leaky** found **proto-human fossil** named as **Zinjanthropus** in **1959**.

Genus Homo

- The **development of the human brain** was to be the main feature of the next stage of human evolution, which produced the **genus Homo**, believed to have emerged **2-2.5 million years B.P.**
- Three species belong to genus Homo. These are:

1/ Homo Habilis:

- ✓ is derived from Latin terms **Homo** which meant **human being** and Habilis meant **skillful or handy**.
- ✓ Its partial skull was discovered in lower Omo dated 1.9 million years B.P.
- ✓ Its brain size is 650- 800 C.C.

2/ Homo Erectus:

- ✓ Also known as **upright walking human being**
- ✓ Its fossil dated 1.6 million B.P was discovered at Melka Kunture, Konso Gardula and Gadeb with 185 cm tall, 68kg weight, 5-6 inches height and 900-1100 cc brain size.
- ✓ *Homo erectus* seems to have originated in Africa and then spread out to the rest of the world.

3/ Homo-Sapiens (wise human being)

A/ Skeleton of **Archaic Homo-Sapiens/Knowledgeable human being/** (dated 400,000 years B.P.), named **Bodo** with brain size of 1300-1400cc was discovered in Middle Awash.

B/ Homo Sapiens Sapiens

- ✓ **Its fossils dated** 100, 000 years B.P, were discovered at **Porc Epic** near **Dire Dawa** and **Kibish** around **Lower Omo** (by Leakey in 1967).
 - **Kibish** fossils were re-dated in **2004** to **195, 000 years old**, the oldest date anywhere in world for modern Homo Sapiens.
 - **Homo sapiens idaltu**, found in **Middle Awash** in **1997**, lived about **160, 000 years ago.**
- **Cultural evolution** is related to technological changes that brought socio-economic transformation on human life. It can be conventionally grouped in to:-
 - **Stone** Age,
 - **Bronze** Age and
 - **Iron** Age.

- **Stone tools** had been **the first technologies to be developed** by human beings. By taking their features, ways and period of production, stone tools can be grouped in to three:-

A/ **Mode I (Olduwan**, which was named based on the first report made at **Olduvai Gorge, Tanzania**). The mode I stone tools are mainly Characterized by:-

- ✓ crude and mono-facial styles, and
- ✓ the direct percussion production.

B/ **Mode II (Acheulean**, named after the first report at **St. Acheul, France**).

Mode II stone tools were produced by:-

- ✓ indirect percussion, by using hand-ax or hammer, and
- ✓ bifacial, pointed and convex features.

C/ **Mode III (Sangoon)**. Mode III stone tools are characterized by:

- ✓ flexible and finest form of production by the use of obsidian

☞ Examples of the above types of stone tools have been found in Ethiopia and the Horn.

- **Fossilized animal bones** (3. 4 million years B. P.) were found with **stone-tool-inflicted marks on them** (the oldest evidence of stone tool in the world) at **Dikika** in 2010.
- Artifact findings suggest that the 1st stone tools (**Olduwan tools**) **made and used by Homo habilis** were discovered near **Gona** (dated 2.52 million years B.P. in 1992) and at **Shungura** in Afar.
- **Homo erectus** produced **Acheulean tools** dated back to 1.7.million years B.P, probably the first to invent fire around 1.5 million years ago and started burial practice. Dutch hydrologist **Gerrard Dekker** found Acheulian tools (over a million years old) at **Kella**, Middle Awash in 1963.
- **Homosapiens** produced **Sangoon tools** that trace back up to 300,000 years B. P. **Gademotta site** in central Ethiopian Rift Valley has been dated back to 200, 000 B. P. Other vital sites such as **Gorgora**, **Ki'one** and **Yabello** in Ethiopia and **Midhidhishi** and **Gudgud** in **Somalia** have offered noteworthy information about Stone Age communities.

The Stone Age

- The period of the usage of **lithus/ stone tools** is divided into sub-periods. They are:

1/ Paleolithic (Old Stone Age)

- ✓ **Was a period from 3.4 million to 11, 000 years B.P.**
- ✓ was the period when human being **developed language with shelter in cave using stone, bone, wood, furs & skin materials to prepare food and clothing.**
- ✓ There was sex-age labor division with able-bodied **males** as hunters of fauna, and **children and females** as gatherers of flora.
- ✓ In due course, society developed from matriarchal to patriarchal hierarchy.
 - **Gademotta** Stone Age site in central Ethiopian Rift Valley is one of the oldest sites in African continent and has been dated back to 200,000 B.P.
 - Other sites such as **Gorgora, Ki'one, Tiyya, Tuto Fala & Yabaldho** in Ethiopia and **Midhishish & Gudgud** in Somalia are important sites that have offered noteworthy information about Stone Age communities in the Horn of Africa.

2/ Mesolithic/ middle Stone Age

- ✓ Dated/lasted from 11, 000-10,000 B.P.
- ✓ was a transition period between Old and Neolithic/New Stone Ages(10.000-6000 B.P).

3/ Neolithic/ New Stone Age

- ✓ Lasted from 10,000 – 6000 B.P
- ✓ was a time when human being used micro-lithic tools.

2.2. The Neolithic Revolution

- ❖ It was during Neolithic period:-
 - ✓ human beings began to transform from **mobile way of life to sedentary**. This was a radical shift involving changes from hunting and gathering to the domestication of plants and animals.
 - ✓ Climatic change and increased hunter-gatherers' population resulted in the declining number of animals and availability of plants.
 - As food gatherers were already aware of growing cycle of most of grass types, they began to thickly grow those, which were most common and yielded seeds that are more edible.
 - The big animals, which depended on dense bushes for sustenance, were reduced by hunting and animals that people were able to domesticate easily were smaller ones.
 - People descend from mountain sides to build houses near cultivated plots fencing both and harvested crops had to be stored & protected from humidity & rodents
 - For better security and to help each other in hard works, families preferred to live together forming larger communities
 - Using stick or hoe for planting was also gradually replaced by ox-drawn plough
 - Farmers acquired surplus produce to exchange with better tools and clothes with the craftsmen who were able to concentrate on and specialize in the production of these items.
 - The process of domestication took place independently in the various parts of the world. In Ethiopia and the Horn chiefly in the more elevated and wetter-parts, people cultivated plants including
 - *Teff (Eragrotis teff)*,
 - *dagussa (Eleusine coracana)*,
 - *nug (Guzotia abyssinica)*,
 - *enset (Ensete ventricosum)* etc.
- ☞ The domestication of *enset* plant (*Ensete edule*) reduced shifting cultivation (continuous clearing of new plots), slowing down soil exhaustion.
 - **Enset** was widely cultivated over central and northern Ethiopia until increasing demands of states which had to support many units of professional soldiers forced farmers to cultivate cereals like **teff** only.
- ☞ The discovery of **polished axes, ceramics, grinding stones, beads, stone figures and animal** remains in sites like **Emba-Fakeda** around **Adigrat** in Tigray as well as Aqordat and Barentu in Eritrea evinces/expresses the existence of Neolithic material culture. Accordingly:-

- The **Gobodara rock shelter** near Aksum has provided us **agricultural stone tools**.
- Stone tools used for cutting grass and grass like plants as well as rock paintings of domesticated animals have been found at **Laga Oda rock shelter near Charchar**.

☞ Archaeologist, Dombrowski, excavated remains associated with **domesticated cattle, chickpeas and vegetables** from **Lalibela Cave** on the southeastern shore of Lake Tana. Evidence for domesticated **cattle** also comes from around Lake Basaqa near Matahara. **Playa Napata and Kado** in the Sudan, **Cyrenaica** in Libya and **Futajalon** in West Africa were among known places of domestication of animals like **Nidamawa and Zebu (*Bos indicus*) cattle** that in due course expanded to Ethiopia and the Horn.

2.3. The Peopling of the Region

2.3.1. Languages and Linguistic Processes

- ☞ Ethiopia and the Horn in general is marked by ethnic and linguistic diversity. There are **about 90 languages** with **200 dialects** in Ethiopia and the Horn. Beneath this apparent diversity, there is some degree of unity.
- ☞ Linguists classify languages of Ethiopia and the Horn into two major language super families. These are **Afro-Asiatic** and **Nilo-Saharan**.

A. Afro-Asiatic: this super family is sub-divided into the following families:

1/ Cushitic: linguists divided this language family into **four branches**:

- **Northern:** is represented by Beja, spoken in northwestern Eritrea bordering the Sudan.
- **Central:** Agaw includes Awign, Kunfel, Qimant; Hamtanga and Bilen.
- **Eastern:** this includes diversified linguistic groups like Afar, Ale, Arbore, Baiso, Burji, Darashe, Dasanech, Gedeo, Hadiya, Halaba, Kambata, Konso, Libido, Mosiye, Oromo, Saho, Sidama, Somali, Tambaro, Tsemai, etc.
- **Southern:** represented by Dhalo in Kenya and Nbugua in Tanzania.

2/ Semitic: is divided into two:

- **North:** Ge'ez, Rashaida (spoken around Eritrea-Sudanese border); Tigre (spoken in Eritrean Lowland); Tigrigna (spoken in highland Eritrea and Tigray).
- **South:** is further divided into two
 - ✓ **Transverse:** Amharic, Argoba, Harari, Silte, Wolane and Zay.
 - ✓ **Outer:** Gafat (extinct), Gurage and Mesmes (endangered).

3/ Omotic: Anfillo, Ari, Bambasi, Banna, Basketo, Bench, Boro-Shinasha, Chara, Dawuro, Dime, Dizi, Dorze, Gamo, Ganza, Gayil, Gofa, Hamer, Hozo, Kachama-Ganjule, Karo, Keficho, Konta, Korete, Male, Melo, Nayi, Oyda, Sezo, Shekkacho, Sheko, Wolayta, Yem, Zayse etc. Among its groups, Omoto includes Wolayta and Gamo while main Gongga is Keficho.

B. Nilo-Saharan: sub divided into sub families namely, **Chari- Nile and Koman/**. Anywa, Berta, Gumuz, Kacipo-Balesi, Komo, Kunama, Kwama, Kwegu, Majang, Mi'en, Murle, Mursi, Nara, Nu'er, Nyangatom, Opo, Shabo, Suri and Uduk are languages belong to the **Nilo-Saharan** supper family.

☞ **Unclassified:** Weyto (might be Cushitic or Semitic); Ongota (moribund possibly Omotic or separate branch of Afro-Asiatic or not at all) & Rer Bare (extinct-may be Bantu).

☞ Language classification **did not remain static**. Factors like **population movements, warfare, trade, religious and territorial expansion, urbanization** etc. have resulted in intense linguistic processes that forced languages to be affected. In this process, **some languages died out** or have been **in danger of extinction** while others **thrived off** the social phenomenon that is evidently observed.

2.3.2. Settlement Patterns

- A settlement pattern, the distribution of peoples across the landscape, is the results of long historical processes in northeast Africa. A Settlement pattern is differ from place to place. Such as:
- In some areas, settlement was dense and in other areas sparse.

- Some people inhabited extensive highlands and others the lowlands.
- Based on historical linguistic and history of inter-peoples relations, studies indicate that **environmental, socio-economic, and political processes** significantly shaped and reshaped the spatial distribution of peoples in the region.
- ❖ Since early times, the **Cushitic and Semitic peoples** had inhabited the area between the Red Sea in the east and Blue Nile in the west from where they dispersed to different directions. In due course,
 - the **Cushites** have evolved to be the **largest linguistic group** in Ethiopia and the Horn and have also spread over wide areas from **Sudan to Tanzania**.
 - the **Semitic** peoples spread over large area and eventually settled **the northern, north central, northeastern, south central and eastern** parts of Ethiopia and the Horn. The **Semites** are the **second majority people** next to the Cushites.
 - Except the **Shinasha**, who live in **Benishangul-Gumuz** and the **South Mao** in Wallagga, the **majority of Omotic peoples** have inhabited **southwestern Ethiopia** along the **Omo River basin**. Yet, **in the earlier times**, they had extended much further to the **north**.
 - **In the west**, the **Nilotes** are largely settled along the Ethiopia-Sudanese border although some of the **Chari-Nile family** inhabited as far as **southern Omo**. The latter are identified as the **Karamojo cluster** living around **Turkana Lake** along **Ethio-Kenyan border**.

2.3.3. Economic Formations

- ❖ The **domestication of plants and animals** gave humanity two interdependent modes of life: **agriculture and pastoralism**.

☞ Pastoralism

- While there may be **pure pastoralists**, it is very rare to think of a farmer without a head of cattle or two. Likewise, in Ethiopia and the Horn, these two forms of livelihood **have coexisted and quite often interrelated**.
- Yet, **topographic features** and **climatic conditions** largely influenced economic activities in Ethiopia and the Horn.
- A predominantly **pastoral economy** has characterized **the eastern lowland region** since early periods. **Pastoral economy** namely the **production of camel, goat, and cattle** has been the most common economic practice among the **Afar, Saho and Somali** as well as **Karayu and Borana Oromo**. While **the Afar and Karrayu** have depended on the **Awash River**, the **Somali** have owed a great deal to **Wabi Shebelle and Genale (Jubba) Rivers**.

☞ Agriculture

- **The plateaus** have sustained **plough agriculture** for thousands of years supporting sizable populations.
- Majority of the populations were engaged in **mixed farming**. It is here (plateaus) that sedentary agriculture had been **started and advanced at least since 10, 000 years B. P.** by the **Cushites, Semites and Omotic** groups.
- The major economic activity of the **Omotic** has been:-
 - ✚ **mixed farming and trade** in **northern Omo**
 - ✚ **pastoralism and fishing** predominantly practiced in **southern Omo**.
 - ✚ Many of the Omotic groups have also been famous in **metallurgy, weaving** and other **crafts**.

- ☞ In the **sparsely populated western lowland region**, the dominant economic formations were **pastoralism, shifting agriculture, fishing, apiculture and hunting**. For instance, **sorghum, millet, cotton and others** have been largely cultivated in the **lowlands along Ethio-Sudanese border** since antiquity.

- ☞ **The Nilotes** along the **Blue Nile and Baro-Akobo Rivers** have been **shifting cultivators** where **sorghum** has been a staple food. Among **majority Nilotic communities**, cattle have high

economic and social values. **Berta and other Nilotes** had trade and other social contacts with **northern Sudan**.

2.4. Religion and Religious Processes

2.4.1. Indigenous Religion

- ☞ This includes a variety of religious beliefs and practices, which are native to the region and have been followed by the local people since ancient times.
- ☞ A distinctive mark of indigenous religion is belief in one Supreme Being, but special powers are attributed to natural phenomena, which are considered sacred. Spiritual functionaries:-
 - officiate over rituals,
 - propitiate divinities, and
 - are held in a lot of respect as intermediaries between the society and spirits.

❖ Waqeffanna of Oromo

- Waqeffanna of the Oromo is based on the existence of one Supreme Being called **Waaq**. Waaq's power is manifested through the spirits called Ayyana. The major spirits include:-
 - **Abdar/Dache** (soil fertility spirit)
 - **Atete** (women or human and animal fertility spirit)
 - **Awayi/Tiyyana** (sanctity spirit)
 - **Balas** (victory spirit)
 - **Chato/Dora** (wild animals defender spirit)
 - **Gijare/ Nabi** (father and mother's spirit)
 - **Jaricha** (peace spirit)
 - **Qasa** (anti-disease spirit) etc.
 - There is also a belief that the dead exist **in the form of a ghost** called **Eker** in the surrounding of his/her abode before death, or **his/her cemetery (Hujuba)**.
- In the autumn and spring seasons every year at the edge of ever-flowing river and top of mountain respectively, there is **thanks giving festival** called **Irrecha** besides **New Year (Birbo)** rite.
 - Revered experts known as Qallu (male) and Qallitti (female) have maintained link between the Ayyana and the believers. Qallu ritual house is called Galma located on hilltop or in the grove of large trees.
 - On **Wednesday and Friday nights**, there is **Dalaga**/ecstasy at which **Qallu or Qallitti** is possessed by **Ayyana** so that s/he can interpret mysteries. The **Jila/Makkala** (delegated messengers) used to make pilgrimage to get consecration of **senior Qallu (Abba Muda or anointment father)** until about **1900**. **Abba Muda** had turban **surrirufa** of tri-colors: **black at top, red at center and white at bottom** representing those in **pre-active life, active (luba)** and **those in post-active life** respectively.

❖ Hadiya

- ☞ Among the Hadiya the Supreme Being is known as **Waa**, who is believed to exist before everything (**hundam issancho**) or create world (**qoccanch**) and whose eyes are represented by **elincho (sun)** and **agana (moon)**. The major spirits include:-
 - **Jara** (male's protector)
 - **Idota** (female's guard)
 - **Hausula, Qedane and Warriqa** attracted prayers and sacrifices at Shonkolla and Kallalamo mountains chosen by Anjancho and Jaramanjocho.
- ☞ One of Hadiya's clans, **Worqimene**, is believed to have the power to send rain in drought. **Fandanano (sing. Fandancho)** practice is believed to be introduced by either spiritual leaders, **Itto and Albaja** from **Bimado clan**, or **Boyamo**, father of five Hadiya clans, and was largely followed by inhabitants of **Boshana, Misha** etc.

- ❖ The **Kambata**
 - have **Negita or Aricho Magano**/Sky God and
 - religious officials known as **Magnancho**.
- ❖ The **Gedeo**
 - called the Supreme Being, **Mageno** and
 - In *Gede'uffa* the word **Dararo** literally refers to **flower**. Its thanks giving festival/ceremony performed just after the harvest season every year in January, accompanied by praying ceremony.
- ❖ The **Konso** religion centered on worship of **Waaq/Wakh**.
- ❖ The **Gojjam Agaw** used to call the Supreme Being **Diban** (Sky God).
- ❖ Among sections of **the Gurage**, there have been:-
 - **Waq/Goita** (supreme deity),
 - **Bozha** (thunder God) and
 - **Damwamwit** (health Goddess).
- ☞ The **Gurage and the Yem** had a common deity known as **Abba** at Enar (Henar).
- ❖ The **Yem**
 - worshipped **Ha'o** (Sky God).
 - So'ala clan was considered as the top in religious duties as it was in charge of **Shashokam** (the most vital deity).
 - Religious functions were performed through couriers in each village called Magos.
- ❖ The **Konta's** spirit-cult was called **Docho**.
- ❖ The **Wolayta**
 - The Wolayta called God **Tosa** and spirit **Ayyana**. These spirits include:-
 - ✚ **Tawa-Awa /Moytiliya** (father's spirit),
 - ✚ **Sawuna** (justice spirit),
 - ✚ **Wombo** (rain spirit),
 - ✚ **Micho** (goat spirit),
 - ✚ **Nago** (sheep spirit),
 - ✚ **Kuchuruwa** (emergency spirit),
 - ✚ **Gomashera** (war spirit),
 - ✚ **Talahiya** (Beta **Talaye** or **talheya**, Omo spirit) etc.
 - In Wolayta:-
 - ✚ **Dufuwa (grave)** was believed to be abode of **Moytiliya**.
 - ✚ Annual worship of spirits was performed at a sacred place called **Mitta** usually at the **end of May** and **beginning of June** to offer sacrifice of the first fruits called **Teramo or Pageta (Dubusha)**.
 - ✚ During annual worship, people gathered around tree called **Dongowa**, which varied from clan to clan. Example:-
 - **sycamore** (*Ficussur exasperate*) for the **Bubula**
 - **podocarp** for **Zatuwa** etc.
 - ✚ The **Qesiga** called their meeting place **Kasha (Dabre)**.
 - ✚ To protect people from eating crop before harvesting **Zomboro** clan used **Diqaysa** practice by planting in their fields **sour olive** and **nubica** trees.
 - The **Wolayta** also:-
 - ✚ had the practice of **Chaganna** (prohibited days to work) to protect produce from disaster.
 - ✚ chose and kept dark brown heifer called **Beka (Beqabe) or Baqa Potilliya** (Literally, ritual cattle) as **birthday fate**. If they made error in respecting this custom, they would anoint their bodies with a leaf called **Aydameta** (ground red pepper) as repentance.

Religious practitioners known as **Sharechuwa** had **Becha or Kera Eza Keta** (ritual house).

✚ The Walayta's New Year is known as **Gifata**.

❖ **The Keficho** called:-

- Supreme Being as **Yero**;
- Spirit as **Ego**
- A person who hosts *Ego*, as **Alamo or eke-nayo**.
- Father of all spirits **dochi or dehe-tateno** and its host **dochi-nayo or Ibedechino/Ibede-gudeno** (including **Arito** and **Wudia Riti**), with residence at **Adio**.
- Harvest spirit **Kollo** and sacrifice to it **dejo**.
- Earth and area spirits as **Showe-kollo** and **Dude-baro** respectively.

☞ There are also local spirits like:-

- **damochechi** of Channa
- **yaferochi** of Sharada and
- **wogidochi** of Adio

☞ In Keficho, **gepetato** or **king of hill** identified by **Yetecho** clan as landowner.

☞ Members of the **Dugo clan** led spiritual services.

❖ The **Boro-Shinasha** people believe in super natural power called **Iqa**, which created everything and presides over the universe. The **indigenous religion elements** prescribe praying for the prevention of drought, flooding, erosion, disease and starvation within the community and their surrounding environment. Among various prayer rituals:-

- The first is **Gure Shuka** for preservation of their locality through slaughtering animals by calling the name of God being at the tip of the mountains.
- The second is **Shode De'na**, praying and slaughtering when unexpected disease happens.
- The third is **Marrowa Shuka**; slaughtering for children **to grow without disease and to prevent children from evil spirits attack; for rehabilitation of wealth; to promote harmonious way of life and productivities in the family**.

☞ The rituals are led by **recognized elders**, whose pray and bless are trusted to reach God among the three clans: **Enoro, Endiwo and Dowa**.

❖ **The Nuer:**

- believe in **Kuoth Nhial (God in Heaven)**, but believe in the coming of God through rain, lightning and thunder, and rainbow is necklace of God. **Sun and moon** as well as other entities are also manifestation or sign of God. There are also **spirits** associated with **clan-spears** names such as **WiW (spirit of war)** associated with thunder.
- believe that when a person dies, flesh is committed to earth while breath or life goes back to **Kuoth** and soul that signifies human personality remains alive as a shadow or a reflection, and departs together with ox sacrificed to place of ghosts.

☞ An **interesting feature of indigenous religion** is the way its practices and beliefs are fused with **Christianity and Islam**. This phenomenon of **mixing of religions** is known as **syncretism**.

2.4.2. Judaism

❖ **Judaism** is considered as the expression of the covenant that **Yahweh/Jehovah (God)** established with the **ancient Jewish (Hebrew)**. Sources indicate that Judaism:-

- has been followed in Ethiopia and the Horn by peoples since early times.
- began to be clearly noticed in the **4th century AD**, when the **Bete-Israel** (literally, house of Israel), one of the ancient peoples in the region, refused to be converted to Christianity.

☞ The **Bete-Israel** practiced **Haymanot (religious practices)**, which are generally recognized as Israelite religion that differs from **Rabbinic Judaism**). Many of **the Bete-Israel** accounts of their

own origins stress that they stem from the very ancient migration of some portion of **the Tribe of Dan** to Ethiopia, led it is said by **sons of Moses**, perhaps even at the time of the **Exodus** (1400-1200 B.C.). Alternative timelines include perhaps the later crises in **Judea**, e.g., split of the **northern Kingdom of Israel** from the **southern Kingdom of Judah** after **the death of King Solomon** or **Babylonian Exile**.

- ☞ **Other Bete-Israel** take as their basis **the account of return to Ethiopia of Menilek I**, who is believed to be **the son of King Solomon** (r. 974-932 B.C.) of ancient Israel and **Makeda, ancient Queen of Saba (Sheba)**, and considered to be **the first Solomonic Emperor of Ethiopia**.
- ☞ **Another group of Jews** is said to have been arrived in Ethiopia led by **Azonos and Phinhas in 6th century A.D.** Still others are said to have been **Jewish immigrants intermarried with the Agaws**. Whatever the case, **the Jews** appear to have been **isolated from mainstream Jewish for at least a millennium**. The Jewish developed and lived for centuries in northern and northwestern Ethiopia.

2.4.3. Christianity

- ❖ Christianity became state religion in **334 A.D.** during the reign of King Ezana (r. 320-360), who embraced Christianity dropping pre-Christian gods like:-
 - Ares (Hariman/Maharram/war god)
 - Arwe (serpent-python god)
 - Bahir (sea god) and
 - Midir (earth god).
- ❖ Instrumental in conversion of **king Ezana** were Syrian brothers, **Aedesius and Frementius (Fremnatos)**.
 - When **Fremnatos (Kasate Birhane or Abba Salama)** visited **Alexandria**, **Patriarch Atnatewos** (328-373) appointed him as **the first Bishop of Ethiopian Orthodox Church (EOC)**.
 - Consecration of bishops from **Coptic Church in Egypt** continued until **1959**, when **Abune Baslios** became **the first Ethiopian Patriarch**.
- ❖ Christianity was further expanded to the mass of the society in later part of **fifth century**, during **the reign of Ella Amida II** (478-86) by the **Nine Saints** shown in the table below:

Table 1: The Nine Saints

Name	Origin	Church/Monastery	Location of the Church
1.Abuna Aregawwi (Abba Za Mika'el)	Rome	Debre Damo	Eastern Tigray
2.Abuna Isaq (Abba Gerima)	Rome	Debre Gerima	Medera (East of Adwa)
3.Abba Pentelwon	Rome	Debre Pentelwon	Asbo (North East of Aksum)
4.Abba Afse	Ladocia	Debre Afse	Yeha (Northeast of Aksum)
5.Abba Alef	Qa'esare'a	Debre Haleluya	Biheza (Northeast of Aksum)
6.Abba Gubba	Cilicia	Debre Gubba	West of Medera
7.Abba Liqanos	Constantinople	Debre Qonasel	North of Aksum
8.Abba Sehama	Antioch	Tsedania	Southeast of Adwa
9.Abba Yima'ata	Qosa'iti	Debre Yima'ata	Ger'alta

Source: Sergew Hable Sellassie, *Ancient and Medieval Ethiopian History to 1270* (Addis Ababa: Haile- Selassie I University Press, 1972), pp.115-9.

- ❖ The **saints** also **translated Bible and other religious books** into **Geez**.
- ❖ Then expansion of Christianity continued in **Zagwe period** (1150-1270) and chiefly gained fresh momentum during the early **Medieval Period** (1270-1527), when many churches and monasteries were constructed. These include:-
 - Rock-hewn churches of Lalibela
 - Debra-Bizan of Hamasen in Eritrea
 - Debra-Hayiq in Wollo
 - Debre-Dima and Debre-Werq in Gojjam

- Debra-Libanos in Shewa
 - Birbir Mariam in Gamo and
 - Debre-Asabot on the way to Harar
- ☞ These churches and monasteries are **not merely religious centers, but served through the ages as repositories of ancient manuscripts and precious objects of art.**
- ❖ From mid-sixteenth to the early seventeenth centuries, Jesuits **tried to convert Monophysite EOC to Dyophysite Catholic**. Yet, this led to bloody conflicts that in turn **led to expulsion of the Jesuits**. However, the Jesuits intervention triggered **religious controversies within EOC**.
 - ❖ As of **1804**, missionaries' religious expansion was one of the dominant themes of **treaties concluded between European diplomats and Ethiopian authorities**.
 - ❖ **The Catholic** Giuseppe Sapeto (Lazarist mission founder), Giustino De Jacobis (Capuchin order founder), Cardinal Massaja, Antoine and Arnauld d'Abbadie were active.
 - ❖ **Anglican Church Missionary Society (ACMS), Church Missionary Society of London (CMSL) and Wesleyan Methodist Society** led Protestant missionaries and their major leaders were **Samuel Gobat, C.W. Isenberg and J. L. Krapf**.
 - ❖ Systematic approach of **trained Protestants** enabled them to win confidence of local people. They **translated spiritual books into vernaculars**. They adopted old names for Supreme Being like Wagayyo, Tosa etc and used them in new versions as equivalent to **God**. Village schools were established as centers of preaching the faith. **These schools** were open to all children of chiefs and farmers. They also provided medical facilities. All these attracted a large number of followers. Eventually, continuous and systematic indoctrinations seem to have resulted in grafting of new teaching on indigenous religion.

2.4.4. Islam

- ❖ When **Prophet Mohammed** started the teaching of Islam in **Mecca in 610 AD**, he faced opposition from the **Quraysh rulers**. Under this circumstance, the Prophet sent some of his early followers including his daughter **Rukiya** and her husband **Uthman** as well as the Prophet's future wives **Umm Habiba and Umm Salma** to Aksum.
- ❖ The first group of refugees was led by **Jafar Abu Talib**. In his advice to his followers, the Prophet said of Ethiopia, **"...a king under whom none are persecuted. It is a land of righteousness, where God will give relief from what you are suffering."**
 - The then Aksumite king, **Armah Ella Seham (Ashama b. Abjar or Ahmed al-Nejash in Arabic sources)**, gave asylum for the refugees from **615-628**.
 - Leaders of the **Quraysh asked Armah** to repatriate the refugees, but the king did not comply. **Armah** is said to have replied, "If you were to offer me a mountain of gold I would not give up these people who have taken refuge with me."
- ❖ Subsequently,
 - **Islam** spread to the Horn of Africa **not through Jihad**, but through **peaceful ways** including **trade**.
 - **Islam** was well established in **Dahlak (Alalay) Islands** on the Red Sea by the beginning of **eighth century**. In the **early tenth century**, the Muslim community on the islands developed a **sultanate**.
- ❖ In due course, Muslims settled other places on the Red Sea coast. It was from these coastal areas that Islam gradually spread among the predominantly pastoral communities of the interior, largely through the agency of preachers and merchants.
- ❖ Notwithstanding the debates, **the Dahlak route played a minor role in introduction of Islam into the interior of the country because:-**
 - Christianity was strongly entrenched as a state religion in Aksum and later states of northern Ethiopia and

- open proselytization of Islam was prohibited. Thus, **the port of Zeila on western coast of Gulf of Aden served as an important gateway** for the introduction of Islam mainly into the present day **Shewa, Wollo and Hararghe**.
- ❖ **Islam** firmly established itself in the coastal areas by **the eighth and ninth centuries**. From there, it radiated to **central, southern, and eastern** Ethiopia through the role of **Muslim clerics who followed in the footsteps of traders**. In this regard, it should be noted that **Sheikh Hussein of Bale**, a Muslim saint of medieval period, played very important role in the expansion of Islam into **Bale, Arsi and other southeastern parts of Ethiopia and the Horn**. Another **Islamic center** in this region is **Sof Umar shrine**.
- ❖ Islam was introduced into **Somali territories** in **8th century A. D.** through **Benadir coasts of Moqadishu, Brava and Merca**. **Abu Bakr Ibn Fukura al Din Sahil** set up **Moqadishu Minirate c.1269**.
- ❖ Islam was further expanded by **mystical orders (turuq, singular tariqa)**. Among these,
 - The **Qadiriyya** (named after Hanbali jurist Abd al-Qadir al-Jilani, 1077-1166) **emphasized collective devotion (hadra)**.
 - The **Ahmadiyya**, which had been set up by Ahmad Ibn Idris al Fasi of Fez in Morocco (1760-1837) **stressed austerity, turban and veil**. It had contacts with **Tijaniyya** (named after Abu al-Abbas Ahmad b. Muhammad b. al-Mukhtar al Tijani, 1737-1815) and **Summaniyya** (named after Muhammad b. Abd al-Karim al Sammāni, 1718-75). The sheiks of these orders expanded Islam as far as the Gibe region. **The mosques**, Islamic learning and pilgrimage centers have been the depositories of cultures, traditions and literature of local Muslims.

UNIT THREE

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIETY IN ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN TO THE END OF THE THIRTEENTH CENTURY

3.1. Emergence of States

- ❖ The **beginning of sedentary agriculture** was one important factor for the emergence of states.
- ❖ The **growth of trade** also facilitated the development of states.
- ❖ **State:-**
 - refers to an autonomous political unit having **population, defined territory, sovereignty and government with the power to decree and enforce laws**.
 - was the outcome of **regular cultural process**. In this regard, it should be emphasized that, states arose independently in different places and at different times. Favorable environmental conditions helped to hasten the rate of transformation in some regions.
- ❖ **Religion** is also the other factor for the emergence of states. The **first states** were **theocratic states** and **priests (shaman)** maintained the social and religious affairs of their people. As production became market oriented, the **priests were gradually replaced by chiefs**, who began collecting regular and compulsory tributes known as **protection payments** with which they maintained themselves; their supporters chiefly the army, the bureaucracy and other followers.
- ❖ **Ethiopia and the Horn** is one of the regions in Africa, where early state formation took place. From small beginnings, such states gradually developed into **powerful kingdoms** and **even empires** with a well-demarcated social structure. **Geographical proximity to** and control of the international water bodies like **Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Indian Ocean** along with their **ports** as well as rich interior favored some of them to become stronger than their neighbors and eventually dominated them.

3.2. Ancient States

3.2.1. North and Northeast

A. Punt

- ❖ Punt was the earliest recorded state in Ethiopia and the Horn.
- ❖ The evidence on Punt comes from **Egyptian hieroglyphic writings**, accompanied by vivid paintings; tell of a series of naval expeditions, which the Egyptian Pharaohs sent to Punt.
- ⌚ **Pharaoh Sahure** (r. 2743-2731 B.C.) sent expedition to collect **myrrh, ebony and electrum (gold and silver alloy)**.
- ⌚ During **Pharaoh Asosi**, treasurer of **God Bawardede** took **dancing dwarf “dink”** to Egypt from Punt.
- ⌚ The best described and illustrated expedition was the one undertaken by the order of the famous Egyptian **Queen Hatshepsut** (1490-1468 B.C.), whose expedition is documented at her **tomb in Dier El Bahri**. She sent five ships under the leadership of **Black Nubian Captain Nehasi** via Wadi-Tumilat. The expedition:-
 - was warmly welcomed by the **Puntites King Perehu**, his wife **Ati**, sons, daughters and followers.
 - was able to return collecting **frank incense, cinnamon, sweet smelling woods (sandal), spices, ivory, rhinoceros horn, leopard and leopard skins, ostrich feathers and egg, live monkeys, giraffes, people** etc. Hatshepsut presented some parts of the items to her **god, Amun**.
- ☞ It was because of the **ritual importance** of their **exports** that Puntites were also known as **Khebis of the Ta Netjeru** (divine or ghosts land). **Iron, bronze, asses, foxes, cattle, animals fur, dying and medicinal plants** were also **exported** from **Punt to Egypt**. In return, **axes, daggers, swords, knives, sickles, clothes, bracelets, necklaces, beads and other trinkets** were **imported from Egypt to Punt**.

Scholars have **not reached agreement** as to the **exact location of Punt**. The varieties of incense and myrrh mentioned in the writings have suggested **northern or northeastern Somalia** to some scholars while others are inclined more towards **Northern Ethiopia** because of the reference to gold, ebony and monkeys. The latter reinforce their guess arguing that at that early period, Egyptian sailboats might not have been strong enough to pass through **the Strait of Babel Mandeb** into the **Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean**. Considering the two suggestions, still some others argue that it was probably stretched from **Swakim** or **Massawa to Babel Mandeb (Gate of Tears) and Cape Gardafui**.

B. Da'amat and Other Cultural Centers in Northern Ethiopia and Eritrea

- ❖ The state known as **Da'amat** had a center a little to the **south of Aksum**.
- ❖ Inscription of the **king of Da'amat** tentatively dated to the **fifth century BC** shows that he used **politico-religious title** known as **Mukarib**.
- ❖ Various gods and goddesses like **Almouqah** (principal god), **Astater** (Venus god), **Na'uran** (light god), **Shamsi** (sun god), and **Sin** (moon god) were worshipped in the domain of the Da'amat state and other northern Ethiopian pre-Aksumite cultural centers. There were similar practices in **South Arabia** at the time.
- ☞ There were a number of cultural centers in northern Ethiopia. The major ones are:
 - **Yeha:**
 - is located **30 kms** to the **northeast of Aksum** and was the oldest of these centers.
 - probably emerged around **1, 000 BC** as a small **emporium** where **South Arabian merchants** and their agents bought and stored **ivory, rhinoceros horn** and other commodities coming from the interior.
 - It seems that the period of its prosperity (zenith) was from about **750 to 500 B.C.** Remains of walls of some of its buildings and stone masonry as well as still standing temple and inscriptions indicate Yeha's glory.
 - **Hawulti Melazo:**

- is situated to **southeast of Aksum**, where stone tablets that are inscribed in rectangular temple surrounded by a wall decorated with paintings representing **herds of cattle** have been excavated.

□ Addi-Seglemani:

- is located at **10kms southwest of Aksum**, from where a stone slab is fetched and the oldest Ethiopian monumental inscription is discovered.
- ☞ There were also other cultural centers like Addi Gelemo, Addi Grameten, Addi Kewih, Atsbi Dera, Feqiya, Hinzat, Sefra, Senafe, Tekonda etc.

C. The Aksumite State

- The nucleus of the Aksumite state was formed around **200-100 B.C.**
- **Initially**, its power was limited to a relatively small area comprising **the town of Aksum and its environs**. Gradually, however, it expanded to include **large territories in all directions**.
- **In its heyday**, Aksumite territories extended from **the Red Sea coast in the East to the Western edge of Ethiopian plateau overlooking the vast Nile Valley in the west and from the northern most corner of Eritrea and possibly as far south as northern parts of Shewa**.
- According to *Periplus of Erithrean Sea*, **Adulis** on the western coast of the Red Sea was the major port of Aksum. The long distance trade routes from Adulis and other posts on the Red Sea coast passed inland through such centers as Kaskasse, Coloe, Matara and even further west across Takaze River. The document also mentioned ports of **Aden (Eudaemon)** Gulf like **Avalites (Zayla)** and **Malao (Berbera)**, and Indian Ocean **Benadir Coasts** like **Serapion (Moqadishu)**, **Nicon (Brava)** and **Merca**.
- The major items of export of the Aksumite state consisted mainly of the natural products such as ivory, myrrh, emerald, frankincense and some spices (like ginger, cassia and cinnamon), gold, rhinoceros horns, hippopotamus hides, tortoise shells and some curiosity animals like apes.
- The Aksumite state imported a number of manufactured products like garments and textiles from Egypt, India, Roman Empire, and Persia; glassware and jewelry from Egypt and other places; metallic sheets, tools or utensils of various kinds, oil and wine from Roman Empire and Syria.
- **Zoscales** (c. 76-89), the then king of Aksum, used to **communicate in Greek language**, Lingua Franca of Greco-Roman world. Aksum also had relations with **Ceylon (Sri Lanka)** and **Laodicea (Asia Minor)**.
- The Adulis inscription written in Greek about an unknown king, which eventually was published in **Cosmas Indicopleustes'** book, the *Christian Topography*, describes **commercial activities** of the Red Sea areas. It also mentions the internal long distance trade between Aksum and a distant region called **Sasu**, most probably in **Beni Shangul** and the adjoining lands beyond the **Blue Nile**. A big caravan made up of close to five hundred merchants some of them special agents of the kings of Aksum would take to Sasu **cattle**, **lumps of salt** (probably salt blocks) and **iron** to **exchange for gold**. Yet, as they **did not speak each other's language**, and did not even trust to be near to each other to bargain through signs and gestures, the whole exchange was done without one side seeing the other. This was a good example of **silent trade**.
- ✚ **Aksumite kings** had extensive **contacts with the outside world** notably with the **South Arabian region**, leading to exchange of ideas, material and spiritual culture. Sometimes such contacts involved conflicts between the two regions. One of such known recorded conflict between areas on both sides of the sea took place around **200 A.D.** Accordingly, peoples in **Southern Arabian Peninsula**, in **present day Yemen**, had difficulties in defending themselves against the army of the Aksumite king, **Gadarat**.
- ✚ **Aksumite kings** like Aphilas, Endybis, Wazeba, Ezana, Ousanas II, etc. minted and issued different kinds of coins in gold, silver and bronze for both overseas and local transactions from the **third to seventh centuries**. Aksum was **one of the four great powers** of the world (i. e.

Roman Empire, Persia, China and Aksum) at the time. It was a **major naval and trading power** from the **first to the seventh** centuries. **Aksumite ships** were the main means of transporting goods. Aksum was the only one with **sufficient sources of timber for shipbuilding** and in those days, the technology for it existed in **Adulis**. Aksum had a large **fleet of ships**, which was used **not only for trade** but also for its **wars across** the Red Sea.

- **Kaleb** (r. 500-35) expanded overseas territories of Aksum beyond Himyar and Saba, but the local prince **Dhu-Nuwas** was converted to Judaism, marched to Zafar and Nagran, and **killed many Christians**.

- ✚ Byzantine Vasiliev Justinian (r. 527-65) with sanctification of Patriarch Timit III (518-538) provided Kaleb with a number of ships transporting armies led by Julianos and Nonossus against Dhu Nuwas. **Dhu Nuwas** was defeated and Kaleb appointed **Abraha** as governor of Arabia that continued until 570 A. D.

- ✚ **Kaleb** was succeeded by his son **Gabra Masqal** (535-48) who built church at Zur Amba in Gayint.

☞ It was during **Gabra Maskal** that **Yared developed Ethiopian Orthodox Church liturgical songs and hymns**.

- The Aksumite state had **begun to decline since the late seventh century** because of **internal and external challenges**.

- ✚ **Environmental degradation, decline in agricultural productivity and possibly plague infestation** started to weaken it.

- ✚ With the destruction of the **port of Adulis** by the Arabs around **702**, the international lifeline of the state was cut. The whole network of Aksumite international trade came under the control of the rising and expanding Arab Muslims, and Aksumite state was isolated from its old commercial and diplomatic partners. Consequently, the Aksumite state declined economically. This naturally led to the decline of its political and military power not only on the Red Sea coast but also in its interior provinces, where Aksumite hegemony was challenged by local rebellions.

- ✚ The recurring **rebellions of the Beja, the Agaw and Queen Bani al Hamwiyah (Yodit)** finally sealed the collapse of the Aksumite state.

☞ However, as a civilization, Aksum had a profound impact upon the peoples of the Horn of Africa and beyond, and on its successors i. e. the Zagwe, ‘Solomonic Dynasty’, the Gondarine period etc.

☞ Some of the achievements of Aksum include:-

- ✚ Sub-Saharan Africa’s only surviving indigenous script and calendar as well as

- ✚ EOC hymns and chants, paintings etc.

- ✚ diversified ceramic and lithic tools

- ✚ ivory curving

- ✚ urbanization and sophisticated building traditions (palaces, stele, rock-hewn churches...).

- ✚ complex administrative and governance system, and agricultural system including irrigation etc.

D. Zagwe Dynasty

- ❖ After its decline, **the center of Aksumite state shifted** southwards to **Kubar** rural highland in the territory of the Agaw, one of the ancient inhabitants of the land between the **Eritrean Plateau** and **Jema River**, and to the west up to the Blue Nile valleys. This apparently gave Agaw elites the opportunity to take part in Aksumite state structure serving as **soldiers and functionaries** for at least four centuries.

- ❖ After integrating so well with Aksumite ruling class, the Agaw successfully took over the state administration. Accordingly, the Agaw prince **Merra Teklehaimanot** married Masobe Worq, the daughter of the last Aksumite king **Dil Na'od**. Later he overthrew his father-in-law and took control

of power. Merra-Tekle-Haimanot's successors include **Yimirahana Kirstos, Harbe, Lalibela** (1160-1211), **Ne'akuto La'ab, Yetbarek** etc. Notwithstanding the debates, the Zagwe Dynasty is believed to have ruled from C. 1150 to 1270.

☞ The Zagwe Dynasty made its center in **Bugna District** within **Wag and Lasta**, more exactly at Adafa near Roha (Lalibela).

❖ The territory of the Zagwe kingdom extended from most of **the highland provinces of the ancient Aksumite kingdom in the north** down to **northern Shewa in the south**; the **Lake Tana region** and the northern part of what is **today Gojjam** in the west.

❖ The Agaw maintained the ancient Aksumite traditions almost intact.

- Zagwe rulers renewed cultural and trade contact with eastern Mediterranean region. The most important export items included **slaves, ivory and rare spices while cotton, linen, silver and copper vessels**, various types of **drags** and newly minted **coins** were imported.

- The Zagwe period was a golden age in Ethiopia's **paintings** and **the translation of some of religious works** from Arabic into Ge'ez. That said, Zagwe rulers are best known for the construction of **cave, semi-hewn and monolithic churches**:

1. **Cave**: with some decoration inside, almost similar with natural cave, eg. **Bete-Mesqel**.

2. **Semi-hewn**: with detailed interior decoration and partial decoration outside. They are not totally separated from surrounding rock. Their roofs or walls are still attached to rock, eg. **Bete Denagil, Bete Debresina/Mikael, Bete Golgota, Bete Merqoriwos, Bete Gabri'el-Rufa'el and Bete Abba Libanos.**

3. **Monolithic**: with detailed decoration inside including roof and outside. They are completely separated (carved out) from surrounding rock, eg. **Bete Amanuel, Bete Giyorgis, Bete Mariyam and Bete Medhanialem.**

☞ Among the eleven churches of **Lalibela**:-

- **Bete Medhanelem** is the largest of all.

- **Bete Giyorgis** is said to be the most finely built in the shape of the cross.

🕒 **Lalibela** wanted to establish the second Jerusalem, and **mitigate or even avoid difficulties, which Ethiopian Christians encountered in journey to Holy Lands** at least once in their lifetime. This was done by constructing **churches based on the model of Holy Lands in Israel**.

☞ The Zagwe Dynasty came to end due to:-

- internal problems of royal succession and

- oppositions from groups claiming descent from the ancient rulers of Aksum.

The groups claiming descent from the ancient rulers of Aksum, considered Zagwe kings “**illegitimate rulers**” based on the legend of the Queen of Sheba. The legend was in turn based on a book known as ***Kebra Negest (Glory of Kings)*** that was **translated from Coptic to Arabic and then into Ge'ez**. Based on the legend, the power claimants contend that “**Solomonic**” **Dynasty** ruled the **Aksumite state** until its power was “**usurped**” by the Zagwes. **Yekuno Amlak** (r. 1270-1285), who claimed decent from the last **Aksumite king Dilna'od**, organized his forces being assisted by the ecclesiastical hierarchy and engaged the **last king of Zagwe, Yetbarek** in battle. **Yetbarek** was killed in Gaynt and Yekuno Amlak took the state power contending the “**restoration**” of “**Solomonic**” **Dynasty**.

3.2.2. East, Central, Southern, and Western States

3.2.2.1. Bizamo, Damot, Enarya and Gafat

A. Bizamo:

- was a kingdom located on the **southern bend of Abay River** just opposite to the present districts of **Gojjam** and around the current **Wambara** area.
- was founded in the **eighth century** and had early connections with **Damot**.

B. Damot:

- was strong kingdom that expanded its territories into most of the lands to **south of Abay** and **north of Lake Turkana** as well as **west of Awash** and **east of Didessa**.
- **Motalami** was its prominent king in **the thirteenth century**.

C. Enarya:

- was a kingdom in the Gibe region in **southwestern Ethiopia**. The royal clan was **Hinnare Bushasho** (Hinnario Busaso).
- In the **ninth century**, Aksumite king **Digna-Jan** is said to have led a campaign into **Enarya**, accompanied by **Orthodox Christian priests** carrying arks of covenant (*tabots*).
- Enarya kingship was a divine one: the **king (Hinnare-Tato)** was secluded and considered as sacred. He communicated visitors through an intermediary, **AfeBusho**. The real power rested with **Mikretcho** (council) including **Awa-rasha** (king's spokesman) and **Atche-rasha** (royal treasurer). The kings had residences in **Yadare** and **Gowi**.

D. Gafat:

- historically, the territory of Gafat **lies south of Abay (Blue Nile) River** adjoining **Damot** on the **south western** periphery of the Christian Kingdom.
- was inhabited by **Semitic speaking population** related to **Adere and the Gurage**. It is not clear from available records whether the Gafat formed a “state” or not, but Gafat mountains provided a rich source of gold.
- Despite efforts by Christian evangelists, **the Gafat** largely remained practitioners of their own **indigenous religion**.
- As of early **medieval period**, **Gafat was paying tribute** to the Christian Kingdom mainly in **cattle** which came from **six districts**, among which **Gambo** and **Shat** are Gafat clan names.
- The province was ruled by the title of **Awalamo**.

3.2.2.2. Muslim Sultanates

After the spread of Islam since the beginning of the **eighth century**, viable Muslim communities and states had been established at many locations especially along the main trade routes from Zeila and its many branches penetrating the interior. These states include:

A. **Shewa**: Makhzumi Khalid ibn al-Walid, who claimed decent from **Meca**, set up **Makhzumite Sultanate** in 896 A. D (283 A.H.) on **northeastern foothill of Shewa**.

B. Dahlak:

- This sultanate seemed to have emerged in the beginning of the **tenth century AD**.
- located within the Red Sea and served as a gate way of Islam. In this direction Islam could not penetrate deep into the interior of northern Ethiopia because local Christian rulers opposed open Islamic activities from this Island.

C. Ifat:

- was a state located in the adjacent to **Shewan Sultanate**. Its territory ran from **northeast southwesterly in the Afar plain eastward to the Awash**.
- established by **Umar Walasma**, who claimed decent from **Hashamite clan** and came from **Arabia** between **1271 and 1285**. He intervened between quarrelsome Makzumite princes **Dil-Marrah and Dil-Gamis**, weakened and annexed the sultanate of Shewa. The sultanate was fertile and well watered.
- Its inhabitants earned their living from cultivation of **wheat, sorghum, millet and teff**, and **animal husbandry**. **Sugar cane, bananas, variety of fruits, beans, squashes, cucumbers, and cabbage** completed the diet. **Chat** was described for the first time as being consumed as a stimulant.
- Descendants of **Walasma ruling family** established another strong Muslim sultanate called **Adal**.

D. Fatagar:

- was founded around **Minjar, Shenkora and Ada'a** in the **eleventh century**.

- was a hilly lowland area with thoroughly cultivated fields of wheat and barley, fruits, and extensive grazing grounds full of numerous herds of cattle, sheep and goats.

E. Dawaro:

- located south of Fatagar between upper waters of **Awash and Wabi-Shebelle** extending to Charchar in Northeast and Gindhir in Southeast. We have valuable information on Dawaro by an Egyptian courtier **Ibn Fad Allah el-umari**.
- was much **smaller than Ifat**, but resembled.
- have a currency called **hakuna** in which transition takes place.

F. Bali:

- was an extensive kingdom occupying high plateau, separating basins of Shebelle and Rift valley Lakes.
- was separated from Dawwaro by the Wabi-Shebelle River and extended southwards to the Gannale Dirre River.
- was one of the largest of Ethiopia's Muslim provinces. Its economic activity resembles those of other nearby Muslim lands. **Trade** was mainly based on barter exchanging cattle, sheep, cloth etc.
- had strong army composed of cavalry and infantry.

G. **Others:** mutually independent states like Arababani (between Hadiya and Dawwaro), Biquizar, Dera (between Dawaro and Bali), Fadise, Gidaya, Hargaya, Harla, Kwilgora, Qadise, Sharkah (West of Dawaro and North of Bali in Arsi) and Sim were established and flourished.

3.3. External Contacts

❖ Ethiopia and the Horn had:-

- Contacts with Egypt since at least 3,000 B. C. These relations may be the region's earliest contacts with the Mediterranean world or the Greco-Roman World.
- Very close relations with all commercially active South Arabian Kingdoms starting sometimes before 1,000 B.C.

☞ The **introduction of Christianity to Aksum** established a new pattern of relation between **the region and Egypt**.

- Until the introduction of Islam into Egypt and the general reduction of the Christians into minority, relations between the two were **fairly smooth and friendly**.
- Following the introduction of Christianity, Aksum had established **close relationship with the East Roman or Byzantine Empire** with which it shared common commercial interest in the Red Sea area against their rival Persians. Yet, in the seven century, this relation became complicated and began to deteriorate. The **rapid expansion of the Muslim Arabs through the Near and Middle East, North Africa and the Nile valley** led to the decline of Aksumite land routes and shipping lines. Successive Egyptian Muslim rulers began to use the consecration and sending of a bishop as an instrument to further their own foreign policy objectives and to squeeze concessions from **Ethiopian Christian rulers**, who reacted by **threatening to divert the Nile**. The coming to power of the Mamluk was followed by the reciprocal persecution of religious minorities. Moreover, the Mamluk presented a barrier to the contacts between Christian Ethiopia and European states.

☞ However, the **tradition to visit Jerusalem and other Holy places** in the Middle East had **begun at the end of the first millennium AD**.

- In order to arrive at Holy places, **Ethiopian Christian pilgrims** used the **land route** to Egypt. From Cairo, again they used **the land route** to the Holy land. Consequently, there were considerable numbers of Ethiopian Christian communities found in different regions, in **Egyptian monasteries**, in the **Holy places of Palestine and Armenia**, and in **Italian city-states** in subsequent centuries.

- The **communities living in different parts of the world** served as an **important link or bridge between Ethiopian Christian Kingdom and Europe**. When pilgrims met their fellow Christians of Europe in the Holy places, they transmitted information about the EOC and its exceptional liturgical practices. They also explained about the territorial extent of the Christian Kingdom. From the information, the Europeans began to consider Ethiopian Christian Kingdom as a **very powerful and wealthy state** existing in the Horn of Africa. Consequently, they wanted to use this imaginary strong Christian power against the Muslim powers in the Holy land.
- ☞ Around the middle of the **12th century**, a myth about a **very rich and powerful Christian ruler** known as **Prester John** began to circulate in Europe. The **legend was developed when the balance of the crusade war fought over Jerusalem between the Christians of Europe and the Muslims of the Middle East** was in favor of the latter. In **1165**, a letter addressed to European kings, thought to be sent by the Prester John appeared in Europe mentioning about the enormous power of the Prester John. **The geographical location of the country of Prester John was not known to Europe** for over a century. However, the Europeans began to regard **Ethiopian Christian Kingdom as the land of Prester John** since the only Christian kingdom between the Red Sea and the Indian sub-continent was the Ethiopian Christian Kingdom. Then, they began to search for the location of the Kingdom and to make an alliance with it.

3.4. Economic Formations

A. Agriculture and Land Tenure System

- ❖ The **main stay of ancient states' economy** in highland areas was **plough agriculture**. The mastery of the technology of irrigation also contributed to the growth of agricultural production. Small valley head wetlands were drained for dry season cultivation that provided an important hungry season grains before main upslope harvest has been available. The people used diverse soil fertility enhancement strategies like manure, compost and spreading residues' ashes as well as fallowing, crop rotation, intercropping and contour plowing. In times of labor shortage, farmers also developed teamwork.
- ❖ **Land** has always been one of the **most precious possessions of human society** throughout history. The rules according to which members of the society hold, share and use land constitute what is known as **the land tenure system**. It has been since ancient time that the traditional system of land tenure seems to have developed. The most ancient system of land holding which survived in many parts of Ethiopia and the Horn is the **communal land tenure system**. Communal right to land is a group right. Here group refers to **the family, the clan and the other lineage groups** to which the individual belonged. Each of these groups had communal right to the land they lived in and freely exploited the resources of the land.
- ✚ Peasants in the north had *rist* rights in their respective areas.
 - *Rist* is a kind of communal birthright to land by members of the families and clans whose ancestors had settled and lived in the area over long periods. It is inherited from generation to generation in accordance to with customary law. All the subjects of the state had the *rist* rights.
 - The *rist* owners were known as *bale-rist*. Yet, they paid tributes to the state and all land belonged to the state theoretically.
- ✚ Tribute was collected through a complex hierarchy of state functionaries or officials who were given ***gult* right** over the areas and populations they administered on behalf of the central government.
 - *Gult* is a right to levy tribute on *rist* owners' produce. The tribute collected by *bale gults*, partly allotted for their own up keep and the rest were sent to the imperial center.

- *Gult* right that became hereditary was called *Riste-Gult* as famous well-placed officials used to transfer their position to their offspring.

B. Handicraft

- ❖ **Indigenous handcraft technology** had existed since the ancient period. The social, economic and political conditions of ancient states had allowed the emergence of artisans in various fields with diverse forms and applications **including metalwork, pottery, tannery, carpentry, masonry, weaving, jewellery, basketry and others.**
- ❖ However, except the **carpenters and masons** in some cases, the artisans were mostly despised and marginalized. The ruling classes mostly spent their accumulated wealth on imported luxurious items rather than the domestic technology. The general public attitude towards artisans was not at all encouraging. Consequently, the locally produced agricultural implements and house furniture did not show any significant improvement and sophistication.

C. Trade

- ❖ Trade was another important economic activity of ancient states that obtained considerable income from both internal and international trade. The major socio-economic and political centers of earliest states seem to have also been major trade centers with wide ranging contacts in various directions within the region itself and with merchants coming to the area across the international water bodies.
- ❖ A network of roads connected the centers with the coast and various dependencies in the interior. Local and international merchants frequented these roads. The region was crisscrossed by various trade routes connecting various market places in all directions. The regular flow of trade was so vital to the states in that one of their major concerns was to protect the trade routes and make them safe from robbers.

3.5. Socio-cultural Achievements

A. Architecture

- ❖ **As the states expanded, architecture** also began to flourish and one of the unique architectural technologies was the engraving of **stele** around the **third century AD**. There were totally **fifty eight steles** in and around Aksum that can be grouped into:-
 - well-made and decorated,
 - half completed and
 - megaliths (not hewn).
- ❖ As local tradition says, the **steles** were engraved specifically **at Gobodara** from which they were **transported and planted in Aksum.**
 - ⌚ The longest one of these stele:-
 - measures **33meters** heights (the first in the world).
 - is highly decorated in all of its four sides. It represents a 14 storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom.
 - bears pre-Christian symbols, which are a disc and a crescent (half moon) at the top. Some scholars suggest that this giant stele was broken while the people were trying to erect it while others claim that it was broken during war.
 - ⌚ The second longest obelisk measures **24 meters** height that was successfully erected.
 - It represents a ten-storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom.
 - ⌚ The third longest stele measures **21 meters**
 - It represents a nine-storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom.
 - It is smooth at the back of its side.
 - It is without any decoration.
- ❖ **The Zagwe churches** are regarded as some of **the finest architecture of artistic achievements of the Christian world** and that is why they were registered by UNESCO as part of world cultural

heritage in **1978**, two years before that of the **Aksumite stele**. Further refinement can be observed in the construction and decoration of the **rockhewn churches** in the Zagwe period. Zagwe architecture used a softer material like sandstone, which was cut and shaped all round, except the floor, into a variety of delicately decorated churches.

B. Writing System

- ❖ The Sabeen language had an alphabet with **boustrophedon** writing type that is paleographical writing from left to right and right to left alternatively.
 - ✚ The earliest **Sabeen inscriptions** in **Eritrea and Ethiopia** date to the **ninth century BC**.
 - ✚ One peculiar feature of Sabeen inscriptions is **absence of vowels** as **most of the words are written in consonants**. For instance, **Da'amat** was described as **D'mt**, while its successive kings as **RDM, RBH and LMN** using title, **mlkn**.
- ❖ After the **seventh and sixth centuries BC**, however, variants of script arose, evolving in the direction of **the Ge'ez script** (an alpha syllabary). This evolution can be seen most clearly in evidence from inscriptions mainly **graffiti on rocks and caves**.
 - ✚ By **the first century AD**, "Ge'ez alphabet" arose, an *abjad* (26 consonant letters only) written left-to-right with letters identical to the first-order forms of modern vocalized alphabet.
 - ✚ Though the first completely vocalized texts known are inscriptions by **Ezana** (who left **trilingual inscriptions** in **Greek, Sabeen and Ge'ez**) c. **330 AD**, vocalized letters predate him by some years, as vocalized letter exists in **Wazeba's coin** some 30 or so years before. The process was developed under the influence of **Christian scripture** by adding **vocalic diacritics** for vowels, **u, i, a, e, ə, o**, to the consonantal letters in a recognizable but slightly irregular way, so that the system is laid out as a syllabary.
- ☞ **Ethiopia's ancient indigenous writing system** has immense contribution to the development of **literature, art and the writing of history**.

C. Calendar

- ❖ People needed to know and remember the times when the rains would begin and end as well as the rise and fall of the water level. The responsibility of understanding these vital climatic cycles fell on expertise. In due course, calendars were invented. Calendars were developed and adopted among various peoples of Ethiopia and the Horn.
- **Oromo calendar:-**
 - ✚ has been based on **astronomical observations of moon** in conjunction with **seven or eight particular stars or group of stars** called **Urjii Dhahaa** (guiding stars) and **Bakkalcha** (morning star).
 - ✚ has **29.5 dates** in a month and **354 days in 12 months of a year**.
 - ✚ **Pillars** (dated 300 B.C.), which were discovered in northwestern Kenya from 1978-86 by Archaeologists **Lynch, Robbins and Doyl** have suggested to represent site used to develop Oromo calendar. In connection with this, c. **900 A. D. Oromo person Waqlim** is said to have taken art of **shaping phallic bowls** to Zimbabwe.
- **The Sidama calendar:-**
 - ✚ rotates following movements of stars with **13 months a year**, **12** of which are divided equally into **28 days** while the **thirteenth month** has **29 days**.
 - ✚ has a week that has only **4 days** (**Dikko, Dela, Qawado and Qawalanka**) and hence **each month** has **7 weeks**. Nominated **Mote (King)** is presented to **Fiche Chambalala**, New Year ritual, for **Qetela** or popular demonstration.
- **Ethiopic solar calendar**
 - ✚ has **12 months of 30 days plus 5 or 6** (is added every 4 years) **Epagomenal days**, which comprise a **thirteenth month**.

- ✚ A gap of 7–8 years between **Ethiopic and Gregorian calendars** results from alternative calculation in determining date of **Annunciation**. Thus, the first day of the year, **1 Meskerem/Enkutatash** is usually **September 11 (Gregorian)**. However, it falls on **September 12** in years before the **Gregorian leap year**.
- ✚ has evolved to become the official calendar of the country.
- **The Muslim (Islamic) calendar**
 - ✚ is a lunar calendar consisting of **12 lunar months in a year of 354 or 355 days**.
 - ✚ employs the **Hijra** year of **622 AD**, in which Mohammed and his followers made flight from **Mecca to Medina** and established the **first Muslim community (ummah)**. Dates in this era are usually denoted **AH** (After *Hijra*, "in the year of the *Hijra*"). Years prior to the *Hijra* are reckoned as **BH** ("Before the *Hijra*").
- ☞ Other peoples like the **Agaw**, **Halaba**, **Hadiya**, **Wolayta**, **Gedeo**, **the Nilotes**, etc have their own dating system.

D. Numerals

- ❖ **Numerals** appeared in Ethiopia and the Horn at the beginning of **fourth century AD**.
- ❖ **Ge'ez** uses numeral system comparable to the **Hebrew**, **Arabic** and **Greek** numerals, but it lacks individual characters for **multiples of 100**.
- ❖ **Numbers** are over- and underlined in proper typesetting, combined to make a single bar, but some less sophisticated fonts cannot render this and show separate bars above and below each character.

UNIT FOUR

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIETY FROM THE LATE THIRTEENTH TO THE BEGINNING OF THE SIXTEENTH CENTURIES

4.1. The “Restoration” of the “Solomonic” Dynasty

- ❖ The rulers of the “**Solomonic**” **Dynasty** claimed that they were descendants of the last king of Aksum (Dil Naod) and hence, they were **legitimate** to take over state power from the “**illegitimate**” rulers of the Zagwe dynasty.
- ❖ The name “**Solomonic**” is placed in quotation marks because:-
 - the claim has no historical evidence.
 - the claim of descent from King Solomon of Israel is legendary. The claim has been elaborated in the ***Kibre Negest*** (“**Glory of Kings**”) that associated Ethiopia with the Judeo-Christian tradition. The ***Kibre Negest*** claims that Ethiopian ruling class descended from the **line of Menilek I, son of the Queen of Sheba and King Solomon of Israel**. As a result, Ethiopian monarchs from **Yikuno-Amlak** to Emperor Haile Silassie I claimed descent from **Menilek I**.

4.2. Power Struggle, Consolidation, Territorial Expansion and Religious Processes

4.2.1. Succession Problem and the Establishment of a ‘Royal Prison’ of Amba Gishen

- ❖ Following the end of the reign of **Yikuno-Amlak** in **1285**, a **political instability** caused by constant **power struggles among his sons and grandsons** for succession occurred.
 - A letter written by **Yegba-Tsion** (r.1285-94) to the **Sultan of Egypt and the Patriarch of Alexandria** in **1290** reflected the existence of those struggles.
 - The power struggle intensified during the reigns of **Yegba-Tsion’s five sons** who reigned from **1294 to 1299**.
- ❖ The **succession problem** seems to have been **partly resolved in 1300** during the reign of **Widim-Ra’ad** (r. 1299-1314) following the establishment of a ‘**royal prison**’ at **Amba-Gishen** located in present day **southern Wollo**. According to the rule:-
 - All male members of the royal family were confined at the **Amba**.
 - Loyal soldiers to the reigning monarch guarded the royal prison.

- When the monarch died, court dignitaries would send an army to the royal prison to escort the designated successor and put him on the throne. This practice continued until **Amba-Gishen was destroyed by Imam Ahmad Ibrahim Al-Ghazi's force in 1540.**

4.2.2. Consolidation and Territorial Expansion of the Christian Kingdom

- ❖ From 1270 until the establishment of Gondar in 1636, the medieval monarchs **had no permanent capital.** Initially, the center of the “restored” dynasty was in **medieval Amhara (today’s South Wollo) around Lake Haik.** However, it gradually shifted southward to the districts of **Menz, Tegulet, Bulga,** and finally to the regions dominated by the great height of the **Yerer, Entoto, Menagesha, Wachacha, Furi and Zequalla** mountains.
- ❖ After coming to power, **Yikuno-Amlak** embarked on consolidating his authority throughout the empire. In this regard, he quickly **subdued Ifat**, the Muslim center adjacent to Shewa. Yet, until the coming of **Amde-Tsion** (r.1314-44), the center and the territorial limit of the Christian Kingdom was mainly in present day **Tigray, Lasta, medieval Amhara and Shewa.**
- ❖ **Amde-Tsion** (r.1314-44) was **the first "Solomonic" King**, who embarked on **a policy of a wider and rapid territorial expansion.**
 - Amde-Tsion ‘s main motives of expansion were **economic and political** i.e. **to control the trade routes and territorial seizures.**
 - During the reign Amde Tsion, the **Christian Kingdom controlled extensive territories.** As a result, he was considered as **the most expansionist king of medieval Ethiopia.** His reign also witnessed the **expansion of trade** leading to the flow of commodities to the coast following the major routes.
 - In the process of consolidating his power, Amde Tsion **subdued rebellions** in an attempt to end centrifugal tendencies, which threatened the unity of the Christian Kingdom. In the process, he expanded his territory into **Agaw (Awi) of Gojjam** around 1323/4; **Bizamo** and **Damot** in 1316/7; **Bete-Israel** (located between Dambiya and Tekeze River) around 1332; and the Red Sea Coast. He gave **Enderta** (in today’s northeastern Tigray) to **his wife Bilen-Saba** to consolidate the control of the Christian state over the provinces of the north extending to the coastal areas of Massawa.
 - Amde-Tsion's army **faced stiff resistance** from among **Ifat and Shewa,** which might have **cooperated with the rebellious army** at **Enderta,** led by **Yibeka-Igzi** in 1320s. However, **Bahr-Sagad,** the son of Amde-Tsion, **became the governor of Tigray.**
 - In 1325, Amde-Tsion **campaigns to today’s Eritrean region.** After controlling the whole region, he appointed a governor with a title of **Ma'ekale-Bahir,** which later on changed to **Bahire-Negash.**
 - In **the southeast,** Muslim sultanates paid tributes to the Christian Kingdom. **In the south,** **Gurage speaking areas** and a few of the **Omotic kingdoms like Wolayta and Gamo** were brought under the influence of the Christian state. Amde-Tsion was in **full control of all the trade routes and sources of trade** of the Ethiopian region **in the early 1330s.** The consolidation and territorial expansion of the Christian Kingdom continued during the successors of Amde-Tsion.

4.2.3. Evangelization, Religious Movements, and Religious Reforms of Zara-Yaqob

I. Evangelization

- ❖ Christianity had a long history of expansion. Churches and their believers had been in existence long before expansion of the Christian Kingdom in various parts of the Horn of Africa. For instance, **in Shewa there were early Christians** who maintained contacts with their distant relatives **in Northern part of Ethiopia.** Those early Christians played an important role in the spread of Christianity in several areas.
- ❖ **Iyesus-Mo'a** opened new opportunities of learning for Christians who lived **in the central part of Ethiopia and later evangelized the newly incorporated areas** where the influence of Christianity had either been non-existent or minimal. The **territorial expansion carried out by Amde-Tsion** during the medieval period **set an addition momentum for the spread of Christianity.**
- ❖ **Abune Tekle-Haymanot** played a key role in reviving Christianity **in Shewa,** which was followed by the evangelization of areas in **southern Ethiopia including medieval Damot.** He **baptized and converted Motalami** to Christianity.

- ❖ The clergy, under the direction of the bishop in Ethiopia, **Yaqob**, spread Christianity to different areas of Shewa such as **Kil'at, Tsilalish, Merhabite, Wereb, Moret and Wegda, and Fatagar, Damot, Waj and Enarya.**

II. Religious Movements

A. The Ewostatewos Movement

- ❖ **Monasticism** became a dominant practice in Ethiopian Orthodox Church in the **mid-thirteenth century**. The period witnessed development of monasticism and religious movements of which the major one was the **Ewostatewos movement**, named after the founder.
- ❖ **Ewostatewos:-**
 - Established his own monastic community in **Sara'e (in present day Eritrea)**.
 - Was joined by many students and taught until about **1337** in **Sara'e**.
 - **The strict observance of Sabbath** was among his teachings. When he was **opposed by an organized religious rival group** of the clergy in **Sera'e**, he **fled** the country to **Egypt**. He faced the same opposition in **Cairo** by Ethiopian pilgrims.
- ❖ **After Ewostatewos left Ethiopia, the movement was weakened** although his followers led by **Abba Absad** tried their level best to maintain its momentum. The movement Ewostatewos:-
 - revived when some of his followers such as **Bekimos, Merkoryewos and Gebre-Iyasus** returned home from **Armenia**. The followers of Ewostatewos soon became active and dispersed to different monasteries in northern Ethiopia.
 - spread to areas like **Enfranz, northern Tigray, and Hamessen**.
- ❖ The **King and the Abun** opposed the movement. Hence,
 - The **anti-Ewostatewos group** led by **the Abbot of the Hayq Monastery** called **Aqabe-Se'at Serege-Birhan** was supported by **the Abun and the monarch**.
 - The monarch **imprisoned some of the Ewostatians** owing to the fact that he feared that dispute in the church could divide his kingdom.
 - The clergy **expelled Ewostatians from their church services**; some of **the Ewostatians were forced to withdraw and settle in peripheral areas** and some of them **sustained their movement in monasteries like Debre- Bizen, Debre-San, etc.**

B. Deqiye Estifanos/ the Estifanosites

- ❖ **The Estifanosites** were a movement within Ethiopian monasticism, called so after their founder and spiritual leader abba Estifanos.
 - The movement rose to prominence in the **fifteenth century** and continued until the **sixteenth century**, when it was formally reconciled with the main body of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church.
- ❖ The head of the movement, **abba Estifanos**,
 - was born in **Agame** at the end of the fourteenth century.
 - established a rigid monastic organization which emphasized **poverty, absolute self-subsistence, equality and independence from secular authorities**. His adversaries in the monastic circles made attempts to discredit him, but the movement gained followers in various monastic communities. When summoned to the royal court, Estifanos was initially able to convince the emperor (**probably atse Takla Maryam**, r. 1430-33) that he posed no threat to royal power or the unity of the Church. Later, however, Estifanos collided with **Zara-Yaqob**. Because, **Estifanos:-**
 - ✚ appears to have disapproved of the Emperor's religion initiatives,
 - ✚ rejected royal supremacy and authority in spiritual matters and
 - ✚ refused to participate in court judiciary procedures.
- ☞ **As a result, Zara-Yacob** took **very harsh measures** against the **Estifanosites** allegedly for their **opposition of the veneration of St. Mary**.
 - **Naod** appears to have been more favourably inclined towards the Estifanosites and to have been instrumental in their reintegration into the EOC during the period of **Metropolitan abune Yeshaq**. For their part, Estifanosites appear to have **softened their position**; the **excommunication was lifted by the Metropolitan**. Despite the importance of the Estifanosites movement for the history of

Ethiopia, as yet we have neither a comprehensive critical history of its background and development, nor a clear idea of its real geographical scale, historical significance and influence.

III. The Religious Reforms of Emperor Zara-Yaqob

- ❖ **Emperor Zara-Yaqob** (r.1434-68) took several measures to stabilize and consolidate the Orthodox Church. Accordingly:-
 - First, he **settled the conflict among the Ethiopian clergy** towards the creation of a suitable church-state union. In this regard, he **made peace with the House of Ewostatewos** by **reviving Sabbath** in the Ethiopian church and **the Ewostatian agreed to receive Holy orders** from the Ethiopian prelates.
 - He urged the clergy to **preach Christianity** in remote areas.
 - He ordered the people to observe **fasting on Wednesdays and Fridays** and get **Father Confessors**.
 - He encouraged **the establishment of a library** in every church to solve the problem of sufficient religious books. This was followed by revival of religious literature. **He himself wrote** some books like *Metsafe-Birhan*, *Metsafe-Me'lad*, *Metsafe-Sillasie*, *Metsafe-te' aqebo Mister*, etc.
 - He made some parts of *Te'amre-Maryam* translated from Arabic to Geez.

4.3. Political and Socio-Economic Dynamics in Muslim Sultanates

- ❖ A number of strong sultanates emerged since the **fourteenth century**. Trade was one of the major factors that resulted in the rise and development of those states. Trade:-
 - served not only as a major source of livelihood
 - acted as a major agent that resulted in the formation of Muslim sultanates and
 - remained a major source of conflict between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim sultanates.
- ☞ One of the **strong Muslim sultanates** that emerged along trade routes and became a center of resistance against the Christian Kingdom until the **second half of the sixteenth century** was the **Sultanate of Adal**.

4.3.1. The Rise of Adal

After its establishment, Ifat:-

- conducted a series of campaigns against its neighbouring sultanates thereby extending its hegemony over these areas.
- resisted the expansion of the Christian Kingdom.
- ☞ However, **one branch of the Walasma family**, which realized that **Ifat** was becoming **an easy target to the Christian Kingdom due to its location**, moved further to the **southeastern lowlands** and **established new and vigorous Muslim Sultanate of Adal** in the highland districts around **Harar** in **1367**.
 - The **first center** of this extended Walasma Dynasty was at a place called **Dakar**, a place located on the **southeast of Harar**. The Walasma family consolidated its power in the new center, and **began another phase of military campaigns against the frontiers of the Christian Kingdom**.
 - The **center of Adal** in 1520 changed to the city of Harar and
 - **After the defeat of Imam Ahmed**; a growing threat from a new force-the **Oromo** forced the sultanate to change its capital to Awsa in 1576/7, to the **present Afar region**.

4.3.2. Trade and the Expansion of Islam

- ❖ **Islam** spread into the **central and southwestern** parts of the Ethiopian region through:-
 - Muslim merchants and
 - Muslim preachers.
- ❖ **Trade** served as **channel for the expansion of Islam in the Muslim Sultanates** while at the same time it formed **the base of the economy** of those states.
- ❖ The **most known Muslim Sultanates** from 13th -16th century were **Ifat** (1285-1415) and **Adal** (1415-1577).
- ❖ The **main trade outlet shifted to Zeila** and the old city-states of Mogadishu, Brava, and Merca were used as ports for their hinterland. In the meantime, **for the trade in the northeast**, Massawa served as an outlet. With the revival of trade, different towns and trade centers emerged along **the route from Zeila to the interior**. Travelers' accounts and chronicles referred to these towns and ruins of mosques and residences mark the existence of market centers, which followed and served the trade coasts.

- The ruins that mark the landscape around **Jigjiga** and the highlands of **Harar** and **Charchar** attest to the market towns that served the **Zeila route**. These include **Weez-Gebeya** in western **Shewa/famous market on the Fatagar-Dawaro-Harar route**, **Suq-Wayzaro** in old Damot, **Suq-Amaja** and the very famous market center **Gandabalo** on the **Ifat-Awsa route**. **Gandabalo** was largely **inhabited by Muslim and Christian merchants** serving the kings and sultans as agents.
 - Other **big market towns** include the ones that **linked medieval Amhara with Awsa**, called **Wasel** near what is today Ware-Illu, **Qorqora/Qoreta** (north of Waldiya) and **Mandalay** in southern Tigray.
 - The **towns of Dabarwa**, the seat of the **Bahre-Negash** (“Lord of the Sea”), and **Asmara** **were the two important entrepôts of caravans** in the hinterland of Massawa.
- ☞ **Muslim states** had significant **control over trade routes that passed through Zeila** due to their geographical proximity, although **contested by “Solomonic” Kingdom** especially after its revival and consolidation.

4.4. Rivalry between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates

- **Zeila** was the main outlet to the sea during the medieval period.
- ☞ The ambition to control the **Zeila trade route** and **commodities** that passed through Zeila led to **rivalry between the “Solomonic” rulers and the Sultanate of Ifat**.
- **The first recorded conflict** between the **Christian Kingdom** and **Ifat** took place in 1328. It was because:-
- The Muslim Sultanates organized their armies to take military action against the Christian Kingdom.
 - The Sultan of Ifat, **Haqaddin I** **stopped merchants belonging to the Christian King**, Amde-Tsion, **confiscating the goods, capturing, and imprisoning the king's agent, Ti'iyintay** returning from Cairo.
- ☞ The actions taken by Haqaddin I forced Amde-Tsion to wage a campaign against Ifat in 1332. Amde-Tsion defeated the Sultan and took him prisoner and eventually replaced him by his brother **Sabradin**. Both **Ifat and Fatagar** came under **Sabradin**. The Sultanates of **Hadiya and Dawaro** **made an alliance with Sabradin**. Yet, **Ifat was defeated** and **Sabradin was captured** on his retreat. As a result, **Ifat, Fatagar and Dawaro** were incorporated. **Amde-Tsion** required from them:-
- annual tributes and
 - freedom of movement for all caravans through Zeila.
- Following the **decline of Ifat**, other Muslim Sultanates like **Sharkha, Harar, Bali, Dara, and Arbabani** were also seriously weakened. It was based on these grounds that **some members of the Walasma moved** their seat of power **further east to Adal**, from where they continued their struggle. To check their attacks on the highlands, **the successors of Emperor Amde-Tsion conducted repeated campaigns into the lowlands**. Example:-
- **In 1376, Haqadin II** came to power and refused to pay tribute and rebelled against **Neway-Maryam** (1371-80), the son of Amde-Tsion. However, he **died fighting in 1386**.
 - The successor of Haqadin II, **Sa'd ad-Din II** (C. 1386-1402) gained initial success until **king Dawit I** (r. 1380-1412) in 1402/3 extended his expansion and defeated him. **Sa'd ad-Din II** became refuge in Zeila until **King Yishaq** (r.1413-30) killed him in 1415. Since then the area was called "**the land of Sad ad-Din.**" Following the death of Sa'd ad-Din and loss of Zeila to Christian Kings, the Muslim sultanates declined in power.
 - **Sa'd ad-Din's sons** who took refuge in Yemen came back to succeed their father. Yet, Adal continued to challenge the Christian state and were **successful in killing Tewodros** (1412-13) and **Yeshaq**. This led to intense struggle for predominance.
 - During the mid-fifteenth century, **Emperor Zara Yaqob** gained some access to the Red Sea. **In 1445, Zara Yaqob** defeated **Sultan Ahmed Badlay** at the battle of **Yeguba**. As a result, the son and successor of Ahmed Badlay, **Mohammed Ahmed** (r.1445-71) sent a message of submission to **Ba'ede Mariam** (r. 1468-78) to remain vassal of the Christian Kings.
 - **On the death of Mohammed**, however, **Adal was still strong and continued its struggle**. Hence, the reigning monarch, **Ba'ede-Mariam** campaigned against Adal. Despite initial successes, **the army of Ba'ede-Mariam lost the battle in 1474**.

- ☞ The successors of **Ba'ede-Mariam** proved weak in their dealings with the rulers of Muslim Sultanates. At the same time, **leaders of the Muslim Sultanate sought to resolve the problem peacefully**. As a result, **Mohammad ibn Azhar ad-Din** (1488-1518) attempted to harmonize relations with the Christian Kingdom. However,
- among the various Sultans of the Muslim sultanates, **Emir Mahfuz** carried out some **effective military campaigns** into the highlands.
 - in 1517 **Emir Mahfuz died** fighting against **Emperor Lebne-Dengel's** (r. 1508-40) **force** and his son-in-law, **Imam Ahmed ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi**, popularly known as **Ahmed Gragn** or the **"left-handed"** took over the leadership.
- **Apart from the hostile relations**, there were **wider socio-economic and cultural interactions between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim principalities**. As in earlier periods, trade:-
- continued to be the major channel of social integration.
 - had long been the source of friendship, interaction, interdependence, and conflict among the states of the region.
 - **the long distance trade and local markets served as core areas of social ties**. Relatively, the difference in ecology of the Muslim sultanates and the Christian Kingdom created economic interdependence, which in due course strengthened socio-economic bondage. Merchants of the two regions often moved from the highlands to the coast and vice versa. It was through such caravan merchants that the social links were strengthened and religions spread. These **interactions and interdependence in economic, social, cultural and political spheres** lay the **foundation for modern Ethiopia**.

☞ Beside the above discussed **socio-cultural and economic interactions**, the period witnessed **the flourishing of Geez literature** as is evident from the works of **Abba Giorgis Ze-Gasicha** and others and **philosophies epitomized by Zara-Ya'iqob** (not to be confused with the king). **On the Muslim side**, literature had developed including the **works of Arab writers** such as **Ibn Fadil al Umari, Ibn Khaldun** and others.

4.5. External Relations

4.5.1. Relations with Egypt

- From the **late thirteenth century** onwards, Christian Kingdom continued to maintain relations with Egypt, which was mainly religious in character. In **1272, Yekuno-Amlak** sent an emissary to **Egypt's Sultan, Baybars** requesting an **Abun from the Coptic Church**. Furthermore, **both Egypt and Ethiopia continued to act as protectors of religious minorities in their respective domain**. **Egypt** also wanted to **ensure secure flow of the Nile** (the Abay River) that originated from Ethiopia.
- In the **early fourteenth century**,
- **Mohammed ibn Qala'un** persecuted the Copts and destroyed their churches in Cairo. In response, **Amde-Tsion** demanded the **restoration of the churches** and warned that the failure to do so would result in **the diversion of the Nile waters**.
 - **Patriarch Marqos** (1348- 63) sent a message to **Sayfa-Arad** (r.1344-71), revealing his imprisonment by the then Egyptian Sultan. **Sayfa-Arad** is said to have mobilized a huge army against Egypt after which **the Sultan** released the patriarch and sent a delegation to the King.
 - Besides, **Patriarch Matewos** (1328-1408) delegated by the Sultan, established harmonious relations between **King Dawit and Egypt**. The Sultan is said to have sent a piece of the **"True Cross"** and in return, Dawitis said to have given a **number of religious paintings** to the Sultan.
 - In 1437/8, **Zara-Yaqob** wrote a friendly letter to **Sultan Barsbay** requesting the protection of Christians in Egypt. **Three years later**, however, **Patriarch Yohannes XI** wrote **Zara-Yaqob** a letter stating the **demolition of the famous church of Mitmaq (Debre-Mitmaq)**. Then **Zara-Yaqob** sent an envoy to **Sultan Jaqmaq** (1438-53) with a strongly worded letter. In reply to this message, **Jaqmaq** sent an envoy to Ethiopia, with **complimentary gifts** to the King but **rejected the reconstruction of the church**.

4.5.2. Relations with Christian Europe

- As with the Muslim Arab world, the Christian Kingdom maintained relations with **Christian Europe**. During the medieval period, contacts between the two regions were strongly influenced by **the legend of “Prester John”**. This was followed by sustained relations in subsequent decades. For example,
- It is stated that Ethiopian delegation was in attendance of Gian Galeazzo Visconti’s coronation in **Milan** in 1395.
 - In **1418**, three Ethiopians attended the Council of Constance. In another report, message from an Ethiopian monarch, Amde-Tsion was presented to King Phillip of France in 1332.
 - The earliest known message to Ethiopia from a European monarch is the letter of King Henry IV of England dated **1400 A.D.** and addressed to “**Prester John**”, the **purported** king of the Christian Kingdom. The identification of the King with “**Prester John**” was firmly established in the **fourteenth century**. They even thought that it was possible to liberate Jerusalem with the help of this King. Hence, during the **reign of King Dawit**, the leaders of Rome, Constantinople, Syria, Armenia and Egypt sent letters to the king in which they asked for support. **King Dawit** received some **Italian craftsmen** consisting mainly of **Florentines**. In **1402**, King Dawit sent his first delegation to Europe led by a **Florentine man** called Antonio Bartoli.
 - **Alphonso de Paiva V of Aragon** received a delegation from Yishaq in the **city of Valentia**, in **1427**. **Yishaq’s** delegation to Europe was to ask for more artisans and military experts. The **embassy of the Duke of Berry** consisting craftsmen, Neapolitan Pietro, a Spaniard and a Frenchman reached Ethiopia during the reign of Yishaq.
 - In **1450** a Silican Pietro Rombulo, who had been in Ethiopia since **the last years of Dawit's reign** and who had previously carried out a successful trade mission to **India** on behalf of the King, was now sent to Europe as **Zara-Yaqob’s ambassador**. An Ethiopian priest, Fikre-Mariam and two other individuals accompanied him. The mission was to Alphonso of Aragon, (also ruled as king of **Naples and Sicily**). **King Zara-Yaqob** sent delegates to **Alphonso** to get political, military, and technical assistance. **Alphonso** wrote a letter to **Zara- Yaqob** and informed him that he sent him artisans and masons he requested.
 - The **most authentic pieces of evidence** on Ethio-Europe links are the **maps of Egyptus Novelo** (c. 1454) and **Fra Mauro's Mappomondo** (1460) which clearly depicted many places and peoples. **Venetian Gregorio or Hieronion Bicini** visited Ethiopia in **1482**.
 - Pedros da Covilhao/Peter de Covilham arrived at court of Eskindir (1478-1494) in **1493**.
- ☞ The beginning and continued rivalry between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates in the **fifteenth century** strengthened the relation between the Christian Kingdom and Christian Europe. **Queen Eleni** (the daughter of **Hadiya Garad** and married to King **Zara Yaeqob**) played an important role in the strengthening of these relations. **Queen Eleni, the mother and regent of Lebne-Dingil:-**
- Had foreseen the threat that came from the **Ottoman Turkish** who showed a clear interest to support the Muslim Sultanates.
 - Had foreseen the possibility to consolidate relations with and get support from Portugal that was against the Turkish. In **1508**, Portugal sent a person to act as an ambassador to Christian Ethiopia.
 - Sent an **Armenian** called **Mathew** to Portugal around **1512**. The Portuguese court doubted his authenticity and was received coldly. The Portuguese Embassy led by Rodrigo di Lima, Duwarto Galliba and Francisco Alvarez reached Ethiopia in **1520** and remained for six years. The **objective** was **to establish a naval port against the expanding Turkish power in Red Sea Area**. The mission was not successful.

UNIT FIVE

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIAL PROCESSES FROM THE EARLY SIXTEENTH TO THE END OF THE EITEENTH CENTURIES

5.1. Conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal and After

- ❖ The revival of long-distance trade caused **competition and struggle for control over the trade routes between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim principalities**. This was followed by a **series of wars**, which were depicted as **wars for religious supremacy in historical accounts of Christian and Muslim clerics**. While **mal-administration** and **exploitation of periphery** made military mobilization possible, **religion** provided **ideological justification for the wars**. However, **the interest to control trade routes** lay at the heart of the conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates that continued for over two centuries, culminating in the **wars between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal that lasted from 1529 to 1543**.
- ❖ As a prelude to this conflict, among the Muslim Sultanates, internal strife, corruption and anarchy was intensified and a new leadership was urgently called for. Such leadership came from **Imam Ahmed Ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi**. The **origins of Imam Ahmed**, alias “the left-handed,” are **obscure**. Ahmed Gragn was:
 - **born at Hubet** in between Dire Dawa and Jigjiga and raised by his devout Muslim kin in one of the oases on the route to Zeila.
 - a rigorous and **ardent believer of Islam**.
 - soldiered for **Garad Abun** of Adal, who during his few years in power called for Islamic Puritanism.
- ❖ According to local tradition, **the Imam withdrew** to the countryside, upon the death of his source of inspiration, **Garad Abun**, and started calling for devotion to the teachings of Islam. Here came fundamental change in the cause of the confrontations. After Imam Ahmad’s rise to power under circumstances discussed above, the battles were not just fought for control of the long-distance trade route going through **Zeila** but mainly because there was a **demographic pressure among the Afar and Somali pastoralists** pushing to **approach Harar and the Christian Kingdom**. For centuries, lowland inhabiting Muslim pastoralists had wanted to expand to high plateaus for better and enough pasturelands and attempted to do so but only to be held back by the Christian army. **With increased population and overgrazing in Somali and Afar of eastern Ethiopia**, between **the thirteenth and sixteenth centuries**, raiding and counter-raiding at water holes or animal rustling intensified.
- ❖ It was one of the **Imam’s remarkable achievements in leadership** that **he mobilized** the pastoral communities of **the Afar, the Somali, the Harla, Harari** and others to a common cause. **He convinced them not to fight amongst themselves but to unite and expand to the Christian Kingdom** and resolve their pressing material needs while at the same time keep Islamic believes and practices from the infiltration of any alien religious doctrine. He was able to **gain audience** as Imam and **consolidated his army to fight the Christian Kingdom**.
- ❖ Meanwhile, **Lebne-Dengel** (1508-1540) was enthroned when he was only **eleven**. **Assisted** by the **elderly Elleni** and **due to internal conflicts in Adal**, the Christian state initially retained its interest and even advanced into Muslim territory scoring significant victories **in the early sixteenth century**. As a result, **most of the Muslim Sultanates including Adal were made tributaries** to the Christian Kingdom.
- ❖ However, shortly, **Adal fell to Imam Ahmed’s army**. By the time Imam Ahmed was strong enough for military confrontation:
 - in **1520**, he refused to pay tribute
 - he campaigned against the Christian Kingdom in **1527**. The Imam’s army fought fiercely and controlled the territories including **Bali, Dawaro, Fatagar, Sidama, Hadiya and Kambata** and **the Christian Kingdom was at risk**.
- ❖ In **1528**, realizing the upcoming threat, **Lebne-Dengel** mobilized a vast force from his domain and **encamped about fifty kilometers east of what is now Addis Ababa**. During this time:-
 - The Christian kingdom had **the problem of logistics and the leadership of the army** of the Kingdom **failed to adopt a common strategy** to defeat Adal’s force.

- On the other hand, enthusiastic Imam Ahmed's army **managed logistics problems with its small-sized army**. The Imam's army had also an **excellent leadership** characterized by **better mobility and flexible tactics** with a unified command.
- ☞ Due to the above-mentioned reasons, the larger and well-equipped Christian army was defeated in one of the most decisive engagement **at the battle of Shimbra Kure in 1529**, near present day **Mojo**. After the victory,
- The Imam's army made a **large-scale control of the territories** of the Christian Kingdom including **Shewa, Amhara, Lasta**, and moved as far north as **Mereb Melash**.
 - By 1535, Imam Ahmed's empire stretched **from Zeila to Massawa** on the coast including the Ethiopian interior.
 - As he penetrated deep into the Christian Kingdom, Imam Ahmed **established a civil administrative bureaucracy** constituted from **his own men and newly recruited personnel from the Christian territories**.
- ❖ One of the most illuminating figures during the war was **the wife of the Imam, Bati Del Wanbara**. She:-
- Was **the daughter** of a Muslim **military commander of Adal** known as **Mahfuz**.
 - Had **encouraged her husband** to **avenge the death of her father** (as traditions claimed).
 - Accompanied her husband throughout his expeditions and she is said to have marched even in a state of pregnancy during which she was unable to use mules. Indeed, she **delivered her two sons** during the campaigns of **1531 and 1533** in **Ifat** and **present day Tigray** respectively.
- ❖ On the part of the Christian Kingdom,
- The military set back forced the reigning king, **Lebne-Dengel**, to retreat who finally **died in 1540** being fugitive.
 - Lebne-Dengel's son, **Gelawdewos (r. 1540-1559)**, ascended to the throne who continued to face the wars this time with more intensity as **Imam Ahmed had received Turkish musketeers**.
 - In the meantime, **based on earlier request made by Lebne-Dengel in 1535, about four hundred Portuguese soldiers**, armed with **matchlocks** arrived in the Christian court in 1541. The army was **led by Christopher da Gama, the youngest son of Vasco da Gama**. However, **in August 1542 the Christian army was defeated in Ofla**, in today's **southern Tigray**. In the battle, **about two hundred Portuguese** and their leader **Christopher da Gama were killed** and the leader was **beheaded**.
- ❖ **Lebne-Dengel's wife, Seblewongel**:-
- ☞ Was said to have **participated in the war** against **Imam Ahmed in 1542** when the army of the Christian Kingdom lost almost half of the Portuguese soldiers and their commander **Christopher Da Gama**.
- ❖ After the success, **Imam Ahmed was confident about his army's ability to repulse any future attack** by the force of the Christian Kingdom that he sent his allies back home and let his army camp. **On the part of the Christians, preparations were made for final confrontation** under the **leadership of Emperor Gelawdewos** (r.1540-59). **The Queen mother, Seble-Wongel, advised the reigning emperor** how to prepare and march for the **battle of Woyna-Dega**. During this period:-
- Due to **limited resources**, **the monarch employed hit and run strategy**, which severely affected Imam's army.
 - **Imam Ahmed's army could not use its previous quality** of easy mobility because they did not know where the attacks came from.
 - **On February 25, 1543** while **Imam Ahmed** was encamped **near Lake Tana**, **he was attacked and killed** after a fierce fighting **at the battle of Woyna-Dega**.
- ❖ Soon after the battle,
- **Gelawdewos was confident that the nobility and his army were loyal to him**. As a result, the king restored possession of almost all the northern and central plateau.

- **Muslim communities** in the highlands **submitted to Gelawdewos** and **he was tolerant toward them to promote national conciliation** and to **develop revival of smooth relations with the Muslim world**.
 - Gelawdewos was **able to restore many of pre-1520s territories and tributary regions**.
 - Gelawdewos **attempted to reconsolidate the state through campaigns to different areas and camping Chewa (regiment)** in border areas.
 - Gelawdewos had established a strong Christian Kingdom by the early 1550s. However, the control over the Muslim dominated areas was not an easy task.
- ❖ In the period, the growing challenge to the Christian state came from the:
- retreating soldiers of the Sultanate of Adal,
 - Ottoman Turks,
 - Jesuit interlude, and
 - Oromo that advanced into the center.
- ❖ **Adal** under the leadership of **Nur Ibn al-Waazir Mujahid** was ready to wage war against the Christian state for revenge. In 1559, the forces of Emir Nur **confronted Gelawdewos and killed the king himself**.
- ❖ **Emperor Minas (r.1559-1563)** who **succeeded Gelawdewos** defeated the **Turks' force** and reclaimed territories in **the coast including Dabarwa**. However, in the early 1560s, **Yishaq revolted and allied with the Turks against him**.
- ❖ Similarly, **Sartsa-Dengle (r.1563-1598)** had to **defend the Turks** while **fighting with the Agaw, Gumuz, Bete-Israel, Sidama, Enarya and the Oromo**. The emperor **then marched to the north, defeated Turkish forces, and restored the territories**.
- ❖ Consequences the Muslim-Christian conflict.

On the negative side

- Huge human and material cost.
- Destruction of the royal prison Amba Gishen
- Both the Muslim Sultanate and Christian Kingdom were weakened thereby paving the way for an easy infiltration and success of the Oromo population movement.

On the positive side the war resulted in:-

- Cultural interaction (Linguistic and religious interactions) among the peoples of Ethiopia.
- Intermarriages among peoples of the various cultural groups

☞ **Competition for supremacy over the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean** between **Portugal** and the **Ottoman Turks** gave the prolonged conflict between the **Christian Kingdom and the Muslim principalities** a global dimension. **Persians, Arabs, Syrians, Egyptians, and Turks**, traditional international trade intermediaries, who were under Ottoman Turks were hit by discovery of a seaway to **India** by **Vasco da Gama** in 1498 and tried to prevent rival Portuguese ships from trading with India. Therefore,

- **Portugal** looked up to the Christian kingdom as an ally and started the old “semi-spiritual quest” for **Prester John**. From the first decade of the century, **messengers were being sent**. However, **actual military alliance did not take place** because Ethiopia was not a sea power to give sensible maritime support to **Portugal against the Ottoman Turks**.
- On its part, the Christian Kingdom had asked **Portugal's military assistance against its Muslim rival**.
- **The Turks** on their part **gave moral and military support to Imam Ahmed**. In 1540, **the Imam** turned to his Muslim ally, **Turkey**, for assistance and regional Ottoman authorities **provided two hundred Muslim musketeers and ten cannons**.

5.2. Foreign Intervention and Religious Controversies

- ❖ As with the state, **the church** was weakened by **the wars against the sultanate of Adal**.

- The **destruction of property and deaths of its clergy** hampered the operation of the Church and therefore, its service as an ideological arm of the state. At the same time, **the monarchy** could not count on the traditional **political and military apparatus** to withstand the **continued expansion of the Oromo deep into the Christian Kingdom** and then to **consolidate the Christian Kingdom**. Thus, revival was sought **in the church**.
- ❖ The **rulers of the Christian Kingdom** may have regarded **an alliance with Roman Catholicism** as a tactic to **secure sufficient modern weaponry and training** to restore its lost territories.
 - In 1557, several Jesuit missionaries along with their bishop, **Andreas de Oviedo**, came to Ethiopia to **expand Catholicism**. The Jesuits promoted Catholic doctrine of two different and therefore separate, **natures of Christ—divine and human**, which was contrary to **Monophysite theology** of Ethiopian Orthodox Church. EOC taught that Christ, through **union or Tewahedo** **had a perfect human nature inseparable from divinity**.
 - The **leading members of the Jesuit mission** who played key role in efforts to evangelize the country include **Joao Bermudez, Andreas de Oviedo, Pedro Paez and Alfonso Mendez**.
- ❖ **The Jesuits evangelical efforts:-**
 - Began with **Emperor Gelawdewos (r.1540-59)**, hoping that the rest of the society would follow suit. Gelawdewos listened and engaged in doctrinal debates with the missionaries, but he was not prepared to give in. Instead, **he defended the teachings of Orthodox Christianity in a document** entitled the **Confession of Faith**.
 - **Minas and Sertse-Dengel**, who succeeded Gelawdewos one after the other, were too busy fighting against **the Oromo and the Turkish forces** to entertain the Jesuits in their courts.
 - The Jesuits got relative success with **Emperor Za-Dengel (r. 1603-4)** who secretly converted to Catholicism. But **Za-Dengel's reign** was too short for the Jesuits to effect the desired result. **Za-Dengel was overthrown by Yaqob (r. 1598-1603; 1604-7)**, who befell a similar fate in the hands of **Susenyos (r. 1607-32)**.
 - **Susenyos**, too, as was challenged by provincial leaders who refused to pay tribute, integrated **the Oromo with the forces of central government** to consolidate his power and **then stabilize the country**. Probably as a means to this, Susenyos sought for an **alliance**, which he got through the diplomatic advisory of **Pedro Paez**.
 - ✚ In 1612, Susenyos converted to Catholicism
 - ✚ In 1622, Susenyos announced it to be state religion.
- ☞ In the meantime, in 1617-1618 **several anti-Catholic voices** mounted following the **changes in liturgy and religious practices**. Even worse, with the monarch's consent, another Spanish Jesuit, **Afonso Mendez:-**
 - ordered **reconsecration of Orthodox priests** and **deacons** and **rebaptism of the mass**.
 - called for **the suspension/prohibition/ of Jewish customs** such as **male circumcision** and **the observance of the Sabbath**.
 - pronounced the **prohibition of preaching in Ge'ez, fasting on Wednesdays and Fridays, reverence for Ethiopian saints and the Ark of Covenant (Tabot)**.
 - **ordered eating pork, Latin Mass and Gregorian calendar to be adopted**.
- ☞ The above reforms **led to revolts** led by **the ecclesiastics/priests/clergyman/ and the nobility**. Even **loyal followers of the emperor** including **his own son Fasiledas (r. 1632-67)** were opposed to the changes initiated by the Jesuits.
- ❖ **After 1625**, controversies, rebellions, repressions mounted and the state came to the verge of falling apart.
- ❖ **In a battle in June 1632**, large number of **peasants lost their lives** in one day. **Finally, the emperor abdicated the throne in favor of Fasiledas**, who countered the Catholic transformation. **Fasiledas:-**
 - **restored the position of Orthodox Church as the state religion**,
 - **expelled the Jesuits and punished local converts** including Susenyos' uncle and the most fervent supporter of Catholicism, **Se'ela Kristos**.

- introduced a new policy called "Close-Door Policy", which isolated the state from all Europeans for about a century and a half. He did this by fearing another religious conflict. Conversely, **he initiated and adopted a policy of close diplomatic relations with the Islamic world** and formed an **alliance with the neighboring Muslim states** to ensure that no European crossed into the Christian Kingdom. As a result, **in 1647, he concluded an agreement with the Ottoman Pasha at Suakin and Massawa** to the effect that the latter should block any European from entering in to his territory.
- ☞ By putting into practice the above measures, **Fasiledas was able to restore peace and order.**
- ☞ Ethiopia's diplomatic break from Europe **remained effective** until the beginning of the nineteenth century with the exception of secret visits by a French Doctor **Charles Jacques Poncet** and the Scottish traveler **James Bruce** in **1700** and **1769**, respectively.
- ❖ Yet, the Jesuit intervention **triggered doctrinal divisions and controversy** within the Ethiopian Orthodox Church that was **divided into disputant sects** and reached its peak during the **Zemene Mesafint**. These disputant sects were:-
 - **Tewahedo teaches Hulet Lidet (two births) of Christ:** first in eternity as a Divine Being the eternal birth and second, born again from St. Mary into the world as **a perfect man and perfect divinity united in one nature**, thus **Tewahedo (United)**. It was **dominant in Tigray and Lasta**.
 - **Qibat (Unction)** was also developed from **Hulet Lidet doctrine** and accepted the **eternal birth as the first birth of Christ**, but claimed that at **the moment of his incarnation**, when he was born into the world, **Holy Ghost anointed him**. This sect was **dominant in Gojjam**.
 - **Sost Lidet/Three Births (Ya Tsega Lij/Son through Grace)** taught that Christ was **first born in eternity as divine being, was born again in the womb of St. Mary** and **anointed by Holy Ghost**. This sect was **dominant in Gonder and Shawa**.

5.3. Population Movements

- ❖ The movements of people from one place to another have played important roles in shaping the history of Ethiopia and the Horn.
- ❖ As far back sources tell, population movements occurred in the Horn due to **various reasons, in varied scales and followed different directions**. People moved from place to place **due to pull and push factors**, which can be summed up as **natural and social**. Specifically, people move out from their **habitats in search of resources and better living environment** in general.

☞ In Ethiopia and the Horn, the causes of the movements could be attributed to **the region's long socio-political conditions** involving **military conflicts, drought and demographic factors**.

- ❖ Population movements of **the medieval period** had extensive effects including **the integration of peoples across ethnic and religious lines**. Major outcomes of population movements during the period under consideration include:-
 - Religious, ethnic and linguistic interactions and
 - Intermingling of peoples (this resulted in intermarriage of peoples, change of abode, original culture and evolution of new identities.)

5.3.1. Population Movements of the Argoba, Afar, and Somali

- ❖ The **military conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal** in the **late fifteenth and the early sixteenth centuries** was partly responsible for the population movement of the **Argoba, Afar and Somali**. In addition, **the demographic pressure** on environment gave background for the population movement. Their territories lay in the region where trade routes passed and hence were affected by the consequences of the **military conflict**. These peoples moved back and forth in response to the ongoing military conflict.
- **The Argoba:**

- The Argoba were major **agents of Islamic expansion, trade and Muslim state formation** in the Horn. **For instance**, the **sultanate of Shewa** and **Ifat** were established by the Makhzumite and Walasma Dynasties respectively.
- Towards the **end of the thirteenth century**, the sultanate of Shewa moved further to the east as the result of the pressure from the Christian Kingdom. **The sultanate of Ifat**, in which the Argoba were dominant, became the **center of Muslim resistance**.
- On the **eve of the wars of Imam Ahmed al Ghazi**, **the Argoba joined the Afar and the Somali against the Christian Kingdom**.
- The **area inhabited by the Argoba** was also a **target of the expanding Christian Kingdom and was the major center of conflict**. This was because **the major caravan trade routes passed through Argoba territory**. As a result, the Christian-Muslim rivalry and the conflicts thereof led to the destruction of sultanates and dispersion of the people. The enduring effect of the conflict can be observed from the fragmented settlement patterns of the people.

➤ The Afar:

- Before the sixteenth century, **due to drought**, the Afar moved towards the east until they reached the middle Awash.
- **Trade routes** linking the ports in the Horn passed through the Afar's territory. As a result, the **region was the centre of competition between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim sultanates to control the trade routes**. Besides being **actors in the conflict**, the conflict inevitably **pressurized the Afar to move into different directions** to avoid the risk of the conflicts. **In the sixteenth century**, their pastoral economy helped them to **survive the destructive effects of the wars**.

➤ The Somali:

- Their territory laid in the medieval competition for the control of trade routes.
- Prior to the wars of **Imam Ahmed al Ghazi**, there was strong demographic pressure from the Somali. The population movement of the Somali was **a strong force behind the military strength of the Imam**. However, **the population movement of the Somali did not last for long** as they returned to their home base following the defeat of Imam Ahmed in 1543.

5.3.2. Gadaa System and Oromo Population Movement (1522-1618)

A. The Gadaa System

- ❖ The Oromo population movement of the sixteenth century cannot be better understood without considering the *Gadaa* system. The *Gadaa* system was an institution through which the Oromo socially:-
 - organized themselves,
 - administered their affairs,
 - defended their territories,
 - maintained law and order, and
 - managed their economies.
- ❖ Studies do not clearly indicate when and how the *Gadaa* system emerged. However, it is clear that for long the society organized **their politics, economy, social, cultural, and religious affairs** through the *Gadaa* institution.
 - ⌚ **The account by Abba Bahrey** indicates that during **the early sixteenth century**, the system fully functioned because of which the Oromo were well organized. Thus, it is reasonable to think that **the Oromo had practiced the Gadaa system long before the sixteenth century movement of the Oromo**.
- ❖ Recent studies based on the **Gadaa calendar** and **Gadaa centers** suggest that **the system evolved from the earlier Cushitic age-set social organization**. Time computation and recording history was based on **the eight-year segment of time**. In the system,
 - **eight years** represented **one Gadaa** period,
 - **5-gadaa periods** or **40 years** represented **one generation** and **nine generations** represented **an era**.

☞ **The earliest eras of Gadaa** but still obscure were those of ***Bidiri Dhoqqe***. Prior to the beginning of ***Gadaa Borana-Barentu*** around **1450 AD**, the Oromo passed through known eras of ***Taya, Tasaa,***

Munyo, Suftu, Maddile, Abroji, Dhittacha and Warra Daye (warden), each of which survived for an era.

- ❖ **Gadaa** was interrupted and revitalized during various eras because of various internal and external factors. For instance, the Borana-Barentu *Gadaa* was instituted after interruption for nearly two generations. It was revived in 1450 at **Madda Walabu** that became the **central Chaffe (assembly)** and **seat of the senior Qallu** until 1900.
- ❖ The *Gadaa* system **constituted elements of democracy** such as periodic succession and power sharing to prevent a one-man rule. Other principles of the system included **representation of all lineages, clans and confederacies**. It also served as a mechanism of **socialization, education, maintenance of peace and order, and social cohesion**. In addition, *Gadaa* constituted **rules of arara** (conflict resolution), *guma* (compensation) and *rakoo* (marriage).
- ❖ The *Gadaa* system organized the Oromo society into **age-grades** and **generation sets** delineating members' social, political, and economic responsibilities. In the system, **ten age-grades** and **five classes operated in parallel**. The system:-
 - ✚ provided a socio-political framework that institutionalized relationship between seniors and juniors and egalitarian relations among members of a grade.
 - ✚ helped the members of age-sets to develop a consistent and stable sense of self and others. **Sons joined the first grade** as members of **Gadaa class (generation class or set) forty years after their fathers** and were initiated into the next higher grade every eight years. The following table shows a common version of **age-grades** and roles associated to them.

Table IV: Age grades and their roles

Gadaa-grades	Ages	Roles
Dabale	birth-8 years	Socialization
Game	9-16	
Folle	17-24	military training, agriculture etc
Qondala	25-32	military service
Raba-Dori	33-40	candidates for political power
Luba/Gada	41-48	leaders of <i>Gadaa</i> government
Yuba	49-80	senior advisors, educators and ritual leaders

Source: Gada Melba, *Oromiya* (Khartoum, 1988), p. 11.

- ❖ In the Gada system:-
 - The *gadaa/luba* assumed power for eight years.
 - The head of the government was known as **Abba-Gadaa** literally “father of the period”
 - The **Abba Gada** was assisted by several elected representatives from among the generation set. These included:-
 - ✓ *Abba Bokku* (father of scepter),
 - ✓ *Abba Chaffe* (head of the assembly),
 - ✓ *Abba-Dula* (war leader),
 - ✓ *Abba Sera* (father of law),
 - ✓ *Abba Alanga* (judge),
 - ✓ *Abba Sa'a* (father of treasury) and other councilors.
 - The **senior Qallu (Abba Muda)** played indispensable roles in power transfer and legitimizing the ruling *gadaa* class.
 - **Women maintained their rights** by the **Sinqe institution**, which helped them to form sisterhood and solidarity. Women from childhood to old age i.e.
 - ✓ *guduru* (pre-pubescent),
 - ✓ *qarre* (adolescent, ready for marriage),
 - ✓ *kalale* (wives of *Luba* and *Yuba*) and

- ✓ **cifire** (wives of *Gadamojji*/above 80 years) were **believed to have sacred power**. They **involved in occasions like power transfer, conflict resolution, thanks-giving and others**. The ***kalale*** were also **privileged to support and advise the ruling class**.

- ❖ The ***Gadaa*** system functioned by the **cyclical power transfer from one *Gadaa* class to the next every eight years**. With some minor differences in nomenclature in different parts of Oromo territories, the five ***Gadaa*** classes (**generation sets**) are listed below:

Table V. The five *Gada* classes/parties/generation sets/

Fathers	Sons
<i>Melba</i>	<i>Harmufa</i>
<i>Mudena</i>	<i>Robale</i>
<i>Kilole</i>	<i>Birmajii</i>
<i>Bifole</i>	<i>Mul'ata</i>
<i>Michille</i>	<i>Dulo</i>

Source: C.F. Beckingham and G.W.B. Huntingford trans. and eds. *Some Records of Ethiopia, 1593-1646* (London: Hakluyt Society, 1954).

B. The Oromo Population Movement (1522-1618)

- ❖ A combination of **natural and manmade factors** caused **the Oromo population movement of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries**.
 - **Natural factors** include **demographic pressure and subsequent need for land** to accommodate the growing human and livestock population.
 - **Manmade factor** was **the conflict between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates from the thirteenth to the sixteenth centuries** might have pressurized mainly pastoral Oromo groups to leave the lands they inhabited for other areas.
- ❖ In 1522, when **the population movement began**, the Oromo were already organized **under Borana and Barentu confederacies**. The Oromo forces **took northern direction** and passed through a corridor between **Mount Walabu and Lake Abbaya**. **When they reached half way between Lakes Abbaya and Hawassa**, they **took westward** and **penetrated across the Bilatte River** to the southwest. Then they **headed northwards to the lakes region of the Rift Valley**.
- ❖ From 1522 to 1618, the Oromo **fought twelve Butta wars.**(a war carried to conquer new areas that did not occupied by their predecessors). Accordingly,
 - The **first *Gadaa* i.e *Melba*** (1522-1530) fought and defeated Christian regiment **Batra Amora** led by **Fasil** and occupied Bali
 - The ***Gadaa Mudena*** (1530-8) reached the edge of Awash River.
 - The ***Kilole Gadaa*** (1538-46) controlled Dawaro after defeating Christian regiment **Adal Mabraq**
 - The ***Bifole*** (1546-54) advanced to Waj and Erer.
 - The ***Michille*** (1554-62) scored victory over **Hamalmal's force** at Dago, and **Jan Amora forces** as well as Adal led by Emir Nur Mujahiddin at Mount Hazalo.
 - The ***Harmufa*** (1562-70) fought Minas (r.1559-63) at Qacina and Wayyata; occupied Angot, Ganzyi, Sayint etc.
 - In 1574, Sartsa Dingil's (r.1563-97) cavalry led by **Azzaj Halibo** defeated ***Robale gadaa*** (1570-78) at Woyna Daga, but Robale recovered by defeating **Zara'a Yohannis' force**.
 - The ***Birmaji*** (1578-86) controlled Ar'ine in Waj, crossed Jama to Wolaqa and overwhelmed the Daragoti regiment.
 - The ***Mul'ata*** (1586-94) seized Damot, Bizamo, Gafat, Dambiya and Tigray.
 - In the early seventeenth century, the ***Dulo*** (1594-1602), ***Melba*** (1603-10), and ***Mudena*** (1610-18) expanded to West and Northern parts of the Horn of Africa while others like the **Warday** moved to **Kenya** and **Bur Haqaba** and **Majertin** in **Somalia**.
- ☞ In addition to the wars between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates, the organization of the Oromo under the *Gadaa* system played crucial role in the success of the Oromo population movement.

- ❖ In the course of their movement into various regions, different Oromo branches established **Gadaa centers**. Accordingly,
 - **Oda Nabee** of Tulama,
 - **Oda Roba** of Sikko-Mando (Arsi),
 - **Oda Bultum** of Itu-Humabenna,
 - **Oda Bisil** of Mecha and
 - **Oda Bulluq** of Jawwi Mecha became major *Gadaa* centers.
- ✚ Other places, which became Gadaa centers, were
 - **Gayo** of Sabbo-Gona,
 - **Me'e Bokko** of Guji,
 - **Oda Dogi** of Ilu,
 - **Oda Hulle** of Jimma,
 - **Oda Garado** of Waloo, etc.
 - *Gadaa* leaders such as **Dawe Gobbo** of **Borana**, **Anna Sorra** of **Guji**, **Makko-Bili** of **Mecha**, **Babbo Koyye** of **Jimma** and others established *Gadaa* centers and laid down **cardinal laws** in their respective areas.
- ☞ However, various Oromo groups kept their relations through the office of **Abba Muda** (the father of anointment) **seated at Madda Walabu** and formed alliances during times of difficulty. Besides, they obeyed similar **ada (culture)** and **sera (law)** through **sending their delegates to Madda-Walabu**, the **central chaffe** until the **pan-Oromo** assembly was forbidden in 1900 due to the political influence of the Ethiopian state.
- In due course, *Gadaa* devised **effective resource allocation formula including land holding system** to regulate resource and their interaction among different clans is known as the **qabiyye system**. The system established **rights of precedence (seniority)** in possession of land. Accordingly, **place names** were **given the names of the pioneer** as a marker of **qabiyye rights**.

5.4. Interaction and Integration across Ethnic and Religious Diversities

- ❖ The **political, social, and economic** processes of the **medieval period** were the major factors for the people's interactions across regions. **Such interactions occurred during peace and conflict times**. The cases in point were:-
 - the trade contacts and conflicts to control trade routes,
 - religious expansion, and
 - territorial expansion and population movements.
- ❖ One of the **major consequences of the interactions in the medieval period** particularly in the **population movement of the sixteenth century** was **the integration of peoples across ethnic and religious diversities** in Ethiopia and the Horn. **Population movement** of the period:-
 - relatively covered extensive geographical areas in the region.
 - involved diverse ethnic groups, cultures, and religions from south to north and from east to west.
- ❖ It is apparent that **territorial and religious expansion** by the Christian kingdom diffused Christian tradition **from north to the south**.
- ❖ The **Wars of Imam Ahmed** and **the population movements of the Argoba, the Afar and the Somali** **caused the expansion of Islam into the central parts of Ethiopia**.
- ❖ The other consequences of the Oromo population movement:-
 - It put an end to **the wars between the Christian and Muslim states** as well as **the southward expansion of the Christian state**.
 - At larger scale, **the Oromo contact with diverse peoples in the sixteenth century** brought **far-reaching integrations among peoples** across ethnic and religious background. That is:-
 - ☞ The Oromo integrated **non-Oromo** through **two adoption mechanisms: *Guddifacha* and *Moggasa***.

- **Guddifacha** refers to **the adoption of a child by a foster parent**. In this system, the child enjoyed equal rights and privileges with a biological child.
- **Moggasa**
 - was a **system of adopting non-Oromos commonly known as Oromsu**.
 - was the practice of incorporation of individuals or groups to a clan through oath of allegiance with all the rights and obligations that such membership entailed.
 - was **undertaken by the Abba Gadaa on behalf of the clan**. The adopted groups **gained both protection and material benefits**. The process significantly contributed to **the social cohesions, national integration, and the revival of long-distance trade**.
- ❖ The interactions also resulted in an **exchange of socio-cultural values and institutions**. A number of peoples in the neighborhood of the Oromo **adopted Gadaa system and Oromo language**. Likewise, the Oromo **adopted and adapted** cultures and traditions of the people with whom they came into contact. Example:-
 - the **adoption** of monarchical systems and the **integration of the Oromo to the Christian and Muslim states**.
 - the **rise of nobles in the northern Oromo in politics** particularly during the **Gondar period, Zemene-Mesafint and the making of modern Ethiopia**.

5.5. Peoples and States in Eastern, Central, Southern and Western Regions

It is **not possible** in the space of a brief teaching module such as this to provide an exhaustive detail of societies and states in **eastern, central, southern, and western parts of the country** in the period covered by this unit. Thus, this section explores **the history of some of the states (as illustrations)** in the period under consideration. Although **there was no one criterion used to select the states**, **due regard has been given to balance the number of states** selected from each region mentioned above. The selection of states for discussion also **considered availability of sources and treatment in earlier sections**.

5.5.1. Peoples and States in the East

Somali

The Somali people:-

- have inhabited vast territory in the Horn.
- practiced pastoral economy for long and moved between places for centuries possibly in search of sufficient pasture.
- were lived south of their present territory at least as early as the twelfth century or thirteenth century. **Ibn Said (1214-86), an Arab geographer**, noted that **Merca town** located in the **southern Somali coast** near **Shabele River** was a capital that brought large number of Somalis together during the thirteenth century.
- **The songs celebrating King Yeshaq's** (r. 1413-30) military success depicts that **the Somali lived close to the Christian Kingdom**.
- **Somali contingents** also **played notable role** in the **victories of the Sultanate of Adal** against the Christian kingdom.
- **The Somali** were governed by a council known as *shir*. The decision making process was highly democratic in which **all-adult male** were allowed equal access and participation. These councils at **sub-clan, clan and inter-clan level** provided a governing structure that acted as an enforcement of **law and justice**. The **council governed wide-ranging affairs** including:-
 - ✓ resource allocation,
 - ✓ marriage,
 - ✓ trade and
 - ✓ crime.
- As a component of *shir*, the **quurti** (a council of elders) was the **highest political council** mandated with **resolving conflict and crisis**.

Afar

- ❖ The Afar people:-

- predominantly have lived in northeastern Ethiopia and in northern Djibouti, although some have also inhabited southern part of Eritrea.
- had an **indigenous governance system** known as Makabanto, which has some elements of democracy.
- were **first mentioned** by Ibn Said under the name "Danakil". During the thirteenth century, they occupied the lowland territory near **Bab el-Mandeb**.
- ❖ Along with the Somali and other adjacent Muslim population, **Afar land**, which was associated with medieval Adal Sultanate, was home for many historical cities such as Maduna and Abasa.
- ❖ Following the collapse of the power of Sultanate of Adal in the **sixteenth century**, the Afar established **their sultanates** like Awsa, Girrifo, Tadjourah, Rahaito and Gobad.

☞ The Awsa Sultanate:-

- **Awsa Sultanate** succeeded the earlier **Imamate of Awsa** in the **middle Awash**. The latter polity had come into existence in 1577, when Mohammed Jasa moved his capital from Harar to Awsa.
- At some point **after 1672**, Awsa declined and temporarily ended in conjunction with Imam Umar Din bin Adam's recorded ascension to the throne.
- The **Awsa Sultanate** was **subsequently re-established** by Kedafo around 1734, and was **thereafter ruled by his Mudaito Dynasty**. **Primary symbol of the Sultan** was silver baton, which was considered to **have magical properties**.
- Awsa's economy was mainly depended on **Bati-Ginda'e trade route**.
- **Later Awsa became center of Islamic learning** led by **preachers** like Tola Hanfre.

Argoba

- ❖ Early reference to **the people of Argoba** is insufficient. There are two versions on **the origin of the people of Argoba**. i.e:-
- ✓ The **first version** holds that they descended from the **eighty-two followers of the Prophet Mohammed** who came to the Horn of Africa and **settled at Ifat**.
- ✓ The **second version** claims that the **origin of the Argoba is not related with Muslim-Arab immigrants**, but claims and arguably seems a logical presentation that indicates **the Argoba as an ancient and indigenous people who accepted Islam** very early from **religious leaders who came from Arabia**.

The Emirate of Harar

- ❖ **Harar** is one of the **earliest Muslim centers** in the region of Ethiopia and the Horn.
- In the **sixteenth century**, **Harar** became the **capital of Walasma of Adal** replacing **Dakar** until 1577 when it was **shifted to Awsa** due to the pressure from the Oromo. Imam Ahmed ibn Ibrahim used Harar as a center from where he launched his campaigns into the Christian kingdom in 1527.
- Later during the reign of **Emir Nur Mujahid**, **Harar** became a **walled city** where the sultanate of the Harari developed.
- In the **mid seventeenth century**, **Emir Ali ibn Da'ud** (r. 1647-62) in cooperation with the Oromo established a dynasty which was to rule for nearly two centuries and a half. It was strengthened by **Amirs like Abdul Shakur** (1783-94). The **Amir's council, Majilis** engaged in supervising **Mosque land, Waqf** and offering other **assistance to the Amir**.
- The **emirate grew** in importance to be a **steady center of Islamic culture and power**.
 - ✓ Its **economic power** grew as it **controlled trade routes** from the **Gulf of Aden ports of Zeila and Berbera**.
 - ✓ Its **authority** was established over the **surrounding Oromo and Somali** through **trade, inter-marriage**, and **expansion of Islamic teachings**. Egyptians were attracted by such a prominence that they sent an expeditionary force in 1875 and controlled the emirate for nearly a decade (until 1885).
 - ✓ Although it was later restored, and ruled by **Amir Abdulahi**, as the **last emir of the Sultanate** for two years, Emperor Menilek's expansion to the region shortly followed in 1887.

5.5.2. Peoples and States in Central and South Central Parts

The Kingdom of Shewa

The Kingdom of Shewan:-

- was formed by a **Menz ruler** **Negasi Kristos** (r.1696-1703) and eventually controlled districts like **Asandabo, Debdabo, Mafud and Yifat**.
- its second king was **Merid Azmatch Sebestie/Sebastyanos** (r.1703-18).
- King **Abuye/ Abiyye** (1718-45) made **Haramba**, his capital and tried to subjugate the **surrounding Oromo** before he was **killed by the Karrayu Oromo**. In addition to his unsuccessful **attempts to control the Afar** and **Abitchu Oromo**.
- **Amaha Iyesus/ Amayyes** (r.1745-75) declared authority over **Bulga, Efrata, Menz and Tegulet** with his capital at **Doqaqit** which later shifted to **Ankober**.
- **Asfa-Wosen** (r.1775-1808) conquered **Antsokia, Asbo, Gedom, Gishe, Merhabete, Morat and Shewa Meda**.
- The dynasty became very strong under **Negus Sahle-Sellase** (r.1813-47), the grandfather of **Emperor Menilek II**. During his reign, many travelers visited Shewa and he even signed “treaty of friendship and commerce” with the **British** in 1841.
- Its economy was mainly based on agriculture **supplemented by trade and craft**. Near the capital, **Ankobar**, there was an important **trade center** in **Aleyu Amba** administered by the Shewan court.

Gurage

The Gurage:-

- live in southern Ethiopia.
- the main Gurage clans and their sub-divisions are the following;
 - ✓ Inor group (**Inamor, Enner, Endegegna, Gyeto and Mesemes**)
 - ✓ Chaha group (**Chaha, Muher, Ezha, Gumer and Gura**)
 - ✓ The Kistane group (**Nurana and many other clans**)
 - ✓ Additional groups included **Dobbi, Gadabano and Masqan**.
- The staple crop in Gurage land is **enset**.
- had traditional system of governance developed over the centuries. There was, however, **no centralized leadership**. Power was vested in clan or lineage groups. The descent groups displayed corporate **rights, obligations, and influence**.
- Gurage’s notable customary modes of governance include the **Yajoka Qicha** and the **Gordanna Sera**.

Kambata

- ❖ By about 1550-70, **four communities** of separate origin coalesced to form the contemporary state of **Kambata** which means, “this is the place” (where we live-as the **Kambata** believe in).
 - The first one, **Kambata** in the narrow sense, had its **original homeland** around **Mount Hambericho** in the **heartland of Kambata territory**.
 - The other three namely the **Dubamo, Donga and Tembaro** trace **their homeland** from Sidama highlands.
- ☞ If the above processes led to the formation of **the nucleus of the state**, the **ethno-genesis** of **Kambata** also **benefitted from Omotic and Semitic peoples** who moved into the region at different times.
- ❖ **Emperor Yeshak** (r.1413-30) **annexed Kambata proper** and **controlled the area between Omo and Bilate Rivers**, which he incorporated into the Christian Ethiopian Empire.
- ❖ In 1532, **the region** was captured by **Imam Ahmed’s army**, which furthered the interaction of peoples. At the **end of the sixteenth century**, the groups were recognized as and conscious of the name **Kambata** related to **one of the seven dominant clans** (**Kambata Lamala**) in the region.
- ❖ The people were **ensete farmers** sharing similar culture and speaking the same language called **Kambatissa**, which belongs to the **Highland East Cushitic family** together with **Qabena, Halaba, Hadiya, Sidama, Gedeo and Burji** groups.
- ❖ The Kambata had **a traditional administrative institution** called **the Hambericho Council**. The council **had seven members** each representing the **seven clans** in the region. With a king at the top, the council **ruled Kambata until the late nineteenth century**.

Hadiya

- ❖ The **origin of the state of Hadiya** goes back to **the thirteenth century**.
- ❖ Hadiya was mentioned in the **Kebre-Negest (*Glory of the Kings*)** and it referred to the **area west of the Islamic states in the federation of Zeila**.
- ❖ The people were **heterogeneous** both linguistically and culturally.
- ❖ **Semitic-speaking** agricultural people dominated **north of the state** while **the southern part** was largely inhabited by **Cushitic-speaking** pastoral communities. There was a considerable Muslim population.
- ❖ By about 1332, the ruler of the Christian kingdom, **Amde-Tsion**, **subjugated Hadiya** after defeating its ruler, **Amano** who **supported by a Muslim “prophet” Bel’am** aligned with the **then leader of Ifat, Sabraddin** to **confront the Christian force**.
- ❖ From the **thirteenth to the sixteenth centuries**, **Hadiya’s political importance** was considerable with sizable population and vast territory.
- ❖ In 1445, a **Hadiya king** called **Mahigo** rebelled against **Emperor Zara-Yaqob** (r.1434-68) and was consequently **replaced by his uncle Bamo**. To stabilize the situation, **Zara-Yaqob** made a **political marriage**. Accordingly, **Princess Elleni**, from Hadiya, who became an important historical figure, **married Emperor Zara-Yaqob**.
- ❖ Another Hadiya leader, **Garad Aze** refused to pay tribute to **Emperor Sartsa-Dengel** (r.1563-98), but was suppressed in 1568/9.
- ☞ The **relations between Hadiya and the Christian Kingdom** was **interrupted** following the **Wars between the latter and Adal and the Oromo population movement** until Hadiya's incorporation into the Imperial state **in the late nineteenth century**. After these two major historical events especially the latter, Hadiya’s population became more diverse. However, **descendants of the old Hadiya** can be traced from **four different linguistic clusters**:
 - the **Oromo**
 - the **Sidama**
 - the **Kabena** and **Alaba**, and
 - the **Hadiya** proper with its sub-groups-the **Mareko, Lemu, Soro, Shashogo** and **Badowacho**.
- ❖ As with the **Kambata and Sidama**, **the Hadiya language** belongs to the **Highland East Cushitic family** and their languages are **intelligible** to members of these ethnic groups.

5.5.3. Peoples and States in the South

Sidama

- ❖ Historically, **the Sidama** have been **living in the southern parts of Ethiopia** occupying lowlands of about 1500 m a.s.l in the **Great East Africa Rift Valley** that cut through **Lakes Hawasa** and **Abaya** up to 3000 m a.s.l in the **eastern Sidama highlands of Arbegona, Bansa and Arroressa** districts.
- ❖ **Agriculture**, although practiced traditionally, remained the **basis of Sidama’s economy**. **Enset and coffee** are Sidama’s important **food and cash crops** respectively.
- ❖ The **Sidama** had an **indigenous system of governance** led by **the Mote (king)**.
 - **The Mote** exercised **political and administrative authority** in consultation with **the council of elders** called **Songo**.
 - **Songo members raised any agenda** for discussion within the council and submitted their decisions **to the Mote for approval**. Although there was no written constitution, rules were known by heart through generations and practiced accordingly.
- ☞ **The cultural and ritual leader** in Sidama society was **the Woma**. The woma:-
 - was selected for his ability as a peacemaker, bodily perfection, oratorical ability, wisdom and caution.
 - could not participate in war or cattle raiding as he was considered a man of peace.
 - handled cultural matters such as offering sacrifices to the spirits.
 - performed other rituals such as circumcision and marriage.

- ☞ The Sidama society was divided into **generation-sets** called *Luwa*. The system had five grades each lasting for eight years. These are *Darara*, *Fullassa*, *Hirbora*, *Wawassa* and *Mogissa*.
 - Candidates for *Luwa* received a five-month military training and war songs like *qerarsha* under **the leadership of the *gaden*** with his deputy called *Ja'lawa*.
 - The *gaden* settled disputes **within his *Luwa***, besides handling **the defense of Sidama society together with the *Mote***.
- ☞ Another important institution of Sidama society is *Seera*. ***Seera* was the social constitution of the Sidama people** governing social life based **on the Sidama moral code, *halale* (the ultimate truth)** to judge the right and wrong. Although it was not written and defined with strict enforcement mechanisms, **people abide by the rules of *halale*** to avoid curse or ostracization by the society.

Gedeo

- ❖ Contradictory traditions exist regarding **the origin of the Gedeo people**. The dominant tradition relates **the ancestors of the Gedeo to *Daraso***, who was the older brother of *Gujo* (father of Guji Oromo). Accordingly, **the seven major Gedeo clans descended from the seven sons of *Daraso***. The clans were grouped in two houses,
 - the first being the *shole batte* (senior house) where **the first four clans belonged** including more than **25 sub-clans** and
 - the second called *sase batte* (junior house) where **the last three belonged** having **10 sub-clans**. Each clan was exogamous and was assigned for particular duty such as ritual, traditional medicine or leadership.
- ❖ The Gedeo had a culture called *baalle*, a traditional governance system that worked with age classes and ranking. I.e:-
 - **The *baalle* had seven grades with a 10-year period each creating a 70-year cycle**.
 - *Sasserogo* was a federation of three territories; *Sobbho*, *Ributa* and *Rikuta* **sharing one *Abba Gadaa*** who leaves office **every eight years** to be replaced by a new holder with the next age set at ***baalle* ceremony**. It was at this ceremony that all positions ranging from the top, *Abba Gada* down to *Hayitcha* were assumed.
- ❖ Like the neighboring *Sidama*, with whom they shared a very close language, **their economy was based on the cultivation of *enset***.

Konso/ Xonso

- ❖ The name Konso is invariably **used to refer** one of the ancient peoples in Ethiopia and the Horn who spoke *affa Konso* (Konso language) and their land. The literal meaning of the term is a “**heavily forested hill/ area**.”
- ❖ A century ago **the highlands of Konso**, which was covered by dense forest, **had been the traditional home of Konso people** while **the low-lying environment along Sagan and Woyito river valley served as hunting grounds**.
- ❖ Konso attracted the **attention of local and international researchers** interested in **human evolution**, as it is **one of the earliest human settlement sites in the world**.
- ❖ Agriculture was and remains to be **the major economic activity of the Konso**. Farmers:-
 - practiced a fairly balanced and integrated system of specialized agricultural technology. The location of mainland Konso within **mosquito infested hot and dry lowlands** at the edge of the Great East African Rift Valley led farmers to adopt **intensive agriculture**.
 - combined **crop production** with **cattle breeding**. At the same time, they **adopted soil conservation techniques** notably the **construction of terraces**, which proved helpful to **convert rugged and hilly areas into permanent cultivation**.
 - were also adept at **selecting plant genes that withstood harsh climatic conditions**. Such complex agricultural practices enabled farmers to **produce sufficient food on small plot of land for their sustenance**.
- ❖ Besides agriculture, Konso's economy depended on bee keeping and craftworks. All of these activities attest the **ingenuity** of local adaptation strategies.

- ❖ Until the late nineteenth century, the Konso people lived in walled villages (*paletas*) namely Karati, Turo and Takati which were further divided into wards called *Kanta*.
 - There was **no central authority** who acted as sovereign power over **the three** regions.
 - Each village was ruled by **a council of elders** called *hayyota* who were **selected** through **direct participation of male members** of the village. Membership to the council was **not hereditary** but rotated every eighteen years.
- ❖ At the core of the socio-political organization of the Konso appear to be the clan or lineage group and generation set, *Tselta*. The Konso were divided into nine exogamous clans namely Toqmaleta, Elayta, Saudata, Pasanta, Kertita, Ishalayta, Mahaleta, Tikisayta and Argamyta. The *Tselta* had fixed cycle of years starting from birth, although they varied across villages-
 - **eighteen** in Karat,
 - **nine** in Takati and
 - **five** in Turo. The major function of the generation set was **informing the responsibilities expected of each age group**.

5.5.4. Peoples and States in Southwestern Part

Wolayta

- ❖ The name **Wolayta** denotes a specific ethnic group in southwestern Ethiopia and their **powerful kingdom**, which **first emerged as a state back in the thirteenth century**.
- ❖ According to local traditions, **before the emergence of Wolayta as a political unit, the area was inhabited by different communities** such as the Badia, Badiagadala and Aruja.
- ❖ The state flourished in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries because of:-
 - successful wars that the Wolayta fought against their neighbors and
 - the material, human and territorial gains thereof.
- ❖ At the apex of the social and political hierarchy was the *Kawo* (king), **assisted by advisory council of nobles** called Ballimalla.
- ❖ From the thirteenth to the late nineteenth centuries, two successive dynasties ruled Wolayta. I.e:-
 - the **Wolayta-Malla** and
 - the **Tigre**.
- ☞ Founded in the thirteenth century by Motalami, the **Wolayta-Malla** seems to have **ruled until the end of the fifteenth century**. It was then **superseded** by the **Tigre dynasty**, so called because it was **supposedly founded by Tigreans** from northern Ethiopia.
- ❖ The land of Wolayta is known for its:-
 - fertility and
 - moderate climate, with green vegetation cover for the most part of the year.
- ☞ All land was **nominally owned by the king** who granted it to his dependents. **In practice, land relationships were ordered according to three basic principles of social organization** i.e.

• kinship • polity and • social status	}	Accordingly, rights over land were vested in:-	{	the lineage group, the crown (royal estate) and the nobility
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- ☞ There were also communal lands allocated **for grazing and social gatherings** to which **all members of the society except artisans** had equal access.
- ☞ **The king rewarded people with land on grounds of:-**
 - **gallant deeds in battle** and
 - other important contributions to the state.
 - By grants of land or by threats of dispossession the reigning monarch ensured loyalty to the state.
- ☞ Except those who worked on the royal estate, **landholders paid tribute to the king**.
- ❖ The **dominant food crop** was enset (*Enset Ventricosum*).

Kafa

- ❖ According to traditions, **this powerful kingdom emerged in fourteenth century**. Around **mid seventeenth century**, **the state had come to prominence**.
- ❖ **The ruling Minjo dynasty and the medieval kingdom of Ennarya** had **close contact**. The Oromo expansion might have forced the ruling house of Ennarya to **flee south of the Gojeb** which as a result **brought Christianity and the royal title tato to Kafa**.
- ❖ As with a number of Cushitic and some Semitic peoples **of the south**, Kafa's economy was **based on the cultivation of enset** on peasant farms **supported by trade**.
 - Besides working on their land, **peasants** rendered free labor service and tilled royal estates **with the support of slaves** who were acquired through raiding or trading, or as payment for debt.
 - As far as trade is concerned, a **prosperous commerce took place with Oromo states of the Gibe region**. Major trade items, such as, **musk, coffee, slaves, Ivory, gold, honey-wax, and civet were exported via markets like Tonkolla, Tiffa, Qeya** etc.
- ❖ From **the seventeenth to the eighteenth centuries**, **the kingdom expanded** to Bonesho, Mashengo, Maji, Nao, She and Chara. At the apex of the administration of the kingdom was the **Tato** with his **major political center** at **Bonga**. **Another seat of power** was **Andarcha**, seven miles to southeast.
- ☞ The **Tato** was assisted by a council of seven advisors called **Mikrecho**.
- ☞ The **Mikrecho** **served to moderate the power of the king** but **they played important roles in succession as well**.
- ❖ The Kafa **had a tradition of digging deep trenches** called **Kuripo** as **defensive barrier**. The Gojeb River also:-
 - **served as natural protection** against external invasion and
 - it might have contributed to their **relative independence** until 1897.

Yem

- ❖ The Yem state:-
 - was **located along the eastern banks of the Gibe** or **to the northeast of the Kafa kingdom**.
 - its economy combined **agriculture, trade and crafts**.
 - initially, an **indigenous dynasty** called **Dida** or **Halman-Gamma** ruled it from its **palace** in **Dudarkema/Zimarma** near **Oya**, in the vicinity of **Bor Ama Mountain**.
 - Besides **being at the top of the political ladder**, **the Amno (king) of Yem** acted as a **chief priest** with attributes of divinity.
 - ✓ **A state council of 12 members** named **Astessor** with **its chairperson Waso** assisted the **Amno** in administering the state.
 - ✓ **Erasho** were **the provincial governors** and they were **responsible for digging ditches** called **bero** and **erecting nearly fifty-meter wooden or iron pillars** at the **center of the kingdom** around **Brisi Bitu** so that **the war father, the Nomiaw, could patrol the surroundings**.
 - ✓ Especial messengers, **Wosi** carried **orders from Amno** down to district chiefs, **Gagna** and vice versa.
- ☞ **In the fourteenth century**, the last King **Oyokam/Amo Dasha** was overthrown by people from the north who **founded a new dynasty** called **Mowa (Howa)** with its center at **Angari**.
- ☞ **In the nineteenth century**, the neighboring state of **Jimma Abba Jifar** **tried to control the Yem** which itself was **absorbed into the imperial state of Ethiopia** under Emperor **Menilek II** **towards the end of the century**.

Gamo

- ❖ Historically, **the Gamo inhabited** areas **from Lakes Chamo and Abaya to the Gughe Mountain and beyond**.
- ❖ Gamo's physical landscape can be divided into two. I.e:-
 - 1/ the **geze** (highland) and

2/ the **bazo** (lowland).

- ☞ **The highlands** were densely populated while people who escaped coercion by the state at the political center largely settled **the lowlands** which also served as hunting fields.
 - **A set of interrelated indigenous laws** called **the Woga** defined **land-use** in the Gamo highlands. The laws had their origin in a belief that everything was connected and bound in a delicate balance. Together they **formed a natural resource management system** that governed everything from interpersonal relationships to the conservation and preservation of pasture, forest, soil, and water.
 - **The cultivation of *enset*** had been **central to the subsistence of Gamo highlands** while maize and sweet potato were staple food crops in the lowlands.
 - Other **crops grown in the highlands** included **barely, wheat, *teff*, peas, beans and cabbage**.
- ☞ **Besides farming**, most farmers **kept cattle for food, farming and manure**, which they needed for successful agriculture. **Craft making, pot making, tanning and metalworking** were other modes of the subsistence system.
- ☞ These people **had developed their own indigenous knowledge and technologies in manufacturing different types of tools and weapons, traditional musical and funeral instruments, weaving colorful textiles** etc.
- ❖ The **first mention of the Gamo** in written records dates back to **the fifteenth century in the praise songs of king Yishak** (r.1413-30). The song mentioned the **Gamo as one of the tributary states** to the Ethiopian monarch. The **Gamo maintained relative autonomy** from control by the **Christian Kingdom after war with the Muslim sultanates** weakened the latter.
- ❖ **Between the sixteenth to the nineteenth centuries**, the Gamo lived in **scattered settlements and organized in different communities** called ***dere***. The ***dere*** were **politically autonomous villages (units)** but **shared three essential features**. These were:
 - (1) **each *dere* had *kawo*** (hereditary ruler) who also offered sacrifices and symbolized the unity of the people.
 - (2) **every *dere* had its own initiates** called ***halaqa*** and
 - (3) **every *dere* had its own assembly** place called ***dubusha***, where communal matters were discussed and disputes solved.
- ❖ **Access to politico-ritual status among the Gamo people was made possible** through **initiation or election** and ***baira***, a **system of seniority**. The two systems functioned both **in opposition to each other as well as complementarily**.
 - ⌚ The First system was carried through **initiation or election**. The ***dulata* (assembly)** **elected married men to positions** that were known by **different names from one *dere* to another**. i.e:-
 - In some *dere* it was called ***halaqa***
 - In others *dere* it was known by the name ***huduga or maqa***.
 - ☞ Election to this office was open to all married men and accorded representatives with provisional political authority.
 - **The *dulata* (assembly):-**
 - ✓ had an **institutional authority** to give decisions on different **social, political and many other important matters**.
 - ✓ had also the power to **impose sanctions as penalty on individuals or groups who committed serious crimes or violated the community's social regulations and cultural values**.
 - ⌚ The second system, the ***baira***, was ascribed and largely **based on genealogical seniority** according to **primogeniture**. The Gamo people were distributed in agnatic clans each having a system of individual genealogical hierarchy.
 - **The *baira* (senior) of the clan**
 - ✓ **had a privilege** over lineage members.
 - ✓ **made animal sacrifice** on behalf of their juniors at all levels of the community. The **senior sacrificer** of the *dere* is **the *kawo***.

☞ **The concept of kawo**

- ✓ **refers to the first rank status**, with variable attributes and he was legitimized by birth and primogeniture.
- ✓ **represented the unity of dere** and played an important role in relations with the outside world.

Dawuro

- ❖ **Dawuro's topography** mostly is mountainous and plateau at the central, and lowland and plain at **Gojeb and Omo river basins**. The land is divided into **three climatic zones**. These are:-
 - *geziya* (highland),
 - *dashuwa* (mid-altitude) and
 - *gad'a* (lowland). Such climatic conditions enriched Dawuro with a variety of tree species and natural vegetation/forest.
- ❖ The **livelihood of Dawuro** people is **based on mixed agricultural activities**.
- ❖ **The language of Dawuro people** is **Dawurotsuwa**, a sub-group of the **Omotic family**.
- ❖ Historically, **Dawuro land** had been inhabited by **three major clans** namely:-
 - *Malla*,
 - *Dogolla*, and
 - *Amara*which altogether were regarded as **Gok'as** or **K'omos**.
- ❖ The area was also **home for people** that came from neighboring Omotic states such as **Wolayta, Kucha, Gamo, Gofa, and Kafa** and from places like **Gondar, Gojjam, Tigray and Shewa** since early times.
- ❖ A **political alliance** through **royal marriages** was one important factor that **facilitated the movement** of people from neighboring territories into Dawuro.
- ❖ By about 1700, **the Kawuka dynasty** had created a big state from a great number of petty chieftainships on the territory between the **Gojeb and Omo rivers in the north, east and south and the Kafa high mountains in the west**.
- ❖ Among the rulers of the **Kawuka dynasty** of Dawuro, **Kati Irashu** and **Kati Halala** were famous. **Kati Halala** :-
 - was the **grandson of the king of Kafa**.
 - during his reign, **Dawuro incorporated Konta**.
 - is known for his **stone fortifications** which he oversaw to defend his territories from outsiders.

Ari

- ❖ The **Omo River basin** had been **home to different groups of people since early times**. These included the **Ari, Dasenech, Tsemayi, Erbo, Hamar, Surma, Meniet, Nyangatom, Bodi, Male**, etc.
- ❖ **Major economic activities** in the region were **sedentary agriculture, pastoralism and handcrafts**.
- ❖ The **language of the Ari people** is called **Araf**, which is one branch of the **Omotic language family**.
- ❖ The **society** was organized into **ten independent clan based chiefdoms**. I.e:-
 - **Hereditary clan chief** known as **Babi** headed each of these chiefdoms.
 - The **clan chief** was **entitled with both political and ritual authorities** over the people of his respective domain.
 - The **clan chief** was **assisted by officially appointed prominent figures in the administration of the political unit**. The assistants included **Godimis** (religious leaders), **Zis** (village heads) and **Tsoikis** (intelligence agents of **Babi**).

5.5.5. Peoples and States in the West

Berta and Gumuz

- The **Berta** people inhabit the present **Beni-Shangul Regional State**.
 - The **earliest record of Berta settlement** in this region dates from the **sixteenth century**.
 - The Berta people **speak the Berta language** as their mother tongue. It is a **tonal language** classified as a branch of the **Nilo-Saharan linguistic group**.

- In addition to the Berta, the **Beni-Shangul** is home for the Gumuz. They are already mentioned by the **Scottish explorer James Bruce**. He notes that **they hunted** with bows and arrows, a custom that survives today.
 - The Gumuz **speak the Gumuz language**, which belongs to the Nilo-Saharan family. It is subdivided in several dialects.
 - **Islamic influence** had been strong **on the Berta and other Nilotes** because of their trade and social contacts with the **northern Sudan**.

Anywa

- Historically, the Anywa predominantly inhabited areas along **Pibor, Sobat, Gila, Akobo, Agwei, Oboth, Baro, and Alwero Rivers** on the **western borderlands of the present-day Gambella region**.
- The people **speak Dha-anywaa**, a sub-branch of the Nilo-Saharan language family.
- The Anywa **had an indigenous administrative system** whereby each **village lived under a chief** called **Kuaari** who along with **the nobles, Nyiye**, managed the distribution of farm and grazing fields, settled disputes etc with the community.
- Although local traditions mention **a certain person** by the name **Oshoda** as **the founding father of the Anywa**, the administration of the territory was not centralized.
- **Economically**, they are engaged in **small-scale cultivation, fishing and hunting**. While most Anywa practiced Christianity, they also believed in **traditional religion**.

Nuer

- Historically, the Nuer lived in areas that extended across **the savannas and marshes of the Bahr el-Ghazal and the Upper Nile regions of the Sudan**. Since the nineteenth century, they had been largely settled in **the plains of Gambella** along **the Sobat and Baro Rivers** and **parts of the Sudan**.
- The **mainstay of Nuer's economy** was **cattle breeding** supplemented by **crop production**. The Nuer had developed a rather **complex spiritual culture around their cattle**, which were used as bride wealth as well.
- **The Nuer had an age-set system** combining social and political functions. Nuer boys had to pass through a severe test and a series of rites connected with it before they were initiated into adulthood.

Majang

- **The Majang** formed the southern end of the **Nilo-Saharan settlement** that covered the escarpment of the **Oromo inhabited highlands to the Baro plains**.
- Linguistic evidence relates the **origin of the Majang** to the **Boma plateau** in **South Sudan**. Gradually, they **moved northwards** and settled in forested areas of **western Ethiopia**. By **mid twentieth century**, their settlement extended to areas near **Dembi-Dollo** in the north.
- **Economically**, the Majang practiced **shifting cultivation and animal husbandry**. Other economic activities of the Majang include **beekeeping, hunting and fishing**.

The Kunama

- The **Kunama people** also called the **Baza**:-
 - are one of the ancient inhabitants of **western Eritrea** on the **Gash and Tekkeze Rivers** and in today's **northwestern and western Tigray**. The Arab traveller **al-Ya'qubi** in **872 A.D.** mentions **the kingdom of Baza**, which is a **self-designation of the Kunama**.
 - had a customary institution called **sanga-anene** mandated with the administration of the society. Other responsibilities of the **sanga-anene** included **granting asylum to new comers in the sanctuary** of their compounds and **performed rituals as part of reconciliation process in case of homicides**. The **office of the sanga-anene** was held by **male members of the society**. The office was transmitted hereditarily from the eldest brother to the next born on matrilineal line.
- The **mainstay of Kunama's economy** is **mixed agriculture**. Agriculture is based on the use of **hoe, spades, sickles and the ox (camel)-drawn plough**. Signs of past practices of **terraced agriculture** are still visible in some areas of the Kunama.
- The **staple crop** among the Kunama is **sorghum (kina)**, which also has a **ceremonial value**. Other crops grown are **millet (borta or beca)**, **pulses** and **maize (afokina)**. The Kunama also **keep livestock** mainly **goats, sheep, oxen, and camels**.

5.6. The Gondarine Period and Zemene-Mesafint

5.6.1. The Gondarine Period

A. Political Developments

- **The period of Gondar begins** from the reign of **Emperor Sartsa-Dengle** when the political center of Ethiopian emperors shifted to Gondar area.
 - **Emperor Sartsa-Dengle** established royal camp at **Enfranz** in **1571**.
 - **Emperor Susenyos** also tried to establish his capital near Gondar like at **Qoga, Gorgora, Danqaz** and **Azazo**.
- ☞ **Gondar was founded** in **1636** when **Fasiledas** established his political seat there.
- Gondar achieved its glory during the reigns of its first three successive emperors:
 - Fasiledas (r.1632–67),
 - Yohannes I (r.1667-82) and
 - Iyasu I (r.1682- 1706).
- ☞ Among the major reforms during the periods the above three emperors were:-
 - the restoration of Orthodox Church as state religion, and the establishment of a royal prison at **Amba Wahn** to solve problems stemming from power rivalry.
 - **Emperor Yohannes I** and his council established a **separate quarter for Muslims at Addis Alem**.
 - **Yohannes I's** successor, **Iyasu I**, reformed land tenure system, introduced a system of land measurement in Begemder, taxes, and customs, and revised the **Fetha Negest (the civil code)**.
- ☞ **The assassination of Iyasu the Great** by a faction under the leadership of his own son, **Tekle-Haymanot**, ushered in political instability in Gondar **involving intrigues** and **poisoning of reigning monarchs**. Tekle-Haymanot was crowned in 1706 before the death of his father and was in turn assassinated by Tewoflos. Tewoflos was again killed by Yostos, who was also poisoned and replaced by Dawit III, who himself was poisoned and replaced by Bakafa. Bakafa tried to restore stability with the support of his followers and his wife **EtegeMentewab** until he was incapacitated in 1728. The Gondarine Period also witnessed increased involvement of the Oromo in politics and the army as will be discussed shortly.
- From **1728 to 1768**, **Etege Mentewab** together with **her brother Ras-Bitwaded Walda Le'ul (1732-1767)** dominated the Gondarine **court politics**.
 - **Walda Le'ul** was influential during the reigns of **Iyasu II (1730-55)** and **Iyoas (1755-69)**. Following his death in **1767**, **Etege Mentewab** was challenged by **Wubit Amito**, her daughter-in-law from Wollo. To counter the growing power of the **Wollo Oromo** in the royal court, Mentewab sought the alliance of **Ras Mika'el Sehul of Tigray** who was politically astute and militarily powerful.
 - **Mika'el Sehul** succeeded in stabilizing the situation and refused to return to Tigray although demanded by Iyoas. This was followed by the **killing of Iyoas** and his **replacement by an old man Yohannes II** by **Ras Mika'el**. Soon **Ras Mika'el killed Yohannes II** and **put his son Takla-Haymanot II (1769-77)** on power. This marked the onset of the period of **Zemene-Mesafint (1769-1855)**.

B. Achievements of the Gondarine Period

- ❖ Gondar became the **center of state administration, learning, commerce, education, art, and crafts** for more than two centuries. The **first three kings** were successful not only **in political** affairs but also in **cultural developments**.
- ❖ Gondar had great influence on the country's cultural developments. This enabled Gondar to repeat the splendors of **Aksum** and **Lalibela**. The cultural achievements of the period led some writers to describe **Gondarine period** in history as **Ethiopian Renaissance**.

Architecture: when Gondar served as a permanent capital, for about **one hundred fifty years**, Ethiopian kings built significant **secular buildings** like **castles, bridges, residences, bath, library, towers, fortifications** and there are **squared, round and unknown shape of churches**.

- In the cities compound the most impressive building known as ***Fasil Gemb***, there are different palaces corresponding to Emperor **Fasiledas**, **Yohannes I**, **Iyasu I**, **Dawit III**, **Bakafa** and **regent Queen Mentewab**.
- The Gondarine architecture would have started before the reign of emperor Fasiledas during the reign of Emperor **Sartsa-Dengle** at about 1586, at **Guzara** near Enfranz. Even it goes back to the reign of **Lebne-Dengel** (r.1508-1540) that is the pointed **oval dome** over the center of the **church of Bahir Gimb Mikael** considered as built by him.
- The architectural styles of **Fasiledas** castle usually have two stride and almost square; circular domed corner towers. Not only castle, bridge building did not originate with the reign of Fasiledas. Rather, Emperor **Sartsa-Dengel** is said to have built a very fine bridge near his palace at **Guzara**, and Emperor **Susenyos** likewise erected a bridge over **Blue Nile** at **Alata**.

Painting: With a wealth of **religious paintings on manuscripts** and **on wood**, **ornaments**, **weapons** and **other accessories** especially, the churches built by Queen Mentwab were known by beautiful paintings, cross and an art works.

Literature: The Imperial and provincial scriptoria produced a great number of manuscripts. Besides the **Gospels**, the **Miracles of Mary**, the **Lives of Ethiopian Saints** and the **Litanies**, and many other kinds of **illuminated manuscripts** were also produced. Gondar is also known for its **traditional medicine**, **music** and **poetry**.

Trade and Urbanization:

- Gondar was a **commercial center** that connected long distance trade routes of the **southern region with Massawa and Metemma in the Ethio-Sudan border**. Gold and salt were used as medium of exchange. The appearance of **daily market** was known.
- With spread of **urbanization**, the city became residences of foreign communities like **Indians**, **Greeks** and **Armenians**. The city had an estimated **60,000-70,000 population**.
- In addition to its **political and commercial importance**, it served as **religious center of Christians, Muslims and Bete-Israel**. Besides, it served as the center of Ethiopian Orthodox Church (**residence of the abun and Ichege**) until the **mid of nineteenth Century**. Many of **Orthodox churches** served as **education centers** (known by excellence in teaching **aqwaqwam**), liturgical chanting was centered at Gondar.

5.6.2. The Period of Zemene-Mesafint (1769-1855)

❖ Zemene-Mesafint

- refers to the period when actual position of political power was in the hands of different regional lords.
 - lasts from the time Ras Michael Sehul "assassinated" king Iyoas in 1769 to 1855, when Kasa Hailu was crowned as Tewodros II.
- ❖ Ras Mika’el Sehul who was a king maker in the period **took strong measures** against the nobility. These measures **made him highly unpopular** because of which **coalitions of lords of Gojjam, Amhara, Lasta and Wollo** that defeated him at **the battle of Sarba-Kussa in 1771**.
- ❖ Under the reigns of Ras Mika’el Sehul’s successors, there was **relative stability** but several regional lords evolved.
- ❖ The main political regions that *Zemene-Mesafint* lords ruled were **Tigray**, **Semen**, **Dembiya**, **Begemedir**, **Lasta**, **Yejuu**, **Wollo**, **Gojjam** and **Shewa**. When compared to each other the “Yejuu dynasty” was the leading power **during the Zemen-Mesafint** with the center at Debre-tabor. **Ali Gwangul (Ali I or Ali Talaq)** was considered as the founder of “Yejuu dynasty” in 1786.
- **Yejuu rule** reached its zenith under **Gugsa Marso (r.1803-1825)** who made incessant struggle against **Ras Walde-Silassie of Enderta** and **Dejjazmatch Sabagadis Woldu of Agame**.
 - In 1826, **Gugsa's** successor, **Yimam (r.1825-8)**, defeated **Hayle-Mariam Gebre of Simen**. **Maru of Dambiya** was also killed at the battle of **Koso-Ber** in **1827**. Ras Yimam was succeeded by Ras Marye in 1828.

- In 1831, **Marye** came to war against **Sabagadis** at the battle of May Aslamay (near Debre Abbay in western Tigray), where both the contenders were killed at the battle.
- Finally, after the death of the Yeju ruler, Marye, **Dori** came to power at Gonder. But, his rule was short – lived. After his death, **Ras Ali II (Ali-Tinishu) 1831-1853** came to power.
- ☞ The period of *zemene mesafint* was brought to an end by Kasa Hailu of Qwara through a series of battles that lasted from **1840s to 1855**.

Major **features of Zemene-Mesafint** include:

- absence of effective central government;
- the growing power and influence of the regional warlords;
- the domination of Yejjju lords over other lords in northern Ethiopia;
- rivalry and competition among regional lords to assume the position of king maker;
- establishment of fragile coalition to advance political interests;
- Ethiopian Orthodox Church was unable to play its traditional role of unifying the state due to doctrinal disputes;
- Revival of foreign contacts that ended the “Closed Door Policy.”
- ☞ In addition to the above features, there were developments in terms of literature, arts, architecture etc during the period.

UNIT SIX

INTERNAL DEVELOPMENTS AND EXTERNAL RELATIONS OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN, 1800-1941

6.1. The Nature of Interactions among Peoples and States of Ethiopia and the Horn

At the beginning of the nineteenth century, many autonomous and semi-autonomous peoples and states existed in Ethiopia and the Horn. This section deals with the history of these peoples and states in the period under consideration.

6.1.1. Peoples and States in South-Central, Southwestern, and Western Ethiopia

A. South-Central:

- ❖ **Hadiya, Halaba, Kambata, and Gurage** were autonomous and semi-autonomous political entities during this period.
 - **Economically**, they depended largely on **agriculture**.
 - **Local merchants** were actively involved in **local trade** and to some extent in **the long distance trade**. **Trade routes** that connected the interior with the coast passed through these territories. Among these, **the Gurage land** was an important market centre and political entity. **Important trade centers** such as **Soddo and Aymalle** were located in **the Gurage land**.
- ❖ **The Gurage** had their own political organization and **their leaders held the titles** of **Abegaz** or **Azmach** who combined political and military authority.
- ❖ **In the second half of the nineteenth century**, **Qabena** emerged as a strong political entity. It became a **centre of Muslim revivalist movement** to the **northeast of the Gibe River**. Stirred by Muslim refugees from Wollo, and with possible connections even with the Mahdist Sudan, the movement swept across a large part of the region and was attended by a fast spread of Islam.

B. The Gibe States:

- ❖ Towards the **beginning of the nineteenth century**, several **monarchical states (motumma)** emerged among **the Mecha Oromo at the expense of the Gadaa system**.
 - Many factors accounted for **the transformation of the Gadaa system**. In the process, **the war leaders of the Gadaa system (Abba-Dula) and powerful individuals usurped the power of the Gadaa government**.
 - **The abba-dula accumulated wealth from the control and taxation on long distance trade and utilized the opportunity to establish hereditary leadership**. This development especially took place **among the Oromo around Gibe**, where the following five monarchical states emerged.

i. Limmu-Enarya: This Kingdom,

- Was the earliest of the Gibe states.
- Was founded through the incorporation of Enarya.
 - ✓ Initially, Abbaa Dula of Limmu like **Tesso** fought and defeated the rulers of Enarya like **Badancho, Gu'amcho and Banaro** at different times.
 - ✓ Finally, **Bofoo/Abba Gomol (1800-1825)** established Limmu-Enarya. **Bofoo** abdicated in favor of his son, **Ibsa/Abba Bagiboo (1825-61)**.
- ✓ Reached the **height of its power** during **Ibsa's reign**, when he incorporated areas including **Hagalo, Badi-Folla etc. Ibsa** was succeeded by **Abba Bulgaa (1861-1883)**.

ii. Guma:

- ❖ Jilcha Abba Bal'oo of **Chira** killed Sarbaroda of **Dagoye clan**; began state formation and **succeeded** by his son **Oncho** (1810-1830) who was in turn followed by **Jawwe** (1840-1854).

iii. **Gomma:**

- ❖ Formed by Abba Bokee (1800-1829) who was succeeded by his son **Abba Manoo** (1829-1840) who occupied Qattuu and **converted to Islam** by **Muslim Ulama/scholars**.

iv. **Jimma:**

- ❖ Towards the late eighteenth century, Makahore emerged as an **influential female figure** among the **Sadacha Mecha Oromo of Jimma**.
- ❖ The local **Abba Dula** sought to take political power from Makahore. Among the **Abba Dulas**, **Ose Kobi** (**Abba Faro**) was elected as a hereditary ruler against the *Gadaa* rule. He was **succeeded** by **Dangila** (**Abba Magal**) who enlarged the domain.
- ❖ The process of state formation was completed by Sanna/Abba Jifar I (r.1830-55) who **formed Jimma Kingdom** and left a consolidated state to **his successors** like **Abba Rebu** (1855-59), **Abba Boqa** (1859-1861) and **Abba Gomol**(r.1861-75).
- ❖ The most famous among the Jimma monarchs was Tullu /Abba Jifar II (ca. r.1875-1934).
- ☞ Apart from agriculture and trade, the kingdom's economy depended on **iron mining and smelting** at **Dakkano** and **Kito**, respectively.

v. **Gera:**

- ❖ was the **last of the Gibe kingdoms to be formed**.
- ❖ The process of state formation in Gera was completed during the reign of Tullu Gunji (r.1835-38), a **successful war leader** who made himself king.
- ❖ **Abba Rago I** (r.1838-48) **succeeded Tullu Gunji** after a short interlude by **Abba Basso**.
- ❖ Enjoyed its **prosperity** under **Abba Magal** who had been **converted to Islam**. As with other Gibe states, **Gera attracted Muslim missionaries** to preach **Islam**.

C. The Leqa States

- ❖ Like in the Gibe region, several **monarchical kingdoms** evolved among the **Mecha Oromo of Wallagga**. Among these were:-
 - ✓ the Leqa states,
 - ✓ the Sibu and
 - ✓ the Jawwi south of the Abbay River.
- ❖ While **Moti Abishe** established strong **kingdom of Horro**, a number of **Abba Dula** declared themselves **moti (king)** by controlling profitable trade routes and large territories in the region west of the Gibe region. Among these, **the Leqa states** were the **prominent** ones.

I. Leqa-Naqamte:

- ❖ Was founded by Bakare Godana in 1840.
- ❖ Reached its height under his successors Moroda and Kumsa. They were able to establish strong monarchical state **rich in trade and agriculture**.
 - **Moti Kumsa** (later **Dejazmach Gebre-Egzi'abiher**) was known for promoting **handcraft work, gold washing, coffee planting and game reserves/hunting**.
- ❖ Its rulers instituted a **new administrative structure and judicial hierarchy** that replaced the **Gadaa system** known as **sirna abba-qoro (qoro system)**. In its nature, the administration system was essentially **kinship** and was quite **similar to feudal administration** in its reliance on land.

II. Leqa-Qellam:

- ❖ Was located in **south western Wallagga**.
- ❖ It was **founded by Tullu** and became powerful under his son, **Jote** being centered at **Gidami** and controlling the areas around **Sayyo-Dambi Dollo**.

D. Ilu:

- ❖ The **Tume clan** leader **Chali Shono** (also known as **Abba Bor**) **set up** the well-consolidated **state of Ilu-Abba Bor** in the **early nineteenth century**.
- ❖ Was one of the prosperous states in the region.
- ☞ **Each Oromo monarchical state** had officials like:
 - **Abba Gurmu** (next person to the king)
 - **Abba Mizan** (treasurer and foreign affair minister)
 - **Abba Dango** (immigration chief)
 - **Lammi** (ambassador/royal messenger)
 - **Abba Qoro** (district governor)
 - **Abba Ganda** (village chief)
 - **Abba Busi** (tax head)
 - **Abba Jiga** (murder judge) and
 - **Abba-Qawe** (body-guard).
- ☞ **Contrary to the Gadaa values** that had not requisitioned any kind of taxation, under monarchical systems **farmers were forced to pay croptax** measured by traditional instruments called **buchano** (about 15 kilograms) and later **guboo** (25 kilograms) on **each crop**.

E. Nilotic Sheikdoms:

- ❖ In the **early nineteenth century**, important **Islamic centres** emerged in the **lower course of the Abbay**. A number of **Shiekdoms** were established through parallel imposition of Arabic-speaking Sudanese mercantilists over **Berta and Gumuz** inhabitants. Among them, the Sheikdoms of:
 - **Assosa or Aqoldi**
 - **Bela Shangul** and
 - **Khomosha**
 } were established to the **south of Abbay River**
 - **Guba** emerged to the **north of the Abbay River** in the western edge of Gojjam (along the Ethio-Sudanese border).
- ☞ These four sheikdoms **were founded by Muslim leaders of Sudanese origin** who considered themselves as '**Watawit**'. The term **Watawit** refers to **Arbaized Berta** people who had **entered and settled in Benishangul** as **traders and Islamic religious teachers** in the **late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries**.
- ❖ The **main economic bases of the sheikdoms** were **agriculture, gold mining and frontier trade**.
- ❖ Among these sheikdoms,
 - **Asosa/Aqoldi** got preeminence under **Sheikh Khojale al Hasan**.
 - **Bela/Beni-Shangul** became famous under **Abd al Rahman Khojale**.
 - **Khomosha** reached its zenith under **Khojale Muhammad Wad Mahmud**.
 - **Guba**: attained similar prominence in the southwest of Gojjam
- ☞ The **influence of Islam** from the Sudan and **cross border trade** was the **main reasons** for the **rise of these states**. The **rich gold** of the region also attracted foreign powers like the **Mahdists and Egyptians** who **attempted to control the sheikdoms** at different times.

6.1.2. Trade and Trade Routes

- ❖ Although the **trade routes** which linked **southwestern Ethiopia to the coast** had medieval antecedents, it was **in the nineteenth century** that they attained particular prominence. This was partly because of **the revival of external trade in the Red Sea region**. As a result, **trade** became one **means of maintaining strong relations across peoples** of different areas and **backgrounds**. During this period, **two main trade lines** linked various territories of Ethiopia and the Horn. i.e:-
 - **The first major trade route:-**
 - ✓ **originated from Bonga**, the capital of Kafa Kingdom,

- ✓ linked **peoples and states of the southwestern Ethiopia** with the northern part of the Ethiopian region.
- ✓ the main **market centers** along this line were:-
 - ⌚ **Bonga, Hirmata, Saqa, Billo, Asandabo (in Guduru), Basso-Yajube (in Gojjam), Yifag and Darita (in Begemider) and Gondar.**
 - ⌚ **From Gondar, one line bifurcated to westward through Chilga to Matamma-Qallabat (Gallabat) taking commodities to be sold to the **Sudanese merchants** called Jallaba. The other route passed through Adwa, Asmara and entered Massawa.**
 - ⌚ Still another **split at Basso** to move via Ancharro and Dawwe in Wollo and Awusa in Afar to Tajura, Obbok and Rahe'ita in Djibouti.
- The second major trade route also:
 - ✓ **began from Bonga** and
 - ✓ passed through Hirmata to Agabja-Andode-Toli to Soddo in southwest Shewa; Rogge near Yerer. Then, the line passed through Aliyu Amba or Abdul Rasul in northern Shewa and **ran eastward to Harar**. From Harar, the route branched into Zeila and Berbera, the most important commercial centers in Somalia. Then **Ethiopian products** were **mostly sold** in the Middle East.
- ❖ In the trade between the interior and the coast, varieties of items were exchanged. The main sources of **exported items** were **obtained from the southwestern regions**. Among these **weregold, ivory, rhinoceros horn, skins, civet, musk, honey, wax, coffee, various spices and slaves**.
- ☞ **Slaves** were either **raided** or **bought from different parts of Ethiopia** and **exported** to Arabia, Persia and India. Likewise, **imported products** included **mirrors and ironware**.
- ❖ The major media of exchange were:
 - salt bars (*amole*)
 - iron bars
 - wines
 - cowries' shells
 - beads
 - pieces of cotton cloth (*abujadi*)
 - Maria Theresa Thalers (MTT) etc.
- ☞ For internal trade, **amole** was the major important commodity and source of wealth. The Amole:-
 - was **mined in the Afar plains (Taltal) bordering eastern Tigray** where it was also suitably shaped for transportation.
 - then, **transported from Afar and eastern Tigray region** to the highlands through **Adwa, Gondar**, and **to south and southwest parts of the region**. The other route took salt from eastern Tigray to **south Wollo and Shewa**. The **town of Mekelle** prospered as the salt was cut in and distributed to the highlands from the area under the supervision of **the governor of Enderta** with the **title of Balqada**, who had the tributes as **tax judge**, grew in importance and rivaled **Bahre-Negash** (the governor of the maritime province to the north).
- ☞ Maria Theresa Thalers (MTT):-
 - was a coin introduced to the Horn of African region at the end of the eighteenth century.
 - on the Red Sea coast used with other kinds of European and Middle Eastern coins.
- ❖ Diverse peoples of different ethnic and religious background were involved in the trade. At each market center, local peoples were active traders. However, Muslim merchants were the most dominant that traveled from interior to the coast. Among these were:-
 - **Northern Muslim merchants (Jabarti)** trading as far as **the Red Sea Coast**.
 - **Muslim Oromo merchants of southwestern region** known as **Afqala**.

- In the northwest, **Sudanese merchants** known as the **Jelaba** played a leading role
- The **Argoba** from the **Kingdom of Shewa** were similarly active merchants in **the trade between Harar and the northern Somali coast**.
- **Somali and Borana** merchants (**Saffare**) dominated the trade between **southern Ethiopia, Kenya and Somalia**.
- **Afar and Harari** merchants run a brisk trade between **Shoa** and the ports of **Djibouti** and the **Gulf of Aden** respectively.

6.2. The Making of Modern Ethiopian State

- ❖ As discussed in the previous units, the diverse peoples of Ethiopia and the Horn were brought into contact through the agency of:
 - trade
 - population movements
 - evangelization, and
 - wars.

☞ **These agents** played an important part in **the making of the modern Ethiopian state**. On the other hand, a number of **autonomous and semi-autonomous peoples and polities** were in existence in many regions up to **the end of the nineteenth century**.

☞ **During the nineteenth century**, **several states** that emerged in the region were **involved in territorial competition** not only **to extend control over resources** but also for **state building**.

To put it differently, **state building** remained **an agenda of several powerful individuals and groups**, that arose in the **nineteenth century**. The difference was:-

- the level of their strength and ambition, and
- their relations with foreign powers.
- ☞ **States** in the **northern and central parts** of Ethiopia had **relative strength** that built up over time and **gained a new momentum during the nineteenth century** owing to **their foreign contacts and their strategic location**.
- ❖ The **making of the modern Ethiopian state** went through **two distinct phases**.
 - **The first one** involved **unifying different regions and peoples** in **north** and **north central** parts of Ethiopia.
 - **The second phase** involved **territorial expansion** into the **southern parts of the country**. Here under, the **processes of unification and territorial expansion** are discussed in some detail.

A. The Process of Territorial Unification

- ❖ **The territorial unification** ushered in a revival of the imperial power which had declined during the *Zemene-Mesafint*. This occurred after a series of battles and human and material losses. A leading figure in the overall process was **Kasa Hailu** of **Quara** who later became **Emperor Tewodros II of Ethiopia**. **Kasa's mission to create a unified state goes back to his time when he was a *shifita***. Hence, it will be vital to trace the origins of his ideas that he tried to translate into action later in his reign as emperor of Ethiopia.
- ❖ **Kasa Hailu:-**
 - Was born to Hailu Walde Giorgis and Atitegeb Wondwosen (she was Koso vender)
 - Was the man who ended the *Zemene Mesafint*.
 - Started his career by assisting his half-brother, **Dejjazmach Kinfu** in defeating the **Egyptians** at **Wad Kaltabu** (in present day eastern Sudan) in **1837**.
 - When Ras Ali II (Ali Alula/Ali Abba Bula) gave Quara to his mother **Empress Manan/Halima Liban**, he moved to jungle and became a bandit. Manan sent expeditions under generals like **Wandeyrad** against him, but he easily defeated them at **Illoha, Chago & Segel** in **1847**. Kasa's force captured Manan her husband Emperor **Yohannes III** in these battles. After negotiation Kasa released them and

Ras Ali II recognized Kasa as Quara governor and arranged for him to marry his own daughter, **Tawabach Ali**.

- As he acquired military and political strength and experiences, he started mobilizing his own army in the area and fought battles in his own right. In 1848, he fought against the Egyptians that he preferred to call them as the 'Turks' at a place called Dabarki. Although they showed extraordinary courage, **Kasa's forces lost the battle** owing to the Egyptians' superior military organization, discipline and better arms.

On the battle of Debarqi was born Kasa's enduring interest in military organization and modern arms, particularly the mortar.

- Yet, when his army incurred heavy casualties from Egyptian forces at Dabarki in 1848, Kasa was forced to turn his attention first against regional lords and confront foreign enemy. Accordingly, Kasa defeated:-
 - ✓ Dejjach Goshu Zewde of Gojjam at Gur Amba on November 27, 1852
 - ✓ Birru Aligaz, Aben, Yazew and Belew, the four dejjazmachs sent by Ras Ali, at Taqusa (Gorgora Bichign) on April 12, 1853
 - ✓ Ras Ali at Ayshal on 29 June 1853 and
 - ✓ Dejjazmach Wube of Simen and Tigray at Deresge Mariam on 8 February, 1855.
- After defeating the major regional lords one after another, he was anointed by Abune Salama, the Coptic bishop at Deresge Mariam on 9 February 1855, with the throne name of Tewodros II (1855-1868), **King of Kings of Ethiopia**.
- ❖ **Tewodros:-**
 - ✓ pursued his victory at Deresge by marching to the south. He subsequently marched first to Wollo and then to Shewa.
 - ✓ wanted to create a strong central government by appointing individuals (both hereditary and non-hereditary) who would be totally accountable to him.
 - ✓ faced resistance soon after he came to power. After the inclusion of Shewa, rebellions broke out in several regions. Some of the important rebels were Tadla Gwalu of Gojjam, Tiso/Tasew Gobaze of Walqayt, Wag Shum Gobaze Gabramadhin of Lasta, Sayfu Sahla-Sellase and Bazabeh of Shawa, (Dejjach Liban Amade, Amade Bashir, Adare Bille and Warqit & Mastawit) of Wallo, Niguse and Tassama Waldamicha'el of Simen and Kasa Mircha of Tigray.
 - ✓ Externally, he was involved in a serious diplomatic crises following the imprisonment of a handful of Britons and other Europeans. As a result, the British Parliament sent an expeditionary force to free those prisoners and punish the emperor. In a battle that took place at Maqdela, Emperor Tewodros committed suicide on April 13, 1868.
- ⊕ **Following the death of Emperor Tewodros**, three contenders to the throne emerged; namely,
 - Wagshum Gobeze of Lasta,
 - Kasa Mircha of Tigray and
 - Menilek of Shewa.
- ❖ **Gobeze** took state power immediately after Tewodros as **Emperor Tekle-Giorgis II (1868–71)**. Although attempts were made to create a smooth relation between the Emperor and Kasa Mircha, the quest for state power put them in enmity and it was brought to an end following a battle at Assam (near Adwa) in July 1871, in which the latter became victorious.
- ❖ **Kasa Mircha**, who became Emperor Yohannes IV in January 1872, **sustained state building project with an approach that differed from that of Tewodros**. Emperor Yohannes IV (1872-1889):-
 - attempted to introduce a decentralized system of administration.
 - permitting regional rulers to exercise a great deal of autonomy. A good example of this was:-

- ✓ his recognition of **Menilek as Negus of Shewa in 1878** by the Liche agreement.
- ✓ his designation of **Ras Adal Tesema of Gojjam as Negus Tekle-Haymanot of Gojjam and Kafa in 1881.**
- succeeded in achieving the unity of the predominately Christian provinces including **Wag and Lasta, Simen, Begemidr, Amhara Saynt, Gojjam, Wollo, Shewa, and including the Mereb Milash** for quite some time.
- sought to end the religious controversy within the EOC as well as effect religious unity in the country as a whole. In this regard, he presided over **the Council of Boru Meda (1878)** where **Tewahdo was declared the only doctrine of the EOC.** This was followed by the conversion of Muslims and adherents of other religions into Orthodox Christianity.

Accordingly,

- ✓ The leading Wollo leaders such as **Mohammed Ali** and **Amede Liben** as well as **Kumsa Moreda** of **Leqa Naqamte** heeded to the Emperor's call, rather reluctantly, converting to Christianity and changing their names to **Ras Michael, Dajjach Hayle-Mariam,** and **Dajjach Gebre Egziabher** respectively.
- ✓ Others accepted the Emperor's demand outwardly but remained Muslims, becoming "**Christians by day and Muslims by night**".
- ✓ **Others resisted and fled Wollo** to **Arsi, Gurage, Jimma** and **the Sudan** while others revolted under the leadership of **Sheikh Tola (Talha) Jafar** that led to harsh measures of **Emperor Yohannes IV.**
- Internally, **Like Tewodros,** Yohannis faced challenges from power contenders from **Gojjam, Gondar, Yejju, Hamasen and Shawa.** In **Gojjam, Adal Tasama (Nigus Tekle-Haymanot) assumed power by killing his contender Dasta Tadla,** although Yohannis tolerated his regional dynasty. The strongest regional challenger of Emperor Yohannis was **Menilek II of Shawa.**
- Externally, **Emperor Yohannes** faced challenges from:-
 - ✓ Egyptians,
 - ✓ Italians, and
 - ✓ The Mahdists
 } at different times.
- ☞ **Emperor Yohannes lost his life fighting the latter at Metemma in 1889.** Although the Emperor had **designated Mengesha Yohannes** as his successor, rivalry for power split the monarch's camp and thus, Mengesha was unable to make a viable bid for the imperial throne. As a result, the throne was assumed by **Nigus Menelik of Shewa** who became **Emperor Menelik II (1889-1913).** Consequently:-
 - ✓ **Ras Mengesha refused to submit** to Emperor Menelik.
 - ✓ The tension was resolved after Menelik led a campaign to force Mengesha's submission in **1889.** Ras Mengesha was **appointed as governor of Tigray** after a temporary arrangement in which **Ras Mekonnen Wolde Mikael** ruled the area for about a year.

B. Territorial Expansion

- ❖ As indicated above, **Emperor Tewodros II, Emperor Yohannes IV** and others made state building their mission and struggled their ways. Yet, the most successful was **Menilek of Shewa.** This was because Menilek had, among other factors, **access to modern firearms.**
- ❖ Menilek's territorial expansion became successful due to:-
 - The control of resource rich areas that enabled the emperor to build military muscle
 - The **determination** of his generals.
- ❖ The process of territorial expansion by Menilek can be discussed in three phases i.e.
 - When he was king of Shewa (1865-89)
 - From 1889-96 and
 - The aftermath of Adwa (1896-1900).

- ❖ Before the 1870s, Menilek had already incorporated the **Tulema and eastern Mecha Oromo** territories after controlling local leaders notably:-
 - **Ashe Rufo** of **Salale**
 - **Dula Ara'e** of **Gullale**
 - **Tufa Muna** of **Gimbichu**
 - **Ture Galate** of **Soddo** and others.
- ❖ The Oromo elites that worked towards the formation of the modern Ethiopian state were:-
 - *Ras Gobena Dache*
 - *Fitawrari Habte-Giorgis Dinagde*
 - *Dejjach Balcha Safo (Abba Nefso)* and others.
- ❖ In 1875-76:-
 - The **northern Gurage**, **the Kistane**, peacefully submitted to Menilek because of:-
 - ✓ their religious affinity and geographical proximity to the Kingdom of Shewa, and
 - ✓ fear of their local rivals notably the surrounding Oromo
 - On the other hand, the **western Gurage**, led by **Hasan Enjamo** of Qabena, which had elements of **Hadiya-Gurage coalition** strongly resisted Menilek's force until **Ras Gobena broke their resistance** in 1888.
- ❖ **Menilek's territorial expansion** to **western and southwestern regions** were concluded through both **forceful** and **peaceful** submissions.
- ❖ In the regions south of the Abbay River, particularly in **Horro Guduru**, **Ras Adal Tesema of Gojjam** had already established his control over the region since **the mid1870s**. Although he faced stiff resistance from **Moti (King) Abishe Garba of Horro**, Adal's force ambushed Abishe and his entourage at a place called **Kokor**. Thus, **Ras Adal (Nigus Tekle Haymanot since 1881) controlled the region until 1882**, when he was **defeated at Embabo** by **Menilek's commander, Ras Gobana**.
- ❖ After the Battle of Embabo:-
 - **Leqa-Naqamte**
 - **Leqa-Qellem** and
 - **Jimma Abba Jifar**
 } submitted to Menilek peacefully, who promised them to recognize and maintain their autonomy.
- ❖ Meanwhile,
 - **Garbi Jilo** (Leqa-Billo)
 - **Tucho Dano** (Leqa-Horda)
 - **Ligdi Bakare** (Leqa-Naqamte)
 - **Genda Busan** (Sibu-Sire)
 - **Mardasa Konche** (Nonno Migira), and
 - **Turi Jagan** (Nonno Rogge)
 } formed a coalition and defeated Menilek's army led by the Nadew brothers, **Dasta, Dilinesaw** and **Tesemma** at the **Battle of Gurra Doba**.
- ❖ Similarly, **west of the Dhidhessa River**, an alliance of:-
 - **Wachu Dabalo** of Sibu,
 - **Jorgo Dagago** of Noole Kabba and others
 } fought Menilek's local allies like **Moroda** and **Amante Bakare** at **Sambo Darro**. Later, however, they were defeated.
- ❖ In the Gibe region, **Firissa** of **Guma** fought Menilek's army from **1889 to 1901**. The imperial army faced similar resistance from **Abba Bosso of Gomma**, although defeated by **Ras Demisew Nesibu** in early **1900**. Also, **Ras Tesemma Nadew's** force incorporated **Ilu Abba Bor** into the imperial state after fighting with **Fatansa** at **Qarsa Gogila**.

- ❖ Of all the campaigns **Nigus Menelik** conducted before he became emperor, perhaps, the most sustained **bloody wars** were those of against the **Arsi Oromo**. In Arsi:-
 - Six different campaigns from 1882-6 were carried to control this vast region.
 - Menilek encountered fierce resistance from the Arsi Oromo led by notables like **Sufa Kuso**, **Damu Usu**, **Lenjiso Diga**, **Gosa Dilamo** and **Roba Butta**.
 - Initially, **the Arsi Oromo defeated Menilek's force** at **Dodota** and **Qalata**. Yet, with intelligence service of local supporters, **Ras Darge Sahile-Selassie's force** defeated the Arsi Oromo at **the battle of Azule** on 6 September 1886. The **battle of Azule** was followed by **the Anole incident that inflicted heavy damage** to the Arsi Oromo in 1887.
- ❖ In the east, Menilek's commander, **Dejjach Wolde-Gabra'el**, fought against **Emir Abdullahi** (r.1885-1887) of the **Harari** and **Bakar Ware** of the **Itu-Humbanna**. Yet, the resisting forces were defeated in the final engagement **at Chalanqo** on 6 January 1887. This was followed by the appointment of **Dejjach (later Ras) Makonnen Wolde Mikael** as governor of the province (Harar) by **Emperor Menilek II**.
- ❖ **The Great Famine or Kifu Qen (Evil Day)** of **1888-92** also contributed to Menilek's territorial expansion to parts of southern Ethiopia. Accordingly, Menilek's army occupied:-
 - **Dawuro-Konta** in **1889**
 - **Kambata** in **1890**
 - From the early **1890s to 1894**, Menilek's army controlled **Bale, Sidama, Gamo Gofa and Wolayta**.
- ☞ **In the campaign to Wolayta**, Emperor Menilek and many notables such as
 - *Ras Mikael of Wollo,*
 - *Fitawrari Gebeyehu Gurmu,*
 - *Liqe Mekwas Abate Buayalew,*
 - *Dejjach Balcha Safo,*
 - *Ras Wolde-Giorgis, and*
 - *Abba Jifar II of Jimma.*

} were participated.
- ☞ **Wolayta's resistance** led by **Kawo (King) Tona** against Menilek's force was defeated in **1894** in which **large number of people lost their lives**. This was followed by the incorporation of **Gedeo, Borana and Konso** into the imperial state.
- ❖ **Menilek's force** incorporated **Kafa, Beni-Shangul, and Gambella** **after the battle of Adwa**.
- ❖ The **process of the incorporation of Kafa paralleled the Wolayta** experience in terms of **human cost**. **In 1897**, the king of Kafa, **Tato Gaki Sherocho**, fought and lost to Menilek's army led by **Ras Wolde Giorgis**.
- ❖ **Beni-Shangul** was incorporated after the **Battle of Fadogno** in **1897/98**. This was followed by the occupation of **Maji** in **1898/99**. **Tesema Nadew** also controlled **Baro (Sobat)** and **Nasir in Gambella** around this time.

Focus

Three events facilitated the success of Menelik's expansion as king of Shoa were:

- The Liche Agreement (1878) reduced the tensions with Emperor Yohannis. It freed Menelik to concentrate on the conquest of new areas (expansion to south, southeast and southwest).
- The Battle of Embabo (1882) eliminated a strong rival of Menelik, King Tekle Haymanot of Gojjam, from the resourceful regions of the southwest. Following the battle, Menelik got royal recognition (recognition of Emperor Yohannes IV) to his expansion in that direction.
- His commercial relations with the Italians, mainly after the treaty he signed with Italy in 1883, enabled Menelik to import firearms which his troops used for suppressing rebellions and local resistance.

- ❖ The process of territorial expansion was consummated with the singing of boundary agreements with the neighboring colonial powers **that continued until 1908**. Most of these treaties were signed after the victory of Adwa. After Menelik, **the process of centralization and establishing a unitary state** continued by abolishing regional autonomies in the early decades of the 20th century. In the process,

- Wollo (after the battle of **Segele in 1916** when *Nigus Mika'el* was defeated),
 - Begemidir (after the **battle of Anchim** at which *Ras Gugsu Wole* was defeated in 1930),
 - Gojjam in 1932 and
 - Jimma in 1933
- } were reduced to mere provinces by **Teferi-Mekonnen** (Haile Sillassie I)

6.3. Modernization Attempts

- ❖ The period from 1800 to 1941 also witnessed efforts to adopt western ideas and technology by **Ethiopian monarchs**. Although several Ethiopian regional rulers were interested in European technologies, **Emperor Tewodros** had preferable degree of information/contact about western technologies than his predecessors. The **former Kasa Hailu the later, Emperor Tewodros** was well aware of the importance of European technologies to transform his people and country. For this purpose, **he attempted to approach Europeans for the introduction of western science and technologies**.
- ❖ It is apparent that, **Kasa's defeat** by the well-trained and equipped **Egyptian troops** at **the Battle of Dabarki in 1848** had made him think putting the country "on an equal footing with European powers." As a monarch, **Tewodros took a number of military, administrative and socio-economic reform measures**.
 - **As regards the army, Tewodros:-**
 - ✓ introduced military titles, like ***Yasr Aleqa, Yamsa Aleqa, and Yeshe Aleqa***.
 - ✓ tried to **organize and replace the regional armies** of the *Zemene-Mesafint* with **salaried national army**.
 - ✓ tried to **manufacture firearms** at his workshop, **Gafat (near Debre Tabor)** with the help of European missionaries and artisans. At Gafat, about **35 cannons** were produced of which the biggest one was known as **"Sebastopol."**
 - ✓ tried to build a small navy in Lake Tana.
 - **The administrative reforms** of Tewodros were focused on **the centralization of power and securing financial base**. Tewodros:-
 - ✓ introduced a policy of **"general pacification"**, warning everyone should return to his **lawful avocation**, the **merchant to his store**, and the **farmer to his plough**.
 - ✓ tried to **separate church and the monarchy**. He **reduced the church land** and the **number of priests and deacons** that brought him into conflict with the EOC which precipitated his downfall.
 - **In the case of socio-economic reforms**, Tewodros:-
 - ✓ began the construction of Ethiopia's **first embryonic road network** to **link Debre Tabor with Gondar, Gojjam, and Maqdela**.
 - ✓ attempted to **put an end to the slave trade**.
 - **Other reform attempts include:-**
 - ✓ land reform and banning of polygamy.
 - ✓ The **use of Amharic became more developed**, established a **traditional library at Maqdela** that contributed for the **development of literary Amharic**. He wrote **letters after letters** to different foreign powers including to Queen Victoria **using Amharic language**.

- ✓ With regard to religion, he **tried to solve the doctrinal controversy** that continued from the 17th century within the EOC.
- ☞ However, Tewodros' reforms were **not fully materialized** owing to **internal oppositions and external challenges**.
- ❖ **Emperor Yohannes' reign** also witnessed several **important reforms and innovations**. Among these he:-
 - was the first **Ethiopian monarch to appoint foreign consul** who served as his representative in London.
 - hired a French mechanic, a Hungarian gunsmith, and an Italian construction worker to assist his modernization efforts of the country. Furthermore, he **sent some individuals abroad for modern education**.
 - was also the first to introduce **modern style vaccine** against smallpox replacing traditional inoculation. His reign also witnessed extensive treatment of syphilis in several towns.
- ❖ **Modernization attempts** of the reign of **Emperor Menilek** had **diverse elements**. The post-Adwa period was marked by the establishment of:-
 - a **postal service** and **telecommunications/ the telephone-telegraph system**,
 - the beginning of **construction of railway line** from Djibouti to Addis Ababa,
 - the **opening of a bank** (the **Bank of Abyssinia**) and the **introduction of paper money**.
 - In terms of administration, the emperor **introduced a European style ministerial system/ministers in 1907**. Accordingly, he appointed:-
 - ✓ *Afe-Nigus Nesibu Meskelo* (Minister of Justice),
 - ✓ *Azazh Metaferia Melke-Tsadiq* (Minister of Imperial Court),
 - ✓ *Bejirond Mulugeta Yigezu* (Minister of Finance),
 - ✓ *Fitawurari Habte-Giorgis Dinagde* (Minister of War),
 - ✓ *Negadras Hailegiorgis Weldemikael* (Minister of Commerce and Foreign Relations), and
 - ✓ *Tsehafe-Tizaz Gebreselase Welde Aregay* (Minister of Pen).
 - Menilek II's reign also witnessed:-
 - ✓ the opening of a **hotel in 1907 (Itege Hotel)**,
 - ✓ the opening of a **modern school (Menilek II School in 1908)** and
 - ✓ the foundation of **Russian Red Cross hospital in 1906** and **Russian-run hospital (Menilek II Hospital) in 1910**.
- ☞ After **Emperor Menelik II** faced **permanent ailment** that incapacitated him, he designated and eventually **proclaimed Lij Iyasu and Ras Tesemma Nadew as heir to the throne and regent, respectively**.
- ❖ During his short stay in power, *Lij Iyasu* (1913-16) also took several reform measures. The reforms are:-
 - the banning of the **Quragna system**, a system that involved chaining the applicant and defendant as well as creditor and debtor until justice was settled.
 - the amendment of **Leba Shay**, a customary mode of detection of criminals or theft.
 - the introduction of **municipal police** called **Tirnbulle**.
 - the introduction of a **policy of auditing of government accounts**, and
 - an attempt to **integrate Ethiopian Muslims into the administration structure**.
 - the **introduction of a flourmill** that functioned mechanically and private industrial enterprises like **sawmill, a grinding-mill, a tannery, a soap-factory**, etc.
- ❖ During the **Dual Rule of Empress Zewditu and Ras Teferi** (r. 1916-1930), there were several modernization attempts in broader scope. The two rulers namely **Ras Teferi and Empress Zewditu** had **different views towards western culture**. Because of his close link with foreigners, **Ras**

Teferi had keen interest to modernization by which he wanted to boost the country's image on the international stage. This was marked by **the entry of Ethiopia into the League of Nations and his grand tour to Europe in 1923 and 1924, respectively**. Some remarkable reforms based on European model took place following his coronation as Emperor Haile-Selassie I in 1930. Some of the reforms were:-

- the centralization of the government,
- the **promulgation of Ethiopia's first constitution in 1931** (despite its drawbacks),
- the establishment of **Imperial Body Guard in 1930**, with the help of **Belgian military mission** and
- the **opening of Ethiopia's first Military Academy at Holeta** by the help of a **Swedish military mission in 1934**.

☞ Empress Zewditu was traditionalist.

6.4. Socio-Economic Developments

- ❖ The period from 1800 to 1941 was also marked by **changes in socio-economic conditions** including trade, slavery and slave trade, agriculture, urbanization and manufacturing. **Factors for these changes** included the socio-economic dynamics in the region and the world.

6.4.1. Agriculture and Land Tenure

- ❖ The nineteenth and early twentieth centuries were times:-
 - when agricultural economy grew and
 - when the demand for land for cultivation and grazing increased.
- ❖ The system **avored the powerful groups to control land** that resulted in the change of property right or the preexisting land tenure system.
- ❖ **The role of agriculture in the local economy and the politics of the period** could be understood from **the territorial competition and expansions to control surplus producing areas**. This altered people's relation to land, making some privileged and others unprivileged.
- ❖ **The quest for land and surplus production were one factor for territorial expansion by Menilek in the late nineteenth century**.
- ❖ Land was required, among others, **to settle and feed the warriors and their families**. Hence, the incorporation of **the southern half of the country** into the imperial state resulted in the redefinition of access to resources in these regions.
- ❖ The **state institutionalized different forms of surplus expropriation and mechanisms to ensure political control** in the **regions peacefully submitted** and **those that resisted**.
 - The **regions peacefully submitted** relatively enjoyed self-administration but were **subjected to pay qurt-gibir (fixed tax)**.
 - The **regions refused to peacefully submit** were **placed under the naftegna-gabbar/gabbar-naftegna system** whereby local peoples were made to pay tribute to the former.
- ☞ Gradually, **the naftegna-gabbar system** led to the evolution of **a new tenure regime in the forcefully incorporated areas**.
- ☞ Literally, **naftegna means a person with a gun**. In this context, **naftegna refers to soldiers of different social backgrounds who stationed in the southern territories under the imperial banner**. In the latter case, the major force of change was the settlement and exploitative nature of the system that altered both settlement pattern and agricultural system.
- ☞ One **effect of the institution of the naftegna-gabbar system** was **the creation of classes like**
 - landlords
 - ballabat,
 - gabbar and
 - tenants.

- The landholders were largely **government agents** while the local population were reduced in time into **gabbar and later tenants**.
- ❖ One major factor that brought change to agricultural practices including land tenure system was **the beginning of the qalad system (land measurement)** in the 1890s.
- ❖ **Land measurement** affected access to agricultural resources in diverse ways including **changes to customary rules of access to land**.
- ❖ **Qalad introduced fresh rules** in which **certain social classes gained access to land** while at the same time it resulted in **the dispossession of the local peasantry in parts of the south**. Later, **land was categorized into:-**
 - lam (cultivated),
 - lam-taf (partly-cultivated)
 - and taf (uncultivated)

} to facilitate taxation.

6.4.2. Slavery and Slave Trade

- ❖ Earlier in this unit, we have learned that both **local and long-distance trade had flourished** in the nineteenth century. The major commodities traded were **ivory, slaves, civet, and gold**. **Slavery and slave trade** had long history in Ethiopia and the Horn.
 - ✓ **Most slaves in Ethiopia** were kept as **domestic slaves** and some were **sold to Egypt** and the **Middle East** and the **Ottoman Empire** through the **Sudan, the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden ports**.
 - ✓ **During the nineteenth century**, in some parts of Ethiopia, slaves were required for **agricultural works, in the army** and **as sources of revenue** through **selling into slavery**. Thus, **several regional and local rulers enslaved people for these purposes**.
 - ✓ **Slaves were traded as commodities in local and international markets**. For instance,
 - It was **in 1837** that slave raiders captured **Bilile from Guma** and sold her to a German prince, **Herman Pickler Muskau** at **Cairo** who **changed her name to Mahbuba** and **made her his mistress**.
 - Similarly, **Hika (later Onesimos Nasib)** was kidnapped **in 1869** in **Hurumu** when he was four years old. He was **sold at Massawa**, later freed by a **Swedish mission**, and **translated the Bible** into **Afan Oromo** at **Menkulu (in Eritrea)**.
 - **Aster Gano** was also sold into slavery **from Limmu**. But **in 1886**, she was **emancipated** and **assisted Onesimos in the translation of the Bible**.
 - ✓ **During the nineteenth century, slave trade expanded in Ethiopia and the Horn** due to increased **demand for slaves in foreign markets** largely in **the Middle East**. This was followed by the emergence of **market centers from Bonga to Metemma and Massawa**. **Selling slaves was source of revenue for many local chiefs**.
 - ✓ **Slaves were acquired through:-**
 - raiding,
 - kidnapping,
 - war captivity,
 - debt bondage, and
 - purchase from open markets.
 - ✓ **Major sources of slaves** were **southern and southwestern parts of Ethiopia**.
 - ✓ Emperors **Tewodros II, Yohannes IV and Menilek II** tried to stop the slave trade although not slavery itself. **In 1923, Ras Teferi banned slave trade** which eventually came out in a **decree in 1924 to emancipate slaves**. This was followed by the establishment of the **Office for the Abolition of Slavery** in 1932. **Freed slaves were kept under the overall supervision of Hakim Worqineh Eshete**.

- ✓ The Italians **proclaimed the abolition of slavery** immediately after their occupation of the country. **After liberation, the Emperor issued a new decree in 1942 abolishing any forms of slave trade and the institution of slavery itself.** But, **slavery continued especially in some parts of the country well into the 1970s.** The impact was obviously social and economic deterioration of the source areas, families and suffering of the slaves themselves.

6.4.3. Manufacturing

- ❖ In many cultures in Ethiopia and the Horn, there were **age-old indigenous ways of producing/making tools.** Such manufacturing activities involved:-
 - simple procedures and techniques and
 - production of limited quantity of items.
- ✚ For instance, different items like **furniture, dresses and food including local drinks,** were produced and processed by using traditional techniques involving manual labor.
- ❖ One result of **the contact with the industrialized world since the mid nineteenth century** was the **introduction of manufacturing technologies.** Although evidences do not trace the exact period of the beginning of modern industry in Ethiopia, there is a consensus that the strong interest of rulers in the region for the introduction of western technologies and the subsequent contacts with the industrial world since **the mid nineteenth century** contributed to the introduction of manufacturing industries.
- ❖ **The beginning of diplomatic relations and opening of legations in the post-Adwa period** was followed by the **coming of many expatriates,** who **either came with the skill or became agents of the introduction of modern manufacturing.** Foreign citizens from Armenia, Greece, Italy and India also **brought the entrepreneurial capacity to develop manufacturing industries** locally. Among modern manufacturing industries were,
 - Holeta Grain Mill set up in 1896 and
 - Massawa Salt Processing established in 1904.
- ✚ Up to 1927, about **25 factories** were established in Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, Asmara and Massawa. These included:-
 - ✓ cement factories,
 - ✓ wood and clay workshops,
 - ✓ tanneries,
 - ✓ soap and edible oil plants,
 - ✓ ammunition factories,
 - ✓ breweries,
 - ✓ tobacco processing plants and
 - ✓ grain mills.
- ☞ **Most of them** were **established by private entrepreneurs.** Among these, Artistic Printing Press and Ambo Mineral Water plant were **established before the Italian occupation.**
- ✚ After 1928, **including in the short lived Italian occupation,** more than **ten manufacturing industries** were set up.

6.4.4. Urbanization

- ❖ The period **from the early nineteenth century to 1941** marked the evolution of towns stemming from **political, socio-economic, demographic and ecological** factors.
- ❖ During the period, **the expansion of both local and long distance trade** since the **early nineteenth century transformed old markets and socio-political centers into towns** in Ethiopia and the Horn. In this case,
 - several towns located on the **long-distance** trade in western Ethiopia grew into both towns and political centers.

- the beginning of **railway** connecting Djibouti and Addis Ababa as of 1917 was followed by the evolution of several fast growing towns. Towns including **Dire Dawa, Adama, Bishoftu, Metahara and others** were results of the extension of the railway and the expansion of trade.
- On the other hand, **politico-religious centers** in several parts of the region evolved into towns. This was true mainly in the northern parts of Ethiopia.
- Many centers that once served as "**royal camps**" evolved into towns and **parallel to this many towns declined with the demographic change when "royal camps" shifted to other centers**. One of the towns that grew from such process was **Addis Ababa**. Entoto or Dildila (its weather is cold and has steep land surface) was Menelik's royal court before Addis Ababa or *Finfine*). Addis Ababa was founded in 1886.
 - ✓ **Empress Taytu Betul chose the place for its hot springs, Fel-Wuha (formerly called Hora Finfinne).**
 - ✓ Similarly, as of the late nineteenth century, **in southern Ethiopia, a number of towns emerged when Menilek's generals established garrisons** in suitable locations in order to maintain control of the occupied provinces. The presence of the governors and soldiers made such areas permanent areas of politico-economic and religious activities. Such **centers of administration known as *katamas* (garrison towns) became centers of trade and eventually grew into towns**. Towns including **Gobba, Ticho, Gore, Arjo, etc** were garrisons that grew into towns. **During the Italian rule (1936-41), several of the above towns grew in size and other new towns evolved** because of socio-economic and political developments of the period.

6.5. External Relations

- ❖ One consequence of the *Zemene-Mesafint* was the end of the 'close door policy' that was introduced by Emperor Fasiladas (1632-1667). Thus, **beginning from the early 1800s, regional rulers made independent foreign contacts and signed treaties**. During the nineteenth century, the agents of these external relations were mainly **travelers**. **Travelers came to Ethiopia and the Horn,**
 - ✓ with the motives of adventure and scientific research. They were also
 - ✓ sometimes, to get involved in fostering friendship and trade relation on behalf of their governments.
 - ✓ Some of them, however, **came with covert mission of colonialism**. Meanwhile, various rulers of Ethiopia and the Horn had also dispatched their own delegations to various countries of the world.
- ✚ One of the **earliest** private travelers was **Henry Salt** who **reached the court of Ras Wolde-Selassie of Tigray on 28 August 1805**. He:
 - ✓ came for scientific reasons, but he claimed that his mission was to establish friendship between Great Britain and Ethiopia.
 - ✓ returned to Ethiopia in 1809 and concluded agreement with the Ras.
- ✚ Several British travelers including **Christian Kugler** also arrived in the 1830s.
- ✚ Travelers from Germany like **Eduard Ruppell** (a scholar) arrived in 1846;
- ✚ **Captain W.C. Harris**, leading an official British mission visited Shewa.
- ✚ **John Bell and Walter Plowden** in the 1840s,
- ✚ The Italian Geographic Society in 1869 and the like arrived for trade relation and scientific purposes.
- ☞ The result of these contacts was the agreement/treaty signed between:-
 - ✓ **Negus Sahle-Selassie** of Shewa and **British Captain W. Harris** in 1841.
 - ✓ **French Rochet d'Hericourt**, in 1843.

- ✓ Walter Plowden and *Ras Ali* in 1849.
- ✚ Furthermore, **other regional lords had contacts with religious centers in the Middle East, particularly with Jerusalem.** During the period, Egyptians threatened the Ethiopian religious community settlement at Deir Al-Sultan in Jerusalem. As a result, in the early 1850s, strong lords like *Ras Ali* and *Dejjazmach Wube* sent letters to **Queen Victoria of England** to request support against the Egyptians.
- ❖ **External relations during the reign of Tewodros II seemed more elaborate and oriented towards obtaining western technology and military support** to defend foreign aggression.
- ❖ As with his predecessors, **Emperor Yohannes IV** tried to create strong relations with Europeans. The **major concerns of Emperor Yohannes IV were:-**
 - ✓ the restoration of the lost territories,
 - ✓ the delimitation of boundaries and
 - ✓ the defense of the sovereignty of the state against the threat and interference by foreign powers. **When he confronted external challenge like Egypt, he tried to solve through negotiation than war.** War was his last choice as he **fought with Egypt in 1875/76 and Mahdist Sudan in 1889.**
- ☞ **One of the major diplomatic relations Yohannes concluded was Hewett /Adwa Treaty.** It was a treaty signed between the **Emperor and the British Rear Admiral William Hewett on behalf of Egypt on 3 June 1884 at Adwa.** The purpose was to safely evacuate Egyptian troops through Ethiopia who were trapped by the Mahdist troops along the Ethio-Sudanese border. In return, Bogos was to be restored to Ethiopia and the latter was to freely use Massawa for the transit of goods and firearms. Based on the agreement,
 - Emperor Yohannes facilitated the safe evacuation of Egyptian troops through his territory.
 - Britain restored Bogos to Ethiopia. However, **Britain secretly transferred Massawa from Egypt to Italy in February 1885.**
- ✚ **One consequence of the treaty was Mahdist determination to avenge Yohannes** that led to the battle of Metemma on 9 March 1889 which claimed his death.
- ❖ In terms of diplomatic relations and repulsing external threats, **Emperor Menilek II was more successful through maintaining the balance among powerful forces of the period.** **While he was king of Shewa,** he established **commercial relation with Italy** that later helped him to acquire military equipment.
- Menelik's relations with Italy reached its climax with **the signing of the Wuchale Treaty.** It was drafted by Count Pietro Antonelli and signed on 2 May 1889, **at Wuchale, Wollo between Emperor Menilek II of Ethiopia and Antonelli on behalf of Prime Minister Crispi of Italy.** The treaty has twenty articles and was written both in Amharic and Italian languages.
 - ✓ The **Italian version of Article III** indicates the “effective occupation” of Italy to legitimize its further expansion towards the Mereb River. However, **Article XVII** has major difference in the two language versions.
 - ✓ **The Amharic version states that Ethiopia could optionally conduct its foreign affairs through Italy, the Italian version indicates that Menilek's foreign contacts must be through the agency of Italy.** As a result, based on the Italian version of Article XVII, Italy announced that all foreign powers had to deal with Ethiopia only through Italy. **European powers gave recognition to this Italian claim except Russia.** In January 1890, the Italian government **formally declared Eritrea as its colony.**
- ☞ Italian action to colonize Ethiopia through tricky treaties; persuasion and the subversive methods failed. This was because:-
 - Menilek publicly abrogated the Wuchale Treaty unilaterally in February 1893 and

- Tigrian lords including *Ras Mangasha Yohannes*, *Ras Sebat Aragawi* and *Dajjach Hagos Tafari*, began to fight against the Italians collaborating with Emperor Menilek.
- ☞ Italian determination to occupy Ethiopia and Ethiopian resistance against colonialism led to the battle. This finally **led to the Battle of Adwa**, where the latter became victorious. **After the victory of Adwa, different foreign countries opened their legations at Addis Ababa to establish relations on official basis.**
- ☞ Furthermore, Emperor Menilek made boundary agreements with the then neighboring colonial powers like:-
 - French-Somaliland (the present day Djibouti) on 20 March 1897
 - British-Somaliland (now Somaliland) on June 1897
 - Anglo-Egyptian Sudan on 15 May 1902
 - The Italian colony of Eritrea on 10 July 1900
 - British East Africa (Kenya) in 1907 and
 - Italian-Somaliland in 1908. These boundary agreements shaped modern Ethiopian boundary.
- ❖ International politics of the twentieth century also shaped Ethiopia's foreign relations. For instance, during the First World War (1914-18) *Lij Iyasu* showed a tendency to **side with the Central Powers (Germany, Austro-Hungary, Bulgaria and Ottoman Empire)** believing that **the defeat of the Allied powers (France and Britain)** would **allow Ethiopia to push Italy out of Eritrea and Somalia**. He also befriended the Somali nationalist leader, Sayyid Mohammed Abdille Hassan, **against Italy and Britain**. Sayyid Mohammed Abdille Hassan (1864-1920) led the Somali against the European occupation. He tried to attract support from the mass through his **Pan-Somali movement**. In the history of the Somali, he is recognized as a forerunner of modern Somali nationalism.
- ☞ **One of the successes of Ethiopia's foreign relation in the early twentieth was her admission to the League of Nations in 1923.** A year later, Teferi made **his grand European tour in 1924** which **shaped his ideas of modernization**. Ethiopia's entry into the League of Nations, however, **did not save her from Italian invasion in 1935/36.**

6. 5. 1. Major Battles Fought Against Foreign Aggressors and Patriotism

- ❖ Ethiopian people **fought several battles** against foreign threats during the period under discussion. The major ones are the following.
- ☞ **The Battle of Dabarki (1848):** Dabarki was **fought between Kasa Hailu of Qwara and Egyptian forces** in 1848. Although the forces led by **Kasa Hailu lost the battle**, the military imbalance particularly, the modern artillery and discipline of Egyptian troops gave him a lesson to modernize his military force, acquire modern technologies. This later initiated him to widen his vision and mission when he became emperor.
- ☞ **The Battle of Maqdela (1868):** Tewodros II had early **relation with Britain** through the two British citizens, Walter Plowden and John Bell. His main aim was to obtain help against foreign threats. To this end:-
 - In 1862, he sent a letter to Queen Victoria requesting assistance through Consul Cameron. Cameron came **back to Ethiopia via Egypt without bringing any response**. Suspecting him as plotting with Egypt, Tewodros imprisoned Captain Cameron and **other Europeans**.
 - On learning the imprisonment of the Europeans, Queen Victoria sent a letter **through Hormuzd Rassam** which did not satisfy Tewodros. After some communications, **the British parliament decided to take military action**. Subsequently, 32,000 troops led by Sir Robert Napier were sent through Massawa. **This force reached Maqdela** guided by
 - ✓ *Dejazmach* Bezibiz Kassa of Tigray (later Emperor Yohannes) and

✓ Wagshum Gobeze of Lasta.

- ⌚ On April 10, 1868, up to 8,000 Tewodros' soldiers including his general Gebriye were defeated by the British at the battle of **Aroge**. On April 13, 1868, **Tewodros** committed suicide at **Maqdela**. This was followed by:-

- ✓ the **burning of his fortress** and
- ✓ looting of **manuscripts, religious and secular artifacts** including his **crown** by the **British troops**.

☞ The Battles of Gundet and Gura

- ❖ In the nineteenth century, Egyptians showed a **keen interest to occupy Northeast Africa** with the **ambition of controlling the source of the Nile**. Following their occupation of the Sudan in 1821, they moved to occupy Ethiopia on several occasions. For instance, in 1875, Khedive Ismail Pasha sent his troops to invade Ethiopia in three directions. Accordingly:-

- ✓ **Mohammed Rauf Pasha** led the **Zeila front** and the result was the **occupation of the Harar Emirate** between **1875 and 1885**.
- ✓ **Werner Munzinger**, the architect of the whole of Ismail's scheme for invasion of Ethiopia, led about 500 Egyptian troops equipped with cannons and rocket tubes **through Tajura**. But, **Munzinger** and his troops were all **killed by the Afars** at **the Battle of Odduma**.
- ✓ **Finally, Colonel Arendrup and Arakel Bey** led another 2,000 well-armed troops through **Massawa**. **Emperor Yohannes IV and Ras Alula** mobilized about 20,000 forces and encountered the Egyptians at the **Battle of Gundet (16 November 1875)** where the Egyptian troops were severely defeated. Notwithstanding their setback, Egyptians again reorganized their forces to avenge Ethiopia and sent their army under the command of **Muhammad Ratib Pasha** that assisted by **General Loring**, an American officer in the *Khedive's* service and other military commanders most of them were Americans to invade Ethiopia. However, the Ethiopian forces again defeated them at **the Battle of Gura** (7–9 March, 1876).

- ⌚ It is important to understand some Europeans were in the service of Egyptians. For instance,

- The architect of the whole of Ismail's plan, **Werner Munzinger**, was a **Swiss born** adventurer and former **French Consul in Northeast Africa**.
- **Colonel Arendrup** himself was a **Danish Citizen**, and
- **General Charles Stone** was fellow **American**.

☞ The Battle of Dogali

- ❖ During the **late nineteenth century**, Europeans had **interest to control the Red Sea area**. With the opening of the **Suez Canal in 1869**, the Red Sea region acquired great strategic and commercial importance. **One of the colonial powers with interest in the Horn of Africa** was **Italy**.

- ✓ The relations Italy had with the Horn began when an **Italian private shipping company (Rubatino)** had **bought the port of Assab** from the local chiefs in 1869.
- ✓ In 1882, **the port of Assab** was transferred to Italian government.
- ✓ In 1885, **Britain** secretly transferred **Massawa from Egypt to Italy**. By using these bases as spring board, Italy began to penetrate into northern Ethiopia.

- ⌚ Subsequently, **the Italian forces occupied Sa'ati, Aylet and Wia** in the then **Mereb Milash** region. However, **they were defeated** decisively at **the Battle of Dogali (1887)** by **Ras Alula Engida (Alula Aba Nega)**, Emperor Yohannes's famous general and right hand man.

- Following this battle, **Italy signed a Treaty of Neutrality with Menilek** in **October 1887** in a bid to **neutralize Menelik** so as to isolate Emperor Yohannes.

☞ The Battle of Metemma

❖ As indicated above, the **Hewett Treaty** caused **clashes** between the **Mahdist and Ethiopian forces** that lasted from **1885 to 1889**.

- The first clash was at **Kufit** between **Ras Alula** and **Uthman Digna** in September 1885. Initially, the Ethiopian force was victorious. However, when **Emperor Yohannes IV** was in northern Ethiopia to check the Italian advance to **Mereb Milash**, he heard the **Mahadist advance up to Gondar**. The Mahdists caused a lot of destruction on churches and monasteries, including the killing of the clergy and the laity.
- **In January 1887**, Yohannes ordered **Nigus Tekle Haymanot of Gojjam** to repulse the Mahdists. A year later, the Mahdists led by **Abu Anja**, defeated **Nigus Tekle Haymanot's troops** at **Sar Wuha** in Dembia. At this important juncture, **Nigus Menelik and Nigus Teklehaimanot conspired** against the emperor, instead of directly facing the Mahdists. As a result, Emperor Yohannes faced what can be called **the triangular tension**, namely the **Italians in the north**, the **Mahdists in the west and northwest**, and **his two vassals in the center**.
- Later, in another direction, **the Mahdists** were defeated at **Gute Dilli (in Najjo-Wallagga)** by **Menilik's** commander **Ras Gobana Dacci** on **14 October 1888**. Emperor Yohannes made a national call:

“የኢትዮጵያ ህዝብ ሆይ! ኢትዮጵያ የተባባሸችው ሀገር፡ 1ኛ እናትህ ናት፤ 2ኛ ከብርህ ናት፤ 3ኛ ሚስትህ ናት፤ 4ኛ ልጅህ ናት፤ 5ኛ መቃብርህ ናት። እንግዲህ የእናትን ፍቅር፡ የዘዉድን ከብር፡ የሚስትን የዋህት፡ የልጅን ደስታ፡ የመቃብርን ከባድነት አስበህ ተነስ!”

Literally, “Oh, the people of Ethiopia, The country called Ethiopia is firstly your mother, secondly your crown, thirdly your wife, fourthly your child, fifthly your grave. Accordingly, rise up understanding the love of a mother, honor of a crown, the goodness of a wife, the delight of having a child, and the shelter of a grave.”

Hence, on **9 March 1889**, the Emperor (Yohannes IV) marched to **Metemma where he died** fighting the Mahdists. Evidently, it has to be noted here that **internal divisions and acrimonies among rulers** would result in a huge cost to the country and its peoples. Among others, **Maqdela and Metemma** are very **good testimonies**.

☞ **The Battle of Adwa and Its Aftermath**

❖ The **disagreement on the Wuchale Treaty** finally led to the **big battle between Ethiopia and Italian forces**. This was because **Italians were determined to colonize Ethiopia** whereas Ethiopians were ready not to give in. **To meet their intention**, the **Italians crossed the Mereb River and arrived at Adigrat and proceeded to Emba-Alage**.

- Following **Emperor Menelik's** proclamation for **general mobilization**, about **100,000 troops** from **every part of the country** gathered at **Wara-Illu** (in today's South Wollo). People marched to the front **irrespective of gender, regional, and ethnic differences** to fight against the Italian aggression. Accordingly:-
 - ✓ The force led by **Fitawrari Gebeyehu Gurmu** defeated the Italians at **Emba Alage** and forced them to retreat to **Mekelle**.
 - ✓ In January 1896, **under the leadership of Ras Mekonnen**, the Ethiopian forces defeated Italians at **Mekelle**. At Mekelle, **they came under siege** that prevented them access to a **well** which they **used for drinking**. The strategy was commonly called the “**siege of Mekelle**” and was considered to be **designed by Empress Taytu**. After some negotiations, the besieged Italian troops were **set free and joined their counterparts at Adwa**.
 - ✓ A month later, Ethiopian forces led by **Emperor Menilek, Empress Tayitu and war generals like Ras Mikael, Ras Makonnen, Ras Alula, Ras Mangasha and Negus Takla- Haymanot** and others **encountered the Italians at Adwa**.

- ☞ The result of this battle was a decisive victory for Ethiopians but a huge blow to the Italians which doomed their colonial ambition over Ethiopia. At this battle,
 - ⌚ On the Italian side:-
 - about 8,000 fighters were killed,
 - 1,500 wounded and
 - 3,000 were captured.
 - ⌚ On the Ethiopian side about 4,000-6,000 troops are said to have been killed.

Consequences of the victory of the battle of Adwa

- Italy **recognized the independence of Ethiopia** by the treaty of Addis Ababa that was **signed on October 26, 1896**.
- A number of powers of the time (including Italy, France, Britain, Russia, the United States, Germany, Belgium, Turkey, and others) also **recognized the independence of Ethiopia** and **opened their legations in Addis Ababa**. Italy in 1896, Britain in 1897, France in 1897, USA in 1903 and Germany in 1905.
- Despite different interpretations on the results of the battle of Adwa, the heroic national campaign, cooperation and common successes of peoples of Ethiopia **had a positive implication for success and national integration**.
- Has witnessed independence and national pride. It has thus become a source of pride for **Ethiopians, Africans and the black race** in general.
- Has **had an enduring legacy** in the **relations between freedom fighters and colonizing powers**. The **victory of black people** on **white colonizers** initiated **entire Africans fighting against colonialism**. The well-known Pan-Africanist, **Marcus Garvey**, inspired his followers in his “Back to Africa” movement with the success of Ethiopians. He used phrases like “Ethiopia thou land of our fathers” and in countries of **Southern Africa**, it sparked the emergence of “religious separatist” movements known as **Ethiopianism**. The churches formed part of the general anti-colonialist struggle. **Ethiopianism** became a **symbol of anti-colonial movements**. **Japan** also used Ethiopia’s experience when it **fought against Russia in 1904**.
- In Italy, the defeats at Adwa aroused internal oppositions against the government of **Francesco Crispi** and **downfall of Crispi government**.
- **General Barateri**, the commander in-chief of the Italian army at battle of Adwa was **imprisoned by the Italian government**. European powers with adjacent colonies with Ethiopia signed treaties to delimitate their boundaries.

6. 5. 2. Italian Occupation (1936-41) and the Patriotic Resistance

A. Background

- ❖ Following their **defeat at Adwa in 1896**, the **Italians suspended their expansionist colonial policy** in Northeast Africa for a short time. However, they were **just waiting the right time to fulfill their interests** in any possible way. Italy eventually **got its ideological strength in 1922**, when Fascists led by **Benito Mussolini** held power. The Fascists were determined to restore the power and glory of ancient Roman Empire by **avenging Italy’s shameful scar at Adwa**.
- ❖ Initially, **Mussolini did not disclose his ambition against the sovereignty of Ethiopia** rather **he was playing diplomatic ‘cards’ till the coming of the ‘right time.’** To achieve their goal of occupation of Ethiopia, Italians followed two policies as it was the case before the Battle of Adwa;
 - 1/ ‘subversion’ and
 - 2/ ‘rapprochement’.

- ✚ **The policy of subversion aimed at affecting the unity of the empire** via sowing dissatisfaction in Tigray, Begemidir, Gojjam and Wollo. This responsibility was entrusted to Corrado Zoli, the governor of Eritrea (1928-1930).
- ✚ The Italian legation in Addis Ababa, headed by Guiliano Cora led **the policy of ‘rapprochement’, a pseudo reconciliation tactic** which was trying to persuade the Ethiopian government to establish cordial relations between the two countries. For instance,
 - ✓ the signing of the 1928 Italo-Ethiopian Treaty of Peace and Friendship was the manifestation of the success of the rapprochement policy. Here, beside their legation in Addis Ababa, the Italians had also consulates in provincial towns such as Dessie, Adwa, Debre Markos and Gondar. These consulates played a significant role in propagating dissatisfaction and gathering vital military and political intelligence. In addition to such preparations, the Fascists were also able to get indirect diplomatic support from Britain and France for their colonial project in Ethiopia. Here, although it is difficult to pinpoint one particular year when the decision was made by Mussolini to launch the intended invasion, 1932 appears to have been a crucial year.
- ☞ Mussolini who made all necessary preparations to launch an invasion against Ethiopia was only searching for a pretext, and then fortunately he found it in the **Walwal incident**. The **Walwal Incident (5 December 1934)** was **the result of the post-Awa boundary agreement limitations**:
 - lack of demarcation on the ground and
 - lack of effective administrative control in the frontier regions. However, the Italians refused to **give back Walwal** and even attacked the Ethiopian soldiers who were stationed nearby. Thus, this situation gave birth to the so called **Walwal Incident**.

Surprisingly, although the number of Ethiopians dead during this border clash was three times as high as the Italians, it was Italy which demanded totally unreasonable apology and reparation from Ethiopia. Then, Ethiopia which refused to accept Italy’s demand took the matter to the League of Nations and a period of diplomatic wrangling followed to resolve the dispute. However, in the meantime Mussolini, who already got the desired excuse, was finalizing his preparations to launch a total invasion.

B. The 1935 Invasion and After

- ❖ After they completed their preparations, the Italians waged their aggression via two major fronts:
 - The northern (in this front the Italian force was first commanded by Marshal Emilio De Bono, soon replaced by Badoglio) and
 - The southern front (in this front the Italian force was commanded by Marshal Rudolfo Graziani).
- ❖ The **war was started in the northern Front** when the Italians **crossed the Mereb River on 3 October 1935** and launched a three pronged invasion and **controlled Adigrat, Adwa and Mekelle**.
- ✚ In January 1936, **Ethiopian counter offensive marched north through three fronts**. i.e:-
 - Ras Emiru Haile-Selassie led the western front,
 - Ras Kasa Hailu (also commander of the entire northern front) and Ras Seyum Mengesha led the central front and
 - Ras Mulugeta Yigezu (War Minister) led the eastern front.
- ✚ On 20 January 1936, the Ethiopian army launched a major offensive against the Italians intending to isolate Mekelle, **but failed to realize its objective** due to lack of coordination among the above mentioned commanders.
- ✚ On January 24, **the Ethiopian force lost** to the Italians at **the first Battle in Temben**. This was followed by an attack on the Ethiopian force which was stationed in what seemed to be an impregnable natural fortress of **Amba Aradom**, to the south of Mekelle. The Italians scored yet another decisive victory in which the commander of the Ethiopian army, **Ras Mulugeta Yigezu**,

lost his life. Besides **modern weapons**, the Italian force had **superiority in the air**. Moreover, the **forces of Ras Kasa and Ras Seyum** were **outnumbered by the Italian troops**. This resulted in another defeat at **the Second Battle of Temben (27-29 February 1936)**. **Ras Kasa and Ras Seyum** narrowly escaped and **joined the Emperor at Korem**.

- ❖ **On the western front**, the Ethiopian army under **Ras Emeru** put strong resistance against the **advancing force of the Italians**. Thanks to **Ras Emeru's better leadership quality**, the number of death of Ethiopian soldiers was less than what it had been in **the northern front**.
- ❖ **A series of battles** between the Ethiopian and Italian forces **in the northern Front** culminated in **Maychew on 31 March 1936**. Although the Ethiopian army (especially members of **the Kibur Zebegna**) **under the command of the Emperor** put strong resistance against the Italians, they were not able to conclude the battle with victory. **Many Ethiopian soldiers lost their lives from**

- gunpowder and
- air bombardment during the battle. Then **the Italian forces** controlled **Dessie and Addis Ababa on 4 April 1936 and 5 May 1936, respectively**.

- ☞ **The Ethiopian army in the Southern Front** was better equipped and well led. **Ras Desta Damtew (in the south) and Dejazmach Nesibu Zamanuel (in the southeast)** were leaders of the Ethiopian troops in this Front. The **Ethiopian army lost to the Italians** at **two major battles in the Southern Front**:

- ✓ **Qorahe** (November 1935) and
- ✓ **Genale Dorya** (12-14 January 1936). In the ensuing battles, the **Askaris** (recruited from Eritrea) deserted the Italians and joined the Ethiopian force which boosted the moral of **Ras Desta's troops**. **Ras Desta** continued to challenge the Italians until he was **captured and executed in early 1937**. The number of soldiers the Italians lost during the fighting in the **Southern Front** was larger than the North, which **slowed their advance to the center**; **Badoglio** who used an internationally outlawed **poisoned gas** on the forces of Ethiopia **entered Addis Ababa before Graziani even crossed Harar**.

- ☞ **On 2 May 1936, the Emperor fled the country** and **three days later, the Italians entered Addis Ababa**. Between Haile Selassie's departure and the Italian entry, **Addis Ababa was beset by burning of buildings, looting and random shooting**. The major targets of the violence were:-

- the rich
- foreigners (many of them saved their lives by taking refuge in foreign legations) and
- the imperial palace.

- ⌚ Here, **the entry of the Italian forces into the capital** in the middle of such chaos was **a relief for both the foreigners and the natives since the Italians were able to bring peace and order to the city**. At this juncture, some scholars suggested that **the Italians deliberately delayed their entry so that the people of the city would consider them as 'angels' of peace, and easily accept their rule**. Anyway, after their control of the capital, **Marshal Pierto Badoglio** immediately reported the situation to Mussolini. **Benito Mussolini announced to the people of Italy and the world about their control of Ethiopia** using the phrase **"Ethiopia is Italian!"**

- ⌚ **The Italians immediately merged Ethiopia with their colonies of Italian Somaliland and Eritrea**. Then, they named the combination of their colonies **Italian East Africa (IEA) or Africa Orientale Italiana (AOI)**. The newly formed Italian East Africa **had six administrative regional divisions** that replaced former international boundaries. These were:

1. Eritrea (including Tigray) with its capital at Asmara;
2. Amhara (including Begemidr, Gojjam, Wollo and Northern Shewa) with its capital at Gondar;

3. Oromo and Sidama (including Southern and Southwestern provinces) with its capital at Jimma;
 4. Eastern Ethiopia with its capital at Harar;
 5. Somalia (including Ogaden) with its capital at Mogadishu;
 6. Addis Ababa (later changed to Shewa), the capital of the entire Italian East Africa.
- ⌚ During the Italian occupation of Ethiopia, the following Italians served as governors of Italian East Africa successively:
- Marshal Pierto Badoglio (till the end of May 1936),
 - Marshal Rudolfo Graziani (till February 1937), and
 - Finally Amadeo Umberto d'Aosta (the Duke of Aosta).
- ☞ Generally, **a top-heavy bureaucracy and corruption** characterized **the Italian administration of IEA**. For instance,
- The last governor of IEA, the **Duke of Aosta** himself characterized **50% of his officials as inept** and **25% as thieves**.
 - **Marshal Badoglio** himself reportedly pocketed about **1,700,000 Maria Theresa Thalers** confiscated from the Bank of Ethiopia, in the immediate aftermath of the conquest.
 - In the economic respect, **the Italians weakened and destroyed non-Italian foreign firms and replaced them with governmental enterprises** that **controlled the industry, trade and agriculture**.
- ☞ The Italians were **relatively successful in the sectors of trade and industry** as compared to the agricultural sector. For instance, **they planned to settle Italian farmers in selected Ethiopian areas** such as **Wegera, Chercher and Jimma**. However, **their agricultural plan was failed** (they only accomplished 10%) due to **their failure to secure the control of the rural areas due to the patriotic movement**. As indicated above, the Italian administrative control was largely confined to urban areas due to the strong patriotic resistance. Thus; **their legacy was also largely reflected in the towns than the rural areas**, which were actually out of the Italian effective rule. Generally, **the legacy of the Italian rule** can be summarized in the following brief points:
- ✚ **Architecture**- the Italians left an indelible mark in towns such as **Addis Ababa, Jimma, Adwa, Gondar, Desse, Harar, Asmara, Mogadishu** and others.
 - ✚ **Introduction of urban facilities** like **clean water and electricity**;
 - ✚ **Social legacies** (**expansion of prostitution, adoption of European habits-including eating and dressing styles, and adoption of Italian words**);
 - ✚ **The consolidation of cash economy**;
 - ✚ **Road construction and development of motor transport**;
 - ✚ **The sense of division**, etc.

C. The Patriotic Resistance Movement

- ❖ The **five-year Italian occupation (1936-41)** was not a smooth experience. Rather, the Ethiopian peoples opposed them in a number of ways. Among others, the patriots:-
 - gave them hard times largely in rural areas. They continuously harassed them.
 - continued their resistance in almost all regions and by all ethnic groups of the empire with varying degree of intensification.
- ❖ The **first phase of resistance** was **the continuation of the war itself**. Among the highlights of this phase was the resistance waged by **three commanders of the Southern Front**:-
 - *Ras Desta Damtew*
 - *Dejjach Beyene Merid* and
 - *Dejjach Gebre Maryam Gari*.

- ☞ An extension of this phase was a five pronged assault on the capital in the summer of 1936. The campaign had involved:-
 - **Two sons of Ras Kasa Hailu (Asfawesen and Aberra),**
 - The veteran of Adwa **Dejjach Balcha Safo,**
 - **Balambaras (later Ras) Abebe Aregay,** and
 - **Dejjach Fikremariam Yinnnadu.**
- ☞ However, **this phase of resistance was failed** because of **lack of effective means of transportation and radio communication**. **Abune Petros**, the Bishop of Wollo, who was the spirit behind the patriots was **executed** and became **a martyr of the resistance**. The killing of the bishop was unheard of in Ethiopia and shocked the nation, arousing the indignation of the people, especially the clergy.
- ❖ **The second phase covers from 1937 to the end of the Italian occupation in 1941.** On 19 February 1937, two young Ethiopian patriots, **Abreha Deboch and Moges Asgedom**, hurled a bomb at **Graziani in the Genete-Le'ul palace** compound at **Sidist Kilo**, wounding him seriously and killing some others. This was followed by **a reign of terror** waged by the **Black Shirts**; who
 - chopped off heads
 - burnt down houses with their inhabitants and
 - disemboweled thousands in Addis Ababa.
- ☞ According to Ethiopian official accounts, **about 30,000 Ethiopians of different ages, classes and sex were killed in three days' campaign.**
- ☞ Special targets of the Fascist terror were:-
 - educated Ethiopians (including many members of the **Black Lion Organization**).
 - The Ethiopian Orthodox Church. For instance, on 21 May 1937, in the monastery of Debre Libanos alone, 297 monks were executed.
- ☞ The **elimination of the intelligentsia** was to create **'the missing generation'** in Ethiopia's intellectual and political history.
- ❖ This **Fascist terror** marked **the transition from the conventional patriotic resistance to guerrilla warfare** that could eventually weaken the enemy forces. Different guerrilla units kept the Italian troops under constant harassment.
- ❖ As the Fascist regime became intolerable to Ethiopians, there were women who led their own army in the guerrilla wars, like:-
 - **Woizero Lekyelesh Beyan**, whose career as a guerrilla fighter ended in January 1941, when she was captured after an Italian air bombardment.
 - **Woizero Kebedech Seyoum** (a daughter of **Ras Seyum Mengesha** and the wife of **Dejjazmach Abera Kasa**), started her patriotic activity before the fall of Addis Ababa to the Italians. Thus, when her husband was fighting in the northern front, she maintained peace and order in the province of **Selalie** representing her husband.
- ❖ Although it **lacked coordination**, patriotic resistance to Italian rule took place in the country in numerous forms and tenacity. **There was no unified command structure**. In most provinces of the country, similar acts of resistance were observed. **Eritreans too were joining the resistance in big numbers**. A comprehensive list and explanation on each patriot in a module such as this would not be possible. However, hereunder an attempt has been made to **list a few patriots** that we think can represent different parts of Ethiopia. These were:-

• Dejjazmach Umar Samatar • Dejjazmach Belay Zeleke • Dejjazmach Abbbai Kahsay • Colonel Abdisa Aga	• Dejjazmach Gebrehiwot Meshesha • Colonel Jagama Kello • Zeray Dire • Major Matias Gemed
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- *Blatta* Takele Woldehawaryat
- W/o Sinidu Gebru
- W/o Shewareged Gedle
- *Ras* Amoraw Wubneh
- *Ras* Abebe Aregay
- *Dejjazmach* Habte Mariam
- Colonel Belay Haile-ab
- *Lij* Haile Mariam Mamo
- Captain Yosef Nesibu
- *Dejjach* Geresu Duki
- BekeleWoya,etc

Some patriots served as Yewust Arbegna. Contribution of Yewust Arbegnoch (“inner patriots”) was great.such as:-

- They were patriots who lived and often worked with the Italians in towns but supplied vital information to the patriots. Some members of this group used to give underground service to the patriots fighting in the bushes
- They contributed in the collection of arms, medicine, food and intelligence reports
- They arranged secret killings of Italian officials
- They collected arms from corrupt officials and deserters
- In addition to the underground activities, there were women that led their own troops in battles of resistance.

Note: The two Ethiopian nationals Zerai Deres and Abdisa Aga showed exemplary patriotism in Italy itself.

- **Zerai Deres** killed the Italian Fascist leaders at square in their own country where as
- **Abdisa Aga** conducted a long fight against the Fascist in their own country. He broke Italian prison
- ❖ The struggle continued but it suffered from **serious internal weakness**. That is:-
 - The resistance was handicapped by the **Ethiopian collaborators** called the **Banda** who exercised their corrosive activities in different areas.
 - The resistance movement was divided and there was **no one national organization to coordinate the activities of the many patriotic groups** dispersed in many parts of the country.
 - Relations between guerrilla groups were characterized by parochialism and jealousy. Some guerrilla groups spent more time fighting one another than attacking the declared enemy.
- ☞ **Despite these weaknesses**, the patriots carried on a persistent resistance against Italian fascism, until suddenly they got external support from Britain in 1941.
- ☞ **Ethiopian struggle for independence** was **associated with World War II**, when **Italy** declared war on **France** and **Britain** on **10 June 1940**.
 - **Mussolini** decided to enter the war on the side of **Germany** in the hope of securing outside support; the **internationalization of the conflict was a good opportunity**.
 - **For Haile Sellassie too**, the situation was important. His requests for assistance were finally answered by **the British government** that decided to **drive out Italians from East Africa**.
- ❖ **On 12 July 1940, London** recognized **the Emperor as a full ally**. The British launched a **three pronged attack on the Italians**. That is:-
 - In **the north**, **General William Platt** led the forces that attacked the Italians in **Eritrea**.
 - In the **West**, in **January 1941**, **Colonel Sandford** and **Major Wingate** accompanied the Emperor from the **Sudan** into **Gojjam** at the head of **British and Ethiopian troops** called the **Gedeon force**.
 - In **the South**, **General Cunningham** led the attack from **Kenya**. The advances were rapid largely due to the demoralization that the patriots had caused among the Italians.
- ☞ **Emperor Haile-Selassie** entered **Addis Ababa** on **5 May 1941**, exactly five years after Italian entry to the capital.

UNIT SEVEN

INTERNAL DEVELOPMENTS AND EXTERNAL RELATIONS, 1941–1995

7.1. Post-1941 Imperial Period

7.1.1. Restoration and Consolidation of Imperial Power and External Relations

A. Ethiopia and Britain

- ❖ In the post-1941 period, **Britain recognized Ethiopia's status as a sovereign state** with mutual diplomatic accreditation, but it continued to exercise the upper hand/preponderance/because of:-
 - the role it played in the liberation of Ethiopia from Fascist rule.
 - Britain preponderant influence in Ethiopia's domestic and international affairs in line with the continuation of WWII (1939-45) which required adequate provision for the Allied defense to win the war.
- ☞ Accordingly, despite protests, the British considered **Ethiopia Occupied Enemy Territory Administration (OETA)**. The 1942 and 1944 agreements that Emperor Haile-Selassie I was forced to sign with the British show the ascendancy of the latter.
- ❖ The 1942 agreement:-
 - Gave Britain a final authority over **Ethiopia's foreign affairs, territorial integrity, administration, finances, the military and the police**.
 - Enabled the British minister in Ethiopia enjoyed precedence over other **foreign diplomats in Ethiopia** and Britain was to **approve employment of other nationals by Ethiopian government**.
 - Even more, British citizens **held key posts in Ethiopian administration as advisors and judges** while at the same time they maintained **total control over the country's police force** which was set up in February 1942. Additionally, **British aircraft had exclusive aviation rights and the emperor** had to obtain approval from the Commander in Chief of the British Forces in East Africa, **Sir Philip Mitchell**, to implement sovereign matters such as declaration of war or state of emergency. Britain also decided details on disposal of Italian prisoners of war and civilians and the administration of Italian properties in the country. In terms of finance, the British assumed control over currency and foreign exchange as well as import-exports.
- ☞ The Emperor resented such restrictions to his powers and made some diplomatic engagements. With this and **the help of the USA and friends of Ethiopia such as Sylvia Pankhurst**, Britain relaxed the restrictions imposed upon the Ethiopian government.
- ❖ **The second Anglo-Ethiopian agreement, signed in 1944**, shows some of the concessions the emperor won from Britain. According to this agreement,
 - the priority accorded to the British minister over all other foreign diplomats in Ethiopia was lifted. The Ethiopian government could now employ non-British foreign personnel and it regained control over a section of the Addis Ababa-Djibouti railway, a vital line of external communication. Control over this route assured Ethiopia free access to foreign goods and services including arms and ammunitions.
 - **The British also agreed to evacuate their army** from the region once they equip Ethiopia's military force- a task mandated to **the British Military Mission to Ethiopia (BMME)**.
 - The BMME assisted the government of Ethiopia in **organizing, training, and administration of its army** until 1951. **Haile-Selassie I Harar Military Academy** was **modeled after a British Military Academy** called Sandhurst.
 - Britain did not, however, yield to Ethiopia's territorial demands during the negotiation for the 1944 Agreement.

- ✓ The Ethiopian government requested **union of Eritrea with Ethiopia** claiming that it was historically, culturally, and economically inseparable from Ethiopia. **Both Eritrea and Ogaden** were part of the Ethiopian empire before they fell into Italian hands in **1890 and 1936** respectively. But Ethiopia's claims to the two territories were met with little sympathy from the British.
- ✓ **Britain insisted that Ogaden should be merged with the former Italian Somaliland and British Somaliland** to form what they called "**Greater Somalia**". Similarly, the **western and northern lowlands of Eritrea** were intended by the British **to be part of Sudan**.
- ✓ Further, they wanted to integrate **the Tigrigna speaking highlands of Eritrea with Tigray to form a separate state**. As a consequence, in **September 1945** at the **London conference** of Allied powers **Ethiopia's claims to Eritrea and Ogaden were rejected**.

☞ **The territorial issues were resolved** only after a decade.

- In 1948, the British left parts of Ogaden, and in **1954** they withdrew from the region.
- In Eritrea people were divided; i.e:
 - ✓ those who wanted a union with Ethiopia rallied behind the **Unionists**.
 - ✓ The **Liberal Progressive Party** and later the **Muslim League** rallied people who sought for separation and independence.

In 1948, **the question of Eritrea** was referred to the **UNSC** by **Britain, France, U. S. A. and U. S. S. R.** The UN appointed a commission of **five men** from **Burma, Guatemala, Norway, Pakistan and South Africa** to find out actual wishes of Eritreans. After a period of investigation:-

- Guatemala and Pakistan recommended granting independence to Eritrea. While
- Norway recommended union with Ethiopia
- South Africa and Burma recommended Federation.

On December 2 **1950** UN Resolution **390V** granted the **Federation of Eritrea with Ethiopia** which came into effect in **1952**. However, this arrangement did not satisfy both unionists and the independence bloc; thus, sought to unmake the federation to fit their respective interests. **On November 14, 1962**, the **Eritrean Parliament**, under pressure from the Ethiopian government, resolved to **dissolve the Federation and placed Eritrea under the imperial umbrella**.

B. Ethiopia and the U.S.A

- ❖ The **first official contacts between Ethiopia and the United States of America** traced back to **1903** when the two countries **signed a Treaty of Friendship and Commerce with the USA** delegate led under **Robert P. Skinner**. The relations between the two countries had been in the **doldrums** because of the **Tripartite domination** of the Ethiopian diplomatic scene until the early **1940s**. **Following the Second World War**, two super-powers, **the Soviet Union and the United States emerged**.
- ❖ **In Ethiopia and the Horn**, British pre-dominance in 1940s was **replaced by the dominance of the United States in 1950s**. In his efforts to ensure his **sovereign political authority from British domination, to modernize his country and consolidate his power**, Haile-Selassie I turned towards the United States as a powerful ally than Britain.
- ❖ **American interest in the region began to grow** especially after they acquired a **communication base in Asmara known as Radio Marina from the Italians**. The radio station was **later on renamed Qagnew** after the **Ethiopian force that fought on the side of the Americans in the Korean War (1950-3)**.

- ❖ In 1943, the Ethiopian vice Finance Minister, **Yilma Deressa**, visited the US to request expertise to assist the country's development. In response, USA:-
 - extended the **Lend-Lease Agreement** with Ethiopia and
 - sent a technical mission led by **Perry Fellows** in May 1944.
- ❖ **Emperor Haile-Selassie I** and the American President, **Franklin D. Roosevelt**, met in **Egypt** and discussed recognition of an **American Sinclair Company to prospect for oil in Ogaden at the beginning of 1945**. By granting a concession to the company, Ethiopia sought to reassert its rights in the region as much as it was eager to exploit a lucrative natural resource.
- ❖ The renewed contact between Ethiopia and USA was concretized with the signing of two agreements in the 1950s. i.e:-
 - First, the **Point Four Agreement** enabled subsequent **American assistance in education and public health** was signed in 1952.
 - Second, the Ethio-US Treaty that granted a continued **American use of the Qagnew base** in return for military assistance was signed in 1953.

These two agreements in general but the latter in particular defined the Ethio American partnership in the following decades.

- ❖ Following the 1953 treaty, the USA:-
 - launched a military aid program named the **American Military Assistance Advisory Group (MAAG)** to equip Ethiopia's armed forces. The MAAG was to train 60,000 Ethiopian soldiers in three separate divisions.
 - In the year between 1953 and 1968, over 2,500 Ethiopians received various forms of military training in the US. It was in the army that American military assistance and training was most noticeable. By 1970, sixty percent of US military aid to Africa went to Ethiopia. In the period between 1946 and 1972, US military aid was over 180 million US Dollar. Anti-tank and anti-aircraft weapons, naval craft, infantry weapons and some times even uniforms like field jackets were of American origin. Civil aviation, road transport, and education were other spheres that the Americans took active part.
 - From 8 September to 15 **December 1945**, the founding conference of the UN was held at **San Francisco**. There, the Ethiopian delegation approached American delegates for assistance to form a civilian airline. Hence, an agreement was concluded with **Transcontinental and Western World Airline (TWA)** that established **Ethiopian Air Lines (EAL) in 1946** with five C-47 warplanes that served during WWII and of which three were converted to passenger version DC-3. In 1962, EAL entered the jet age. Meanwhile the shortage of trained Ethiopian personnel slowed the progress towards the Ethiopianization of the EAL. For almost three decades since the signing of the agreement with the TWA in 1946, **key management and executive posts of the Ethiopian airline were seized by expatriates notably by the Americans**. EAL got its **first Ethiopian national pilot, Alemayehu Abebe**, in 1957 and **Colonel Simeret Medhne** became **the first Ethiopian General Manager of EAL** in 1971.
- ❖ The **Imperial Board of Telecommunication** was established with the help of **International Telephone and Telegraph (ITT) organization** between 1950 and 1952.
- ❖ In January 1951, with financial loan from the **International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD)**, the **Imperial High Way Authority (IHA)** was set up based on the model of the **US Bureau of Roads**. It continued to be run by **Americans until 1962**. Together with ELA's domestic network the improvement of **road transport** along with **communication services** played important role in facilitating national integration and **the speedy transport** of such lucrative commodities as **coffee**.

- ❖ **In the field of education**, American presence was particularly evident in the **university and high schools**. A variety of **American scholarship programs under USAID** and **African American Institute African Graduate Fellowship Program (AFGRAD)** offered opportunities for many Ethiopians to **go to the United States for their second and third Degrees**. Meanwhile, **many American volunteers came to Ethiopia** to teach in Ethiopian schools under **the Peace Corps Program**.

☞ **Other foreign countries** with significant presence in Imperial Ethiopia include:-

- **Sweden and Norway** whose advisors were entrusted to the **Air force** and **navy** successively.
- **Germany and Israel** trained and equipped the **Police Force** while the **Swedes** supported the **Imperial Bodyguard** and the **Harar Military Academy** was entrusted to British trained **Indians**.
- In 1956, the **Qoqa Dam** was built with **war reparations money that the Italians** agreed to pay. This was followed by the return of the **Statue of Judah in 1972**, which **Italians** had taken during the occupation period.
- **Russians** established good relations with Ethiopia through **their exhibition, library around city hall, post office, mathematics and literature**.

7.1.2. Socio-Economic Developments

- ❖ **Ethiopia and the Horn** is one of the regions in the world where **early domestication of plants and animals took place**.
- ❖ The **mid-twentieth century** witnessed that there was **low development in industrialization**, meant that **Agriculture was the leading economic sector** in providing employment for about ninety percent of the population, generating about **seventy percent of the national GDP** and **supplying almost hundred percent of the country's income from export trade**. Therefore, the **landholding** which was a **primary means of production was vital**. Generally,
 - peasants in the northern and central highland parts of Ethiopia held land in the form of **rist**.
 - **in the 1970s**, more than **sixty-six percent** of the peasant farmers cultivated less than **0.5 hectares**.
 - **in southern Ethiopia**, government grants were made by the Government for large number of its supporters and tenancy was widespread. The **disparity of landownership between north and south Ethiopia** by the **middle of the twentieth century** can be seen from the **proportion of tenants to landed peasants**. It was only minority religious and occupational castes who suffered from tenancy **in the north** while the tenant population as percentage of total rural population in **newly incorporated regions** varied from **37 percent** in former **Sidama Governorate General** to a **staggering 73 percent in Ilu Abba Bor**, and **75 percent in Hararghe**, whereas tenancy **in northern provinces** averaged **11 percent**. Tenants surrendered **up to 60 percent of their produce** to landlords who mostly lived in towns or the capital.
- ❖ **In addition to formal tributes**, there were **sundry/various/ payments** that **smallholder and landless farmers had to make**, such as “**voluntary**” contributions to self-help funds for projects from which they **rarely benefitted**.
- ❖ **Sharecrop tenancy** arrangements in the country were so onerous that increasing production only increased the **exploitation of peasants**.
- ❖ **The extreme taxation** to which smallholding peasants were subjected to was also potent enough to **discourage peasants** from maximizing production beyond subsistence levels. From **1953 to 1974**, the **annual growth rate of agricultural production** was only **2.4 percent** which was lower than

the **2.5 percent population growth rate**. As a consequence, **Ethiopia ranked among the countries with very low per capita income**.

- ❖ **The deteriorating condition of the country's economy** posed a threat to the **social and political stability of the country** and thus, the regime's power. This coupled with **external pressure from donors**, induced the government to establish a **Land Reform Committee in 1961**. This later became the **Land Reform and Development Authority that grew to become the Ministry of Land Reform and Administration**. Yet **no meaningful reform was implemented** because it would affect the vested economic and political interests of landlords who at that time had taken hold of government.

- ❖ **In 1960s and 1970s commercial agriculture** was expanding especially:-

- in **southern Shewa**,
- the **Setit-Humera** region on the Sudan border, and
- in the **Awash valley**.

- ☞ The **mechanization of farming** in these areas **led to eviction of tenants**. Profitability of agriculture:-

- led some **landlords to work the land by themselves**.
- Sometimes landlords rented the land under their ownership to whoever offered them better price in cash (as opposed to the sharecropping tenancy practice); a price paid in advance and for longer periods. The effect of all these was the eviction of tenants.

- ☞ Furthermore, **the government** attempted to **enhance the productivity of small farmers** through launching **comprehensive agricultural package programs**. The most notable in this regard were:-

- The Chilalo Agricultural Development Unit (**CADU**) and
- The Wolayta Agricultural Development Unit (**WADU**).

- ⌚ **CADU** was launched in **1967** through **the initiative of the Swedish International Development Authority (SIDA)** while the **World Bank** supported **WADU**.

- ⌚ **The major objective of the package programs was demonstrating the effectiveness and efficiency of agricultural packages** to pave the way for subsequent nationwide emulation of the intensive package approach. Nonetheless, **the plan was conceived and implemented without undertaking the crucial task of land reform**, thereby leaving the **targeted population (small peasant producers) at a disadvantageous position vis-a-vis big landlords** when it comes to the distribution of benefits. Although few participant small farmers gained real benefit, farmers with large land-holdings took the lion's share of the benefits **accrued** from these projects. The unintended **outcome of CADU was aggravating tenant eviction**. **WADU** initiated by the World Bank was **more successful in promoting re-settlement**.

- ❖ **Since the 1950s**, the government formulated **strategic plans for economic development** and this came in **a series of five-year plans**. i.e:-

- The First Five Year Plan (1957-1961) targeted the development of infrastructure.
- The Second (1962-1967) turned towards mining, manufacturing and electricity. The Plan also mentioned major constraints to the development of the agricultural sector, although in very general terms.
- The Third (1968-1972) gave priority to large scale agricultural development and 'bringing higher living standard'. The package projects noted above were part of the third plan.

- ☞ **Following these plans**, the **Ethiopian economy witnessed some progress particularly after 1950**. i.e:-

- Overall, domestic output increased nearly three and a half times and even **better progress was registered in manufacturing**. The number of **industrial enterprises** grew to over four hundred and the **industrial working force** to nearly sixty thousand.

- The **electricity supply and infrastructure** expanded considerably. **Road and air communication** enabled linkage of parts of the country.
- The **emergence of new towns and the development of city life** hastened **urbanization**.
- Moreover, **public revenue and expenditure both grew nine times and tenfold**, respectively.
- **Banking facilities** expanded and the **State Bank of Ethiopia** was formed in 1942. In 1963 it was divided into the **Commercial Bank and the National Bank of Ethiopia**. Also a **private bank, Addis Ababa Bank** was established in 1963.
- The capital **Addis Ababa** became a **continental capital** when the **UN Economic Commission for Africa (ECA)** and the **Organization of African Unity (OAU)** were established in 1958 and 1963 respectively.
- Overall, there was **relatively high level of modernization** that was reflected in many facets of life: **music, sports, cuisine and dress styles**.

☞ Yet, **much of Ethiopia remained traditional** with a **low living standard** and Ethiopia was a **least developed country in global terms**. While the manufacturing sector contributed less than five percent of the national income, **industrialization was spatially limited in the capital and its vicinity in addition only to Asmara and Dire Dawa**. The manufacturing sector only produced **light consumer goods**. Moreover, **industrial investment was also primarily of foreign origin**. For example, the Ethiopian share in capital was hardly more than twenty percent for **Wonji-Shewa and Methara sugar factories** which were **largely Dutch-owned**. Above all, the **absence of meaningful land reform** constrained the forces of production in the countryside where the majority of the population lived.

Consolidation of Autocracy

- ❖ The post-liberation period witnessed the **climax of the emperor's power**. As in the period before, at the center of post-1941 national policies was the **state's enduring interest to curb the political and economic bases of the power of regional lords in favour of the monarch**. After he was restored to the throne in May 1941, Emperor Haile-Selassie I **embarked on consolidating his power**. This was made possible through:-
 - the bureaucratization of government,
 - the building of a national army and
 - a centralized fiscal system.
- ❖ **In order to fill-in the expanding bureaucracy, education** was promoted at **both school and college levels**. While **primary schools** had already been **established prior to 1935**, **secondary schools** were **opened in the post 1941 period**. i.e:-
 - The **Haile-Selassie I Secondary School**, founded in 1943 and
 - The **General Wingate School** established in 1946
 } became the two most popular and prestigious secondary schools
- ☞ A **significant number of the educated elites** in the **1950s** attended either of these two schools.
 - In 1950, the University College of Addis Ababa (UCAA) was inaugurated. This was followed by the Engineering and Building College in Addis Ababa, the College of Agriculture in Alamaya (Hararghe), and the Public Health College in Gondar. These various colleges were brought **together to form the Haile-Selassie I University in 1961** which again was **re-named Addis Ababa University** after the outbreak of the Revolution in 1974.

- ❖ **The post-1941 political order was dominated by Haile-Selassie** that both the state and the country came to be identified with the emperor.i.e:-
 - Significant urban landmarks such as **schools, hospitals, theatre halls, stadiums, main avenues and squares in the country bore the name of the Emperor.**
 - It was common for students to **chant songs praising the emperor** who would then gift them with **sweets or fruits on holidays** such as **Ethiopian Christmas on January 7.**
 - The **emperor's birthday and coronation day** were **national holidays** where large sum of money was spent.
- ❖ Yet another major pre-occupation of the imperial regime was **the strengthening of the military and security apparatus.** The **ministries of Defense and Interior**, in charge of maintaining public security, consistently received the highest budgetary allocations. For example, out of the country's total budget of **ETB 38 million in 1944/5 fiscal year, nearly 11 million** was allocated for the **Ministry of Interior** of which security absorbed almost **5 million and about 8 million** went for war. Figures show **over 80 million** allocation for **Ministry of Defense** and nearly **60 million** for **Ministry of Interior**, out of about **400 million ETB in 1967.** Ironically, although the emperor anticipated that the military that was composed mainly of **the army, the police force and the Imperial Bodyguard** would suppress opposition to the regime, **they themselves rebelled more than once.** It failed in 1960. It was **more successful in 1974.**
- ❖ **The traditional aristocracy although made to enjoy urban and rural property, had lost most of its political privileges.** Based on the traditional *shum shir*, the emperor appointed and demoted his ministers, **most of whom had humble origins.** In 1943, the emperor appointed eleven ministers to **draft laws** and **appoint junior officials** but **their subservience to the monarch** was stated in explicit terms. For example, it was only in 1966 that **even the prime minster was allowed to select his cabinet members** to be approved by the emperor.
 - **Ras Bitweded Mekonnen Endalkachew** served as **prime minister from 1942.** Next to **Mekonnen Habte-Wold (1949-58)**, whose brother, **Aklilu Habte Wold**, became **the last prime minister** of the imperial regime (1961-74)
 - **Yilma Deressa** left **the strongest mark** on the **Ministry of Finance.**
 - The **most powerful** of the ministers in the post-1941 political order was **Tsehafe-Tizaz Wolde-Giorgis Wolde-Yohannis** who headed the **strategic Ministry of Pen** in the period 1941-55. Besides **Wolde-Giorgis** held the **portfolios of Justice and Interior on various occasions** that he was **the defacto prime minister** in the above stated period. **Wolde-Giorgis's access to the emperor and the latter's trust in him made him so powerful.**
- ❖ In general, members of:-
 - royal family,
 - leading nobility and
 - the *Abun* still were members of the crown council, which was an advisory body to the emperor. In 1959, the Emperor's private cabinet was set up as a high-level advisory body to the emperor and developed into agency doing intelligence.
- ❖ In 1955, Haile-Selassie **promulgated a new constitution**, revising the first constitution issued in 1931. American advisers like **John Spencer** as well as **Tsehafe-Tizaz Wolde-Giorgis Wolde-Yohannis** and **Tsehafe-Tizaz Aklilu Habte-Wold** were in the **drafting committee of the 1955 revised constitution.** More than its predecessor, the 1955 revised constitution **provided the basis for the consolidation of absolutism** in Ethiopia. About **36 articles of the 1955 constitution dealt with the question of imperial succession and the emperor's privileges.** The constitution clearly states:-
 - the Emperor's personality as sacred,

- the Emperor's dignity inviolable and his power indisputable.
 - Some Human rights provisions like those of speech and press were accompanied by nullifying phrases like within law limits.
- ☞ However **this constitution introduced:-**
- **universal adult suffrage** and
 - elected **chamber of deputies** for four years term and that of **the senate** six years with certain property qualification.
- ☞ In the final analysis, however, **neither the constitution nor the Parliament that it created put a limit to the autocratic power of the emperor**. He was **the head of the three branches of government: the executive, the legislative and the judiciary**. The idea of a constitutional monarchy was never materialized. **Human rights and civic liberties were restricted and violated**. Regional identities, needs and feelings were ignored in the interest of **centralization**.
- ❖ As the years progressed, **the emperor started to dedicate** his attention to **foreign affairs**. i.e:-
- He played a significant role in **the Non-Aligned Movement** and
 - He also contributed his share in the drive for **African unity** and this increased his international stature that finally resulted in **the birth of the Organization of African Unity at the summit of heads of African states held in Addis Ababa in 1963**. But his preoccupation with international affairs detached the emperor from the domestic affairs that he became **careless of the signs of trouble at home**.

7.1.3. Oppositions and the Downfall of the Monarchical Regime

A. Plots and Conspiracies

- ❖ Various sectors of the society opposed the imperial rule **before the 1974 Revolution** broke out.
- **Before the 1960s opposition to the regime** took in the form of **plots and conspiracies**.
 - **After the 1960 Coup d'état**, however, **oppositions gained wider mass support and came out more open**.
- ❖ Some leaders of the resistance movement against fascist rule were **opposed to the restoration of the emperor to the throne for he fled the country** when it needed him most whereas **others wished for a republican government**. Such misgivings combined with **the privileges and rewards accorded to exiles and people who served the colonial administration** exacerbated the resentment against the monarchy leading to rebellions.
- ⌚ One notable patriot who resented the fact that he was not given a stature recognizing his contribution to the Resistance was ***Dejazmach* Belay Zeleke**.
- The emperor **made Belay governor of a southern province of Gojjam with the rank of Ras** because **he wanted to remove him from his base in Bichena in eastern Gojjam**.
 - Belay:-
 - ✓ rejected the offer and
 - ✓ was even more **dissatisfied at dignified positions of Ras Haylu Belaw (Governor General of Gojjam) and Bitweded Mengesha Jembere (Deputy Governor General of Gojjam)**.
- ☞ In February 1943, forces from Debra-Marqos and Addis Ababa invaded Belay's district. After fighting for three months, **Belay surrendered**, was **detained in Fiche** from where **he tried to escape and return to Gojjam a few months later**, but was **captured with his brother Ejigu**. **Taken back to the capital, Belay was finally hanged and killed in public**.
- ⌚ ***Bitweded* Negash Bezabih** was a vice minister and Senate President in the emperor's administration after liberation. **He plotted to assassinate the emperor and proclaim a republic in 1951**. In the process, **some military officers** like **Begele Anasimos** were attracted to the plot, but **Dejach Geresu Duki**, another patriot, whom the plotters had

unsuccessfully approached to recruit to their cause, **exposed them**. Finally, the plotters were tried and sentenced to various terms of imprisonment after being arrested during one of their **clandestine** meetings.

- ⌚ **The most fierce and sustained opposition to the emperor** came from **Blatta Takele Wolde- Hawaryat**, who **couched a plot in constitutionalist terms** using **Yohannes Iyasu** as front and **with the support of some contingents of the army**. But the plot was uncovered and **he was detained**. In 1945, **Blatta Takele Wolde-Hawaryat** was **released and appointed** as **deputy Afe nigus**. Yet, he was **involved in another plot in 1946** and was **detained up to 1954**. Upon his release, **he once again became Vice Interior Minister and Afe nigus**. He **tried to assassinate the emperor on November 17, 1969**, but his final plot failed and **he barricaded himself in his house** and engaged in a shoot-out with the police in which **he was killed**.
- ❖ **The most serious challenge to the emperor's authority** came in **1960 in the form of a coup attempt**. The abortive Coup d'etat of 1960 was led by the Neway brothers:-
 - Brigadier General Mengistu Neway and
 - Girmame Neway.
- ☞ **Girmame:-**
 - ✓ attended **Haile-Sellasie I Secondary School**, and then the **University of Wisconsin** where **he received his B.A and M.A. Degrees from Columbia**.
 - ✓ was also **president of Ethiopian Students Association** during his stay in the USA. Upon his return to Ethiopia, Girmame **became the president of a clandestine alumni association of his former school**.
- ☞ **As governor of Wolayta, Girmame's activities were alarming to the regime**. He:-
 - ✓ monitored police activities,
 - ✓ introduced a settlement program in which he distributed government holdings to landless peasants and
 - ✓ ordered written tenancy agreements.
- ⌚ As a result, **he was then summoned back to Addis Ababa for explanation**. However, unable to criticize Girmame's intentions **Haile- Selassie sent him to Jijiga where he continued as radical reformer**. In Jijiga, Girmame:-
 - ✓ oversaw the digging of new wells while improving the old,
 - ✓ set up clinics, schools etc.
- ☞ But Girmame's actions were not liked by the regime which convinced Girmame of the need for change. Together with his brother **General Mengistu Neway**, the **head of the Imperial Bodyguard**, and **others** the two brothers:-
 - ✓ **started detaining ministers and other members of the nobility when the emperor was on state visit in Brazil**.
 - ✓ **took over the radio station and spoke about the backwardness of the country** than other newly independent African states. **The crown prince Asfawosen was said to be a salaried constitutional monarch**. The prince delivered a speech on **Radio Addis** explaining the **rationale of the coup** in which he promised the **establishment of new factories, schools etc**.
- ⌚ **On 14 December 1960**, a new government was declared that was to be headed by **Ras Emiru Haile- Selassie**. **Major General Mulugeta Buli** was chosen as **chief of staff of the armed forces** while **Brigadier-General Tsige Dibu** was to **lead the Imperial Bodyguard and the Police Force**, and **Colonel Workneh Gebeyehu** was **security chief**.

☞ However, **the army and the air force** refused to side with the rebels and with the support of the Americans and the blessing of the patriarch, the loyalists led by **General Merid Mengesha, Ras Asrate Kassa** etc attacked the plotters. The rebels asked for a cease-fire which the loyalists rejected. Finally, they had to run for their lives but only after killing the ministers and other dignitaries they had detained at Geneta L'uel palace. In the meantime, the emperor entered the capital. Finally,

- **Girmame died** fighting in the outskirts of the capital and
- **Mengistu** was captured and **hanged after trial**.
- **The regime made some concessions** after the failed coup attempt, **but failed to address the root causes that triggered the coup itself**. Thus, opposition to the imperial regime was only to grow stronger that **led to the outbreak of the 1974 Revolution**.

B. Peasant Rebellions

The post-liberation period also witnessed **growing opposition among peasants** in different parts of the country against Haile-Selassie's regime thereby giving the opposition a broader dimension. Peasant revolts, although **on a small scale**, were especially **numerous in the southern territories**, where the imperial government had traditionally rewarded its supporters with land grants thereby reducing the local peasantry into tenancy. It is not possible in the space of a brief essay such as this to discuss the numerous peasant rebellions in the entire country. But an effort will be made to canvas major eruptions in the country with the intent of showing some of the deficiencies of the system.

The Woyane Rebellion

❖ **The first peasant resistance** against imperial rule **took place in Tigray**, known in history as the **Woyane rebellion**. The term *Woyane* means 'revolt' in Tigrigna language. A combination of longrunning problems stemming from the **inequities of the system** and short-term factors caused the eruption. i.e:-

- **Peasants felt victimized by corruption and greed of the territorial army unit stationed in the region and general administrative inefficiency that led to the shiftment of peasants who possessed armament left by Italians**. The peoples of **Wejjerat** and **Raya-Azebo** had **wanted to maintain their local autonomy** that the government violated.
- **Another cause for the rebellion was the 1942 land decree which forced peasants to pay tax arrears whose collection was problematic**. This rebellion had the support of **members of the nobility** who perceived their position to be endangered by the expansion of central authority. The nobility took advantage of the popular discontent against government officials and their militias and put strong resistance against government forces thanks to the able leadership of ***Blatta Haile-Mariam Reda***. Finally, the government's retribution against the **Raya-Azebo** on allegation of **cattle raids on Afar territory** sparked the **general rebellion**. As such, the Woyane rebellion was as a continuation of the government's punitive campaign against the region's peasants **in the late 1920s**. The dress rehearsal for the major confrontation took place on **January 11, 1942** where the imperial force was crushed and humiliated by **Raya-Azebo peasants**. On **May 22, 1943**, the rebels scored an astounding victory fighting an even larger and well-equipped government army **in Addi Awuna**, 15 kms away from **Hewane in southern Tigray**. Soon small towns around **Meqelle** like **Qwiha and Enda-Iyyasus**, and **Meqelle itself** on October 14, 1943 fell in rebel hands. They then expanded to **Kilte-Awlalo, Wuqiro** etc in **eastern Tigray**. Such initial advances of the rebel forces, however, did not last long.

☞ **In October 1943, the imperial army under the command of Abebe Aregay with the support of the British Royal Air Force crushed the rebellion**. In line with this:-

- The government exiled or imprisoned the leaders of the revolt.

- The emperor took reprisals against peasants suspected of supporting the Woyane. Meanwhile, the imperial regime **reversed the 1942 land decree**, although the **Wejjerat and Raya-Azebo** lost their autonomous status, and **Raya-Azebo** was **made part of Wollo**.

The Yejju Rebellion

- ❖ **Overt dissidence of Yejju peasants in Wollo during Haile-Selassie's rule occurred three times.** i.e:-
 - **In 1948, peasants rose against the system after their appeal against land alienation** was ignored by the government. With **Qeqnazmach Melaku Taye** and **Unda Mohammed** in the forefront, peasants stormed and freed inmates held in **Woldya prison**. The **nech lebash** were called to quell the unrest and eventually **the leaders were publicly flogged**.
 - **Throughout the 1950s**, localized skirmishes between government forces and peasants expanded to **Qobo, Hormat, Tumuga, Karra-Qore** etc led by prominent figures like **Ali Dullatti (Aba Jabbi)**.
 - **In 1970, peasants revolted against the introduction of mechanized agriculture that encroached on pastureland**. They killed **Qeqnazmach Abate Haylu** who was a member of the local nobility and direct beneficiary of the new development.
- ☞ Finally **the rising was suppressed by the local militia**.

The Gojjam Peasant Rebellion

- ❖ **In 1968, another violent peasant uprising set off in Gojjam caused by the government's attempt to implement new tax on agricultural produce which the parliament adopted in November 1967.** This rebellion was not, however, without its antecedents. The **nobles of Gojjam refused to accept any limitation upon the prevailing land tenure system and successfully battled the regime over this issue**. Although the **expansion of central authority by appointed officials** and the **development of infrastructural works required a parallel increase in tax payments**, it was **fiercely resisted by the local gentry**. Against this background, **the then governor of Gojjam, Dejach Kebede Tesema,**
 - **initiated land assessment and classification to determine taxation.**
 - **then raised tax rate from what it had been in the pre-1935 period.**
- ☞ **In 1950, a revolt broke out in Mota, Qolla-Daga Damot and Mecha districts led by people like Dejach Abere Yimam.** As a result,
 - **tax rate was reduced by 1/3,**
 - **Kebede was removed and replaced by Haylu Belew, a hereditary ruler of Gojjam.** Later, **Haylu's Shewan successor named Dejjazmach Tsehayu Enqu-Selassie forced handouts to build the emperor's statue in Debra Margos.** Besides, **peasants were ordered to pay tax arrears and register their arms with fees.** Meanwhile, **peasants were victimized by the ravages committed by the nech lebash in the pretext of eradicating banditry.** With all the above unfolding, **an attempt was made to introduce the new agricultural tax** and this finally **sparked the 1968 uprising** led by veterans of the resistance period, who had taken titles for themselves such **as leul and fitawrari**. As a result,
 - ✓ The government was forced to transfer *Dejjazmach Tsehayu* to Kafa,
 - ✓ declare amnesty,
 - ✓ abandon the new tax, and cancel all tax arrears of taxation going back to 1950.
- ☞ Despite these concessions, **the rebellion spread throughout Gojjam except Agaw-Midir and Metekel** which alarmed the government. Finally, **the rebellion was subdued by:-**
 - the combined forces of the army
 - police and
 - *nech lebash*

The Gumuz Rebellion

- ❖ **The Gumuz** staged major armed rebellion against the regime of Emperor Haile-Selassie in 1952/3. The movement is named after one of its famous leaders, **Aba Tone**. Aba Tone served the imperial regime with a position of **Aba Qoro (head /chief of a sub- district)** responsible for:-
 - collection of taxes,
 - maintenance of law and order as well as
 - mobilization of the people for public works in time of peace and for war in cases of conflict.
- ❖ As with the other peasant rebellions, **the Aba Tone armed uprising** had its roots in:-
 - administrative injustice,
 - land and
 - taxation policies of the imperial regime.
- ❖ Aba Tone sided with the local people who were discontented with **the system of government and administration of Emperor Haile-Selassie** in general and **heavy taxation and mal-administration** in particular. Although Aba Tone reported the complaints of the peasants to higher government authorities **in Najjo and Gimbi**, they were not in a position to solve the problem. Meanwhile, **the Gumuz** were determined **not to pay taxes unless the government took appropriate measures to address their concerns**.
- ❖ Finally, **an open clash broke out between the policemen and the Gumuz** when tax collectors with the backing of the police force attempted to force the people pay land taxes. **The situation soon grew into an open rebellion** against the government leading to a general breakdown of law and order in the region, particularly **in places like Gaba Robi and Tullu Lubu** where **the first clash had occurred**. In the event of the initial combat between **the government's expeditionary forces** and **those of Aba Tone** the **latter had obtained an upper hand over the former**. Nevertheless, **the government forces were soon reinforced with more weapons and manpower**. Aba Tone and his followers were **outgunned and outnumbered** and thus, the government was able to put down the uprising. **Aba Tone** was **captured and later released on pardon**.

The Gedeo Peasant Rebellion

- ❖ As in many parts of rural Ethiopia, **the major source of peasant discontent in Gedeo** was **land alienation**. The dispossession of land from the indigenous peasantry was unabated particularly following the introduction of land measurement in the 1920s.
- ❖ **In the 1960s**, the Gedeo witnessed an **unprecedented level of land expropriation by members of the northern nobility** who were vying for **coffee farms**. The major contender in this regard was the emperor's daughter, **Princess Tenagneworq**. This coupled with **the denigration of their culture** exacerbated Gedeo's **resentment** against the system. Petitions and appeals to higher authorities to curb the continued land alienation proved futile. Then peasants:-
 - refused to pay ***erbo*** (1/4 of agricultural produce payable to landlords),
 - armed themselves with traditional weapons like **spears, swords and arrows** and **clashed with the imperial army at Michille in 1960**. That is why it was known as **the Michille rebellion**. Over a **hundred peasants lost their lives in the fight** while much of their property was destroyed. Finally, ***Afe Nigus Eshete Geda***, fined the elders locally called **the hayicha** **accused of supporting the rebellion**.

The Bale Peasant Rebellion

- ❖ The Bale peasant uprising, which **lasted from 1963 to 1970**, presented the most serious challenge to the Ethiopian government. The **causes of the uprising were multifaceted**. i.e:-
 - The indigenous **peasants largely became tenants** on their own land after **the introduction of the *qalad*** that initiated **land measurement** in 1951.

- Peasants also suffered from high taxation, religious and ethnic antagonism that reached to unprecedented level after **the appointment of Warqu Enquselassie as governor of the territory in 1963**. The predominantly Muslim population resented the **imposition of alien rule from the northern and central highlands parts of the empire** and thus, political and cultural domination by Christian settlers.
- Further, **the government of Somalia** extended **material and moral support to the rebels** as part of its strategy of reestablishing a “Greater Somalia”.

❖ **The revolt broke out** in El Kerre led by people like Kahin Abdi. Initially, **rebel groups** conducted hit-and-run raids against military garrisons and police stations separately. Soon, however, **they tried to coordinate their military activities under an umbrella organization** named **the Western Somali Liberation Front (WSLF)**, engaging in conventional wars against government forces.

❖ **Haile Selassie tried to win loyalty of the people** by developing alliances with notable Oromo leaders. Although this strategy enabled the emperor to recruit some members of local ruling houses in the service of the imperial system, it failed to contain the popular revolt. Instead, it quickly spread to Wabe, Dallo and Ganale under the able leadership of **Waqo Gutu and others**.

- **In Gola-Abbadi forest**, rebels went to the extent of attacking two government airplanes which campaigned against them with support from the Americans and Israeli.
- Further, **the rebels killed Girazmach Begele Haragu of Adaba and Fitawrari Wolde-Mika’el Bu’i of Dodola in 1965 and 1966 respectively**.

☞ **In December 1966**, the government put **Bale** under the martial rule of Wolde-Selassie Baraka, the head of the army’s Fourth Division.

☞ **In 1967,**

- the army, police,
 - Territorial Army (*beherawi tor*)
 - settler militia (*nech lebash*) and
 - volunteers (*wedo zemach*)
- } launched massive operations against the province.

🕒 **Meanwhile, the rebels lost Somali support after Mahammad Siad Barre took over the Somali government in 1969 and found it impossible to sustain their campaigns in southeastern Ethiopia. The rebellion ended in 1970s** after some of its popular leaders including the self-styled general Waqo Gutu surrendered to government forces.

C. Movements of Nations and Nationalities

❖ **Oppositions to the imperial rule did not come only from individuals, peasants, students and the army**. The **question of nations and nationalities for equality, freedom and autonomy** was also assuming a significant development towards the end of the imperial regime. Among the movement of nations and nationalities of this period, **the Mecha-Tulama movement of the Oromo** deserves a special treatment here.

- **In January 1963, the Mecha-Tulama Welfare Association (MTWA)** was formed with the objective of improving the welfare of the Oromo through **the expansion of educational, communication and health facilities in Oromo land**. Founding members of the association included
 - ✓ Colonels Alemu Qitessa
 - ✓ Colonel Qedida Guremessa
 - ✓ Lieutenant Mamo Mezemir
 - ✓ Begele Nedhi, and
 - ✓ Haile-Mariam Gameda.

- In the next two years, **the association attracted** large number of **Oromo elites**, including such high-ranking military officers as **Brigadier General Taddesse Birru**.
 - Although **the Mecha-Tulama Association** had its root in the will and commitment of a few Oromo elites to mobilize support for the development of Oromo inhabited territories, it soon **transformed into a pan-Oromo movement coordinating countrywide peaceful resistance against the regime**. This is evidenced by the successful rallies the association organized in, **Gindeberet, Dandi, Arsi (Dera and Iteya), etc.**
 - The association raised contentious **issues such as land and expressed its dissatisfaction with the condition of the Oromo in the society** during mass rallies as well as in private meetings. The **regime was alarmed by the activities of the association** and determined to **curb the movement** before it crystallized into an organized liberation front.
 - Meanwhile, **leaders of the association plotted to assassinate the emperor and change the regime on the anniversary of his coronation in November 1966**, but the plot was foiled by security forces. This coupled with a **bombing incident in one of the cinemas at the capital** in which the association was implicated led the government to move swiftly and violently to ban the association's activities.
 - **Mecha-Tulama was dissolved in 1967** following the **imprisonment and killing of its prominent leaders such as Mamo Mezemir and Hailemariam Gemmeda** by the regime's forces. **Brigadier General Taddese Birru** was captured while retreating to the bush and eventually sentenced to death. **Later the death sentence was commuted to life imprisonment and he was exiled to Gelemso** where he stayed until the outbreak of the 1974 revolution. **In 1975 the Derg executed Tadesse** on allegation of instigating armed struggle.
 - **The brutal suppression of the Mecha-Tulama Association, however, did not end the struggle of the Oromo for justice, equality and liberty.** In 1971 an underground movement called **the Ethiopian National Liberation Front (ENLF) was formed by Oromo elites**, perhaps by former members of the association. The Front **maintained contact with student circles and other opposition figures in and outside Addis Ababa**. The aim was to coordinate local resistance towards a common goal of liberation, although thwarted by the regime's security forces. The regime's unwillingness to accommodate the legitimate and peaceful demands of various Oromo groups for equality within Ethiopia transformed Oromo nationalism into militancy for self-determination. **In 1973, some members of the ENLF and other Oromo nationalists formed the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF)** with the aim of establishing an independent State of Oromia.
- ❖ The following year (1974), **OLF launched an offensive against the imperial regime in Hararghe**. After the revolution, **OLF increased its military activities because the Derg would not allow the Oromo to elect their rulers and use their language in schools and newspapers**. Accordingly, **the armed struggle which set off in the eastern part of Ethiopia** extended to other Oromo inhabited areas such as **Arsi and Wallagga**. But **the biggest military challenge to the imperial regime came from Eritrea**.
- As we have discussed above, Eritrea was integrated into the Ethiopian empire. The measure consolidated internal and external opposition to the union and led to the formation of liberation movements based in Eritrea and abroad. Although some liberation movements had taken shape as far back as the late 1940s, they did not seem to have much of an impact.
 - **In 1958, a number of Eritrean exiles had founded the Eritrean Liberation Movement (ELM) in Cairo.**

- In 1961, the ELM evolved into the **Eritrean Liberation Front (ELF)** or **Jabaha** in Arabic. **Hamid Idris Awate** who **fired the first bullet of the Eritrean armed struggle** (he is the one who ‘started the armed struggle’).
- By 1966 the ELF challenged imperial forces throughout Eritrea.
- In **June 1970**, two **splinter group liberation movements** emerged from the ELF. These were the **Popular Liberation Forces (PLF)** and the **Salfi Natsenet Eritrea (Front for Eritrean Independence)**. The PLF was formed in the Red Sea area led by **Osman Salah Sabbe** while **Salfi Natsenet Eritrea (Front for Eritrean Independence)** emerged under the leadership of **Isayas Afeworqi**.
- In early 1972, a **new coalition of forces composed of Eritrean Liberation Front-Popular Liberation Front (ELF-PLF)** led to **the founding of the Eritrean People’s Liberation Front (EPLF) or Sha’abiya in Arabic**. After a long and bloody civil war, the EPLF was able to establish its hegemony over the independence movement. Finally, **the EPLF** succeeded in **achieving *de facto* independence in 1991** and which eventually was **confirmed through referendum in 1993**.

D. The Ethiopian Student Movement (ESM)

- ❖ The regime was not only challenged in the provinces. In fact, the Ethiopian student movement was building up in the center as a strong opposition against the regime. Although the movement started within the university, students had turned into a radical opposition and were already marching on the streets from 1965 onwards and by 1968, it was spreading to high schools. **The parliament’s rejection of tenancy reform bill in 1964 triggered student protest in the following year demanding “Land to the Tiller”.**
- ❖ Factors that contributed to sharpening the students’ ideology include:
 - **the 1960 coup**, students’ increased awareness of the country’s socio-economic and political conditions vis a vis other African countries which they learned from scholarship students from different parts of Africa, and
 - the Ethiopian University Service (EUS). Launched in 1964, the EUS required the students to teach and offer other services to the community usually in the provinces. In 1964, the emergence of a radical group of students with **Marxist-Leninist leanings** known as “**the Crocodiles**” marked the increased militancy of the students. Side by side with the radicalization of the movement, **students formed the University College Union (UCU) to coordinate their activities in 1962 and then the National Union of Ethiopian University Students (NUEUS) 1963**.
- ❖ In February 1965, the **Main Campus Student Union (MCSU)**, and the **University Student Union of Addis Ababa (USUAA)** with its **paper Tagel (Struggle)** were established.
- ❖ Outside the country, students were organized under the **Ethiopian Students Union in North America (ESUNA)** with its **paper called Challenge** and the **Ethiopian Students Union in Europe (ESUE)** with its **paper Tateq (Gird yourself)** in the USA and Europe.
- ❖ ESUNA had gave ideological support to MCSU and USUAA. Throughout **the 1960s** a rallying cry of student demonstrations was “**land to the tiller**”, but other local and global issues were also raised. For example, students protested against the minority white regime in Southern Rhodesia (Zimbabwe) in 1968, while at other times they expressed their solidarity with the people of Vietnam. **In the national arena**, students protested against:-
 - Shola Destitute Concentration Relief Camp and fashion show (in 1966) and
 - educational reform (in 1969).
- ❖ With the students’ demands for **the respect of the rights of nations and nationalities**, the government was alarmed and **started taking measures against leaders of the movement** ranging

from **press campaigns** to **detentions** and **killings**. Furthermore, **the regime deported large number of students to the torrid Gibe river valley in 1972**. Meanwhile, **students' opposition was aggravated to armed hijacking of Dc-aircraft**.

❖ **By early 1970s, the student movement coupled with** other under-running issues such as:-

- rising inflation,
 - growing discontent of urban residents
 - corruption and
 - widespread and yet covered-up famine especially in Wollo
- } all prepared a fertile ground for a revolution.

7.2. The *Derg* Regime (1974-1991)

❖ **The mass uprising that finally put an end to the old regime came in February 1974.**

- **From January 8 to 15 1974, soldiers and non-commissioned officers** stationed at a frontier post **Negele-Borana** mutinied protesting their bad living conditions. In the process, they detained the commander of the ground forces who was sent to pacify the situation. The soldiers made the commander eat their food and drink their water so that he could witness the kind of life they were living.
- In addition, soldiers of **the Second Division in Asmara, the Fourth Division in Addis Ababa and the Air Force in Debre-Zeyt (Bishoftu)** **mutinied demanding salary increment and political and economic reforms**. The various units then **set up a coordinating committee** which became a precursor of the later *Derg*, in order to coordinate their actions.
- **Teachers throughout the country protested against:-**
 - ✓ the implementation of an education reform program known as **Sector Review**, which they deemed was disadvantageous for the poor and biased against them. Although **the Ethiopian Teachers Association (ETA)** had coordinated demonstrations against the program already in December 1973, it **called for a general strike demanding a number of other social reforms on 18 February 1974**.
- On 18 February 1974 (the same day with ETA's call for strike), **taxi drivers** went on strike **demanding increase in transport fees (fifty percent)** due to rise of petrol prices that followed the Arab-Israeli Yom Kippur war of 1973. **Students, workers and the unemployed youth** joined the protests and vehicles particularly buses and luxury private automobiles were attacked.

❖ The government responded by:-

- suspending the Sector Review
- reducing petrol prices and
- raising the salaries of soldiers

❖ In spite of the government had taken the above measures, **the uprisings continued**

- On February 28 the cabinet of **Prime Minister Aklilu Habte-Wold** resigned. He was **replaced by Endalkachew Mekonnen** who was an Oxford-educated member of the aristocracy. Although **Endalkachew** seemed to gain the support of a group of officers within the army, **promised to introduce reforms**, including **constitutional reform** and **included highly educated and progressive ministers into his cabinet**, the protests continued.

- On March 8, the **Confederation of Ethiopian Labour Unions (CELU)** staged a successful general strike.
 - It was only a matter of time before the strikes and demonstrations spread to the provinces. A **major popular demonstration was made on April 20** by about **100,000 Muslim residents of the capital and their Christian sympathizers who came out demanding religious equality.**
- ☞ In the meantime, **the soldiers**, through their various committees, were also **taking their own measures.** i.e:-
- The **coordinating committee of soldiers and Non-Commissioned Officers (NCOs)** set up in February had been **joined by officers**, such as **Colonel Alem Zewd Tessema** of the **Airborne Brigade**, who then **became its leader.**
 - In April, **the Committee**, perhaps with an involvement of **Endalkachew**, arrested Aklilu and **hundreds of other high-ranking officials of the regime.**
 - **The Minister of Defense, Lt. General Abiy Abebe**, who had noticed the growing power of the Committee as well as series of demonstrations and strikes, set up what was called **the National Security Commission to restore order and respect for the authority of the government.**
- ❖ The **leading opposition against the Endalkachaw cabinet** were **the students.** Not only did they staged their own demonstrations against the cabinet but they also encouraged other sectors of society to join in the revolutionary tide. But **the students were less organized to achieve their goals and eventually, the struggle was hijacked by the soldiers.**
- ☞ **The Derg was officially formed on June 28 1974** when it held **its first meeting at the headquarters of the Fourth Division.** “Derg” a Ge’ez word for “Committee” was the shorter name given to **the Coordinating Committee of representatives from various military units:**
- the Armed Forces,
 - the Police and
 - the Territorial Army.
- ✚ However, **officers above the rank of major** were suspected of supporting the old regime and therefore **were not included.**
- ❖ Hence, **Major Mengistu Haile-Mariam** of the Third Division of Hararghe, and the vice-chairman, **Major Atnafu Abate** of the Fourth Division, came to be key figures.
- ❖ For some time **the Derg exercised power parallel with** the Endalkachew’s cabinet and **the emperor tied up in a dual state**, trying to keep a balance between the two. However, on **August 1, Endalkachew** was imprisoned and replaced by **Lej Mikael Emiru** as prime minister. Meanwhile, the **Derg continued arresting other members of the regime** whom it considered obstacles to the revolution.
- ❖ The **Derg** also tried to **define its ideology and declared the motto, “Ethiopia Tikdem” (“Ethiopia First”), “Yaleminim Dem” (“Without any bloodshed”).**
- ❖ The **Derg continued systematically working to isolate the emperor and removing the supports of his imperial power.**
- ⌚ A **strong propaganda campaign was launched against the regime** and **the widespread corruption of government functionaries.** Two enterprises:-
- Anbessa Bus Company and
 - the St. George Brewery
- } in which the emperor and the imperial family had more fifty percent stake were nationalized.
- ⌚ Moreover, a **British documentary film** of (**Jonatan Dimbilby**) disclosing the hidden horrors of **the Wollo famine** precisely served the awaited interest of the **Derg.**
- ☞ Finally, on **September 12, Emperor Haile-Selassie I** was **deposed and detained at the Fourth Division headquarters.** The **Derg** then:-

- proclaimed itself the Provisional Military Administrative Council (PMAC) and assumed full powers.
 - Immediately, banned all strikes and demonstrations.
- ☞ Very soon,
- **civilian revolutionaries**, who had started calling for the establishment of a provisional people's government, started **gathering around the Confederation of Ethiopian Labor Unions (CELU), the University teachers' group known as Forum, and the students.**
 - Sections of **the military, the Army Engineers Corps, the First Division (the former Bodyguard), and the Army Aviation**, also opposed what was to become a military government.
- ❖ However, **the Derg was not prepared to make compromise on any ground.** Instead, it imprisoned the leaders of CELU and a leader of the Forum group.
- On October 7, **the militant Engineers were violently crushed in a tank assault which took the lives of five soldiers and there was massive arrest afterwards.** The motto of "Ethiopia First, without any bloodshed" thus failed as early as then.
 - On November 23, an even more violent phase commenced. **Lieutenant General Aman Mikael Andom**, Chairman of the PMAC was **shot dead after a disagreement within the Derg over the Issue of Eritrea.** Aman Mikael Andom who was of Eritrean origin believed in peaceful approach against some radical members of the *Derg* particularly the First Vice-Chairman Mengistu Haile-Mariam, who advocated for a military solution.
 - The killing continued and **the Derg announced execution of some 52 prominent members of the old regime who had been detained and half a dozen other leaders of the military units who had opposed the Derg as a "political decision."**

7.2.2. Attempts at Socio-Economic Reform

- ❖ The *Derg* took a series of measures that aimed at fundamentally transforming the country. i.e:-
- ☞ In December 1974, what was called **the Edget Behibiret Zemecha (Development Through Cooperation Campaign)** was inaugurated. In this campaign, **all high school and university students and their teachers were to be sent to the countryside to help transform the life of peasants** through programs such as:-
- ✓ literacy campaigns and
 - ✓ the implementation of the awaited land reform proclamation. However, the campaign was **opposed by most of the civilian left as a system that the Derg designed to remove its main opponents from the center.** **To appease the oppositions**, the Derg changed its slogan of "Ethiopia First" to "Ethiopian Socialism". It also adopted slogans like **Ethiopian Unity or Death**, **Revolutionary Motherland or Death**, and later **Every Thing to the War Front**, **Produce while Fighting or Fight While Producing** etc
- ☞ In 1975, banks and insurance companies were nationalized following a series of proclamations. Over seventy private commercial and industrial companies were then nationalized.
- ☞ Finally, **in March 1975 the Derg made a radical land reform proclamation.** The proclamation:-
- abolished all private land ownership and set the upper limit on family holdings at ten hectares.
 - **provided the establishment of peasant associations which were to be implemented with the cooperation of the zemach.**
- ☞ On 26 July 1975, another proclamation **nationalized all urban lands and extra houses.**
- ☞ In April 1976, **PMAC proclaimed National Democratic Revolution Program (NDRP) and set up the Provisional Office for Mass Organization and Affairs (POMOA)** with the objective of

organizing and raising the political consciousness of the masses. The campaigns showed *Derg's* **belief in mass mobilization** to achieve a cause. There were also other campaigns:-

- the “Green Campaign” of 1978 aimed at bringing about rapid economic development
 - the literacy campaign aimed at irradiating illiteracy, and
 - the “Red Star Campaign” of 1982 that aimed at solving the Eritrean problem.
- ✓ Of these campaigns, **only the literacy campaign registered some degree of success.**
- ✓ **The land reform proclamation did put an end to landlord exploitation** but it has failed to make the peasant master of his land because now the state took over as ultimate owner, with **the peasant associations** serving as its agents.
- ✓ The **cooperatives only led to monopolistic government enterprises** such as *Ersha Sebil Gebeya Dirijit* (Agricultural Marketing Corporation), resettlements and villagization. On the other hand, **nationalization killed private initiative and introduced a highly bureaucratized management of resources.** The state, with its significant role and growing proportion now gained tremendous capacity to reward or penalize. The *Derg* **used peasant associations to control the countryside and the urban dwellers' associations (*kebele*) to control the towns.** The *kebele* became battleground when the struggle between **the Derg and the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Party (EPRP)** (formed in Berlin in 1972) reached its bloodiest phase in 1976/7. The EPRP targeted **kebele leaders and assassinated them** while they in turn led the **government's campaign of terror** against the EPRP called **the “Red Terror”**, as opposed to the **“White Terror”** of the EPRP.
- ❖ Initially, **the leftist opposition to the *Derg* came from two rival Marxist-Leninist political organizations** called:-
- the EPRP and
 - the **All-Ethiopian Socialist Movement** (acronym in Amharic, *Meison*).
- ❖ In October 1976, **the Marxist Leninist Revolutionary Organization (MLRO)** was formed with its first Secretariat being Tesfaye Makonin. Later, it was merged to form **the Ethiopian Marxist Leninist Democratic Union (UMLO)** but was purged by the military junta in June 1979.
- ❖ **After the land reform proclamation, *Meison* ceased its opposition to the *Derg* by adopting what it called “critical support” and tactically formed an alliance with *Derg*** which helped it gain more organizational strength. In the meantime, the *Derg* **pushed by the dominant leftist political culture systematically abandoned “Ethiopian socialism” and embraced Marxism-Leninism.**
- ❖ With the setting up of the **Provisional Office for Mass Organization and Affairs (POMOA)**, *Derg* proclaimed **the National Democratic Revolution Program** which was **the Chinese model for socialist revolution** and had identified **feudalism, imperialism and bureaucratic capitalism** as the **three main enemies of the people.** In a few months, *Derg's* leftist political organization known as **Abyotawi Seded (Revolutionary Flame)** was launched.
- ❖ In 1977, an alliance called *Emaledesh* (the Union of Ethiopian Marxist–Leninist Organizations) was established **as prelude to the formation of one vanguard party.** The *Emaledesh* was composed of:-
- *Meison*
 - *Abyotawi Seded* (Revolutionary Flame)
 - *Wezlig* (Workers League) founded by a onetime president of the Ethiopian Students' Union in North America, Dr. Senay
 - *Malerid* (the Ethiopian Marxist–Leninist organization) and
 - *Ech'at* (the Ethiopian Oppressed Masses Revolutionary Struggle) founded by **Baro Tumsa.**

- ☞ That said, the *Emaledeh* was beset by power struggle from the outset as each organization competed for supremacy instead of working together to realize the original objective of the organization. Meanwhile, the struggle between the EPRP and the Derg and its allies had created a civil war scenario since September 1976 when EPRP militants were arrested and executed by the Derg and supporters of the *Derg* were assassinated by EPRP squads. EPRP had also attempted to assassinate Mengistu himself in mid-September. In what followed, the *Derg* attacked EPRP with large-scale arrests of its members and sympathizers and massive search and destroy campaigns, particularly in Addis Ababa.
- ❖ In late 1976, the *Derg* itself was ideologically divided and with the internal struggles. In consequence:-
- Mengistu had eliminated two powerful members of the *Derg* and potential rivals of his power and influence, Major Sisay Habte and Major Kiros Alemayehu.
 - Many other key members of the *Derg* were accused of being EPRP members or sympathizers. On their parts, other members such as Lieutenant Alemayehu Hayle and Captain Moges Wolde-Mikael resented the growing dictatorial power of Mengistu and his alliance with Meison and other pro-Derg leftist organizations. With the help of the chairperson, Brigadier General Teferi Benti, they then successfully re-organized the structure of the *Derg* in such a way that Mengistu was marginalized.
 - On 3 February 1977, Mengistu hit back with a coup against Teferi. Eventually, Teferi and other anti-Mengistu Derg members were executed. After the coup, Mengistu Haile-Mariam:-
 - ✓ assumed the chairmanship of the *Derg* and the post of commander-in-chief of the armed forces.
 - ✓ filled the top positions in the *Derg* with his loyal supporters. Within just a year, the only remaining outstanding *Derg* member, Lt. Colonel Atnafu Abate, was charged of impeding the revolutionary process was executed. Then Mengistu and his civilian left allies unleashed what they called the “Red Terror” initially targeting the EPRP and later including other opposition organizations, including EPLF and the Tigray People’s Liberation Front (TPLF) and Meison after its break up from the Derg. EPRP had to take its only option of turning to rural guerrilla warfare as internal split within it hastened its collapse.
- ❖ In the meantime, the *Derg* faced another challenge. In the summer of 1977, the government of Somalia led by Siyad Barre waged a large-scale war against Ethiopia. The Somali National Army crossed the border into Ethiopia and carried out military operations in Degahbour, Kebridehar, Warder and Godey taking control of Jijiga and large scale pockets of western regions in the first two weeks of the war. Within a couple of months, the cities of Harar and Dire Dawa were endangered. Yet Somalia’s invasion did not last long. The government mobilized a force of about 100,000 peasant militia and other forces that were trained at Angetu, Didessa, Hurso, Tateq and Tolay in a short time with the help of USSR advisors and equipment. Finally, with 17,000 Cuban troops and the help from Southern Yemen Democratic Republic the Somali National Army was defeated at Kara-Mara near Jigjiga on March 4, 1978. The aggression of the State of Somalia had been checked. The defeat led to the weakening of Siyad Barre’s government and contributed to its fall. At the same time, the aggression of the State of Somalia made it possible for the *Derg* to rally the population to its side.
- ❖ In early 1977, the *Derg* had severed relations with the USA as the American cultural and military institutions ended their operation in the country. This was preceded by the termination of the Ethio-USA 1953 mutual defense agreement. After a month, Mengistu

concluded agreements with Moscow for economic, cultural and military co-operation. The relations between Ethiopia and the Soviet remained strong until the end of the military regime.

- ❖ In the north, Eritrean insurgents had encircled Asmara while a pro-monarchy organization, the Ethiopian Democratic Union (EDU), was marching inroads from the Sudan in the Satit-Humera region. Yet,
 - by the end of 1978, the EPRP had been contained in the towns. And the Eritrean insurgents had been pushed back.
 - EDU was crushed near the Ethio-Sudan borderland in places like Metema, Abder Raffi and Satit-Humera.
 - The Union of Ethiopian Marxist-Leninist Organizations fell apart once Meison defected the Derg and its leaders were consequently either killed or arrested as they tried to retreat to the countryside. The other three member organizations *Ech'at*, *Wezlig*, and *Malerid* were successively expelled from *Emaledah* and their leaders and members executed or detained. It was only Mengistu's Seded that remained as the authentic Marxist-Leninist organization in the country.
- ☞ The strategy of merging political organizations for party formation was then replaced by recruitment of individuals loyal to Mengistu Haile-Mariam. In December 1979, the Commission for Organizing the Party of the Working People of Ethiopia (COPWE) was established with this motive. In September 1984, the Workers' Party of Ethiopia was inaugurated during the celebration of the tenth anniversary of the coming of the Derg to power. It was given that Mengistu became the new party's secretary-general.
- ❖ In order for the government to have a more direct societal control, there was the need for restructuring of mass organizations, which took place after the formation of the party. It started with workers who had challenged the Derg right from the start. i.e:-
 - on January 6 1977, the Confederation of Ethiopian Labour Union (CELU) was replaced by a government-controlled All Ethiopia Trade Union (AETU) which was later re-named Ethiopian Trade Union (ETU). This was followed by the formation of the All Ethiopia Peasants' Association (AEPA) which ensured the government's control over peasants. Later AETU was renamed Ethiopia Peasants' Association (EPA).
 - The Derg, Established in 1980, the Revolutionary Ethiopian Women's Association (REWA) and Revolutionary Ethiopian Youth Association (REYA) played similar role, rallying women and the youth behind the state.
 - It was when Shengo (PMAC National Assembly) proclaimed the People's Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (PDRE) in 1987 that such elaborate organizational set-up designed to ensure total control of society reached its peak.
- ☞ With the birth of the PDRE, the Derg officially ceased to exist. A typically Communist constitution already on its way, Colonel Mengistu had become:-
 - President of PDRE,
 - secretary general of WPE and
 - Commander in chief of the national armed forces with Fisseha Desta as Vice President while Fiqre-Sellassie Wegderes headed the Council of Ministers as Prime Minister with five deputies. Finally it turned out that Mengistu could not stay in power more than four years after he was proclaimed president of PDRE.
- ☞ The dictator, who had maneuvered the urban left and had gone ruthless in the process, fell under the attack of rural-based guerrilla movements. Rural-based movements fighting for national

self-determination thrived as liquidation of the **urban-based multi-national movements** like the **EPRP and Meison intensified in the center**. These included:-

- the **Oromo Liberation Front (OLF)**, active mainly in the **Wallagga region**,
 - the **Islamic Front for Liberation of Oromia**, based in **Hararghe**,
 - the Afar Liberation Front,
 - the Sidama Liberation Front,
 - the Beni Shangul Liberation Front and
 - the Gambella Liberation Front.
- Some of these fronts appeared only in the last days of the Derg.
- The two significant liberation fronts which could be considered to have jointly brought about the downfall of the Derg were **the EPLF and the TPLF**.

❖ In 1984/5, a more **devastating famine** than the one in 1973/4 indicated the failure of the **Derg's economic policies** especially in agricultural production and marketing. **In the late twentieth century, Ethiopia had experienced two major famines** that had rose up national and international mobilization and **created bad image on the country in international scene**. These were:-

- the 1972-4 and
- the 1984-5 famines

☞ These famines caused by a variety of interrelated factors which include:-

- environmental crises (notably drought) and
- economic, social causes as well as political factors.

☞ The state responded to the economic, social and political factors by **resettling the affected people in less affected areas of western Ethiopia**. The government responded to the famine by ignoring the problem for some time and then only to introduce its **controversial policy of massive resettlement of the affected peasants**, mostly of **Tigray and Wollo provinces, in south-western Ethiopia**. **The villagization program** that followed the resettlement further alienated the majority of peasants. It was in this context that **the guerrilla forces scored remarkable victories against the regime forces** towards the end of the decade. **International politics too did not carry on serving Mengistu's interest as his ally, the Soviet Union ceased to be the source of his external support**. i.e:-

- Mikhail Gorbachev's policy of **perestroika (restructuring)** and **glasnost, (openness)** in 1985 aimed at making **Soviet communism more efficient and humane** was a failure and **the Soviet Union collapsed as a major world power**.
- Even worse, **the United States who the Derg had never been friendly with** became the **sole arbiter of international affairs**. Although **Mengistu now tried to improve relations with the Americans**, they were **more directed towards to his opponents, the EPLF and the TPLF**, who they believed had fully **abandoned Marxism Leninism**. In March 1990, the **Derg proclaimed a mixed economy policy** which seemed to come **just late**.

❖ The government's military failure came **after defeating the invading force of Somalia**; the **Derg** turned its forces to the north, with the rather too **assured slogan** that **"the victory scored in the east will be repeated in the north."** Initially the plan seemed to go well when the EPLF forces pulled back under the massive assault launched by the Derg, which regained control over the rebel's **major strongholds in 1976/7**. However, the retreated EPLF forces **were not driven out of their fortress at Naqfa** in northern Eritrea.

- In **March 1988**, EPLF scored a major victory at **Afabet**, north of Asmara, from its stronghold in **Naqfa-Raza**. When in 1990, EPLF forces **captured the port town of Massawa**, it became only a matter of time before the capital, Asmara, also fell to them.

- The **final decisive blow to Mengistu's regime** came to be administered by **the TPLF** that aimed to secure **the self-determination of Tigray within the Ethiopian polity**. The TPLF, at its inception, was grounded on the **cumulative grievances of Tigray people against the successive regimes of Ethiopia**. To address the problems, **Tigrayan students created the Political Association of Tigrayans (PAT) and the Tigrayan University Students' Association (TUSA) in the early 1970s. PAT developed into a radical nationalist group calling for the independence of Tigray, establishing the **Tigray Liberation Front (TLF) in 1974**. In TUSA, there emerged a Marxist leaning group favouring national self-determination for Tigray within a revolutionary transformed democratic Ethiopia. Whereas **the multinational left movements such as the EPRP and MEISON advanced the view that the problem of Ethiopian nationalities could be resolved through class struggle**, the **Marxists of TUSA** argued that due to the existing inequalities among Ethiopian nationalities, revolutionaries must use the struggle of Ethiopian nationalities for selfdetermination as the launching pad for the ultimate socialist revolution.**
- ❖ In February 1974, **the Marxists within TUSA welcomed the Ethiopian Revolution**, but **opposed the Derg** as they were convinced that it would neither lead a genuine socialist revolution nor correctly resolve the Ethiopian nationality question. Three days after the *Derg* took power, on 14 September 1974 the Mahber Gesgesti Bihere Tigray (Association of Progressives of the Tigray Nation), also known as **Tigrayan National Organization (TNO)** was established. TNO was to prepare the ground for the future armed movement of Tigray.
- ❖ **The TPLF started in February 1975 as a small guerrilla band** in the northern region of Ethiopia and eventually grew to provide the core of the Ethiopian government. Before it turned to confront the Derg, **the TPLF was engaged in a bloody struggle with:-**
 - **EPRA (the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Army, the armed wing of the EPRP)**
 - **EDU**
 - **TLF**
 - **ELF**
- ❖ The **Derg initially thought that TPLF was a mere creation of the EPLF to be vanished once EPLF was crushed** and thus **underestimated its potentials**. This made it possible for TPLF to strengthen its forces and when the Derg opened offensives against it in the early 1980s, TPLF, which had built strong army was able to successfully fight back.
- ❖ In February 1989, **TPLF scored its most decisive victory at Enda-Selassie, Western Tigray**, after a series of other military successes. At the victory of Enda-Selassie, **tens of thousands of government troops were captured and their commanders were either killed or captured**. This resulted in the withdrawal of all government troops from Tigray. **TPLF then took control of the whole of Tigray and then started marching into the neighboring provinces**. Meanwhile, the prevalent accumulated dissatisfaction with Mengistu's regime and the exhausting war in the north had been high especially in the higher echelons of the army.
- ❖ In May 1989, commanders of almost all military units, coordinated and led a coup against Mengistu when he left the country on a state visit to the German Democratic Republic, East Germany. However, **the coup was poorly organized that loyal palace troops encircled the leaders before they could even announce their intentions to the public**. Mengistu returned triumphantly to take his revenge which he did. **The coup leaders were all imprisoned or executed**.
- ❖ TPLF, which **after liberating Tigray, continued to move forward and made the necessary organizational adjustments forming a bigger front** known as the **Ethiopian Peoples' Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF)**. The member organizations were:-

- TPLF
 - the Ethiopian People's Democratic Movement (EPDM),
 - a fragment group of the EPRP which had begun to play a significant role in many of the military campaigns,
 - the Oromo People's Democratic Organization (OPDO) and
 - the Ethiopian Democratic Officers' Revolutionary Movement (EDORM).
 - Other Liberation Fronts including:-
 - ✓ the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF)
 - ✓ Afar Liberation Front
 - ✓ Sidama Liberation Front
 - ✓ Gambella Liberation Front and
 - ✓ Beni Shangul Liberation Front
- } also became active
- ❖ In 1990 and 1991 in consecutive and stunning campaigns, **EPRDF forces drove the *Derg* out of:-**
 - Gondar
 - Gojjam, and Wollo and
 - parts of Wallagga and Shewa and **approached the capital from the north and west.**
 - In 1990 Oromo forces **dismantled** the Derg army of the **131st Brigade** in battle that **liberated Asosa and Bambasi** in the then **Wollega province.**
 - ❖ In the meantime, **negotiations for a peaceful end to the conflict were underway between the government and the EPLF and the TPLF in Atlanta, Nairobi, and Rome.** In May 1991, while **the last of these negotiations were going on in London**, series of events put an end to the regime. *i.e:-*
 - On May 21, **Mengistu fled the country** first to Nairobi and then to Harare (Zimbabwe). There remained no resistance left that the *Derg* troops could put. **In London**, the **government delegation could not bargain anymore** after the flight of the president.
 - **EPLF forces entered Asmara and Assab and announced the de facto independence of Eritrea.** The PDRE Vice President, **Lt . General Tesfaye Gebre-Kidan** appealed for an end to the civil war on **May 23 1991.**
 - Prime Minister **Tesfaye Dinga** left for the London peace conference mediated by **the U.S.A's Foreign Affair African Service head Mr. Herman Cohen** on **May 27 1991.**
 - In the early hours of May 28 1991, **EPRDF forces triumphantly entered Addis Ababa.**

7.3. Transitional Government

- ❖ On 1 July 1991, a handful of organizations of which some were organized along **ethnic lines assembled to review the draft Charter** prepared by:-
 - the EPRDF and
 - the OLF
- ✓ **The gathering was called the Peace and Democracy Transitional Conference of Ethiopia.** The **USA** was at **the forefront in providing the necessary diplomatic backing for the Peace and Democracy Conference**. The Conference was attended by delegates from:-

• The UN	• The G7
• The OAU	• The US
• The USSR	• Sudan
• Kenya	• Djibouti
• Eritrea	
- ✚ Eritrea was represented by its future president, **Isayas Afeworki.**
- ✓ **The Conference debated and approved the Transitional Charter** on the basis of which the **Transitional Government of Ethiopia was created.**

- ✚ Representatives of 27 organizations formed a Council of Representatives (COR) which acted as a legislative body ('Parliament'). **This transitional parliament** had 87 seats of which 32 were taken by the EPRDF and the remaining 55 seats were divided among the 23 non-EPRDF organizations.
- ✚ At the same time, a Council of Ministers was formed as an **executive branch**, with **Meles Zenawi** as the **President** of the Transitional Government of Ethiopia (TGE). Meles Zenawi then appointed a **Prime Minister (Tamirat Layne)** and a seventeen-member Council of Ministers. Key posts were given to members of the EPRDF and OLF.
- ❖ In December 1994, the constitution of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE) was **ratified**, taking effect following federal elections in mid-1995. The constitution stipulates that the country would have **nine federated states** based on identity and settlement patterns. The federal arrangement sought to **decentralize power to the regional states** by accommodating the country's **various ethno-linguistic groups**. After the election, **Meles Zenawi** assumed the **premiership** while **Dr. Negasso Gidada** became **head of state**.
- ❖ Meanwhile, **EPLF** set up a **Provisional Government of Eritrea** in 1991. This was followed by a referendum to decide the fate of Eritrea in which the majority of the population voted for independence from Ethiopia. In May 1993, the Government of Eritrea was formed with **Isayas Afwerki** becoming the **first elected president** of the country after independence.